

Self-pinned distances

through unforced scale selection

30 September 2026

This manuscript refines the Hausdorff–packing sufficient condition by separating standard spatial wave packets from the auxiliary angular partitions in the Fourier estimate. The angular marks remain constant on each standard packet label; only the spectral calculation is subdivided more finely. This removes the prescribed midpoint from the scale-selection problem.

The latest refinement normalizes the profile endpoint and represents its optimal chain cost through the gaps between hard components. Two exact nonnegative-weight certificates give matching upper and lower profile bounds. They yield an explicit, stronger dimension curve beginning at $(7 - \sqrt{7})/4 = 1.088562172\dots$

The manuscript also proves a stronger regularity conclusion under the same curve: selected separated source and pin probabilities have a raw joint distance density in some L^p , $p > 1$. It also proves an optimal averaged deletion order in a finite geometric model and gives two precise criteria using source–pin geometry. These results do not lower the dimension curve. A separate comparison shows why the tested local weighted-decoupling alternative leaves the profile optimum unchanged.

Scope. The manuscript gives the complete mathematical argument using the explicitly cited established analytic inputs, including both analytic branches and the Borel-set reduction. Internal mathematical audits are not external refereeing. The finite weighted algebra is now verified in Lean; the profile geometry and analytic transfer are not yet formalized.

Optimality. The weakest possible condition on the two dimensions is not established. The new curve is optimal for the precisely specified criterion based on the limiting universal chain cost, combined with the coherent criterion. Its extremizing profiles are not planar distance-set counterexamples. No unrestricted improvement below five quarters is claimed.

The existing Lean challenge and comparator are unchanged. This mathematical manuscript does not complete the unconditional formalization.

Contents

1	Statement and scope	2
2	Coherent positive linearizations and a conditional convergence theorem	5
3	The finite-profile branch	10
4	Refinement using the actual minima	23
5	Endpoint normalization and adaptive intervals	31
6	Sharp profile bounds from hard-component gaps	35
7	Algebra and proof of the dimension criterion	44
8	Subquadratic integrability from the profile decomposition	46
9	Positive selection: a valid target and a finite-model gain	52
10	A fixed positive angular selection and near-source collisions	58
11	What the sharpness statement does and does not establish	62
12	What optimizing the finite start can achieve	64
13	A local refined-decoupling terminal step	65
14	Realizing the sharp profiles in one measure	72
15	Plan for formal verification	80
16	A weighted embedding for one Fourier step	81

1 Statement and scope

For a Borel set $E \subset \mathbb{R}^2$, write $d = \dim_H E$, $D = \dim_P E$, and $\Delta_y(E) = \{|x - y| : x \in E\}$. All distances are Euclidean and $|\cdot|$ denotes one-dimensional Lebesgue measure. The strongest sufficient curve proved in this manuscript is

$$B_H(d) = \begin{cases} 2d - 1, & 1 < d \leq d_\alpha, \\ 1 + r_2(d - 1), & d_\alpha < d \leq d_c, \\ \frac{1}{3 - 2d}, & d_c < d \leq \frac{5}{4}, \end{cases} \quad (1)$$

where

$$d_\alpha = \frac{7 - \sqrt{7}}{4} = 1.088562172\dots, \quad d_c = \frac{2 + \sqrt{6}}{4} = 1.112372436\dots,$$

and, for $\alpha = (3 - \sqrt{7})/4 \leq a \leq a_c = (\sqrt{6} - 2)/4$,

$$r_2(a) = \frac{2 - a + 8a^2 - \sqrt{4 - 28a - 63a^2 + 32a^3 + 64a^4}}{4(1 + 4a - 2a^2)}. \quad (2)$$

The square root is real on this interval, and the branches agree at both joins, as proved in Section 6.10.

Theorem 1.1 (Explicit improved packing condition). *Let $E \subset \mathbb{R}^2$ be Borel. If $1 < d = \dim_H E \leq 5/4$ and $\dim_P E < B_H(d)$, then $|\Delta_y(E)| > 0$ for some $y \in E$.*

For orientation, $B_H(11/10) = 28/23$ and $B_H(23/20) = 10/7$. The conclusion now covers, for example, $d = 1.09$, $D = 1.181$ and $d = 1.15$, $D = 1.40$.

The earlier adaptive bound is retained for comparison:

$$B_A(d) = \begin{cases} 2d - 1, & 1 < d \leq \frac{11}{10}, \\ 1 + \beta(d - 1), & \frac{11}{10} < d < \frac{7}{6}, \\ \frac{1}{3 - 2d}, & \frac{7}{6} \leq d \leq \frac{5}{4}. \end{cases} \quad (3)$$

Here $\beta(a)$ is the unique solution in $[2a, 1/2]$ of $C_A(a, b) = a$. The function C_A is the minimum, over one parameter in $[0, 1]$, of the explicit rational expression (56). Lemma 5.2 proves uniqueness, continuity and the endpoint values $\beta(1/10) = 1/5$, $\beta(1/6) = 1/2$. No numerical optimization hypothesis is used.

Theorem 1.2 (Adaptive sufficient packing condition). *Let $E \subset \mathbb{R}^2$ be Borel. If $1 < d = \dim_H E \leq 5/4$ and $\dim_P E < B_A(d)$, then $|\Delta_y(E)| > 0$ for some $y \in E$.*

The preceding actual-minimum refinement is retained for comparison:

$$B_M(d) = \begin{cases} 2d - 1, & 1 < d \leq \frac{9}{8}, \\ 1 + b_*(d - 1), & \frac{9}{8} < d < \frac{7}{6}, \\ \frac{1}{3 - 2d}, & \frac{7}{6} \leq d \leq \frac{5}{4}. \end{cases} \quad (4)$$

Here $b_*(a)$ is the unique solution in $[2a, 1/2]$ of $V(a, b) = a$, for the explicit rational minimum–maximum expression (40) below. The proof establishes uniqueness, continuity, and the endpoint values $b_*(1/8) = 1/4$, $b_*(1/6) = 1/2$; thus this definition requires no numerical or optimization hypothesis.

Theorem 1.3 (Refined sufficient packing condition). *Let $E \subset \mathbb{R}^2$ be Borel. If $1 < d = \dim_H E \leq 5/4$ and $\dim_P E < B_M(d)$, then $|\Delta_y(E)| > 0$ for some $y \in E$.*

The preceding, simpler sufficient curve remains useful for comparison:

$$B_U(d) = \begin{cases} 2d - 1, & 1 < d \leq \frac{8}{7}, \\ \frac{2 + 2d - 3d^2}{6 - 5d}, & \frac{8}{7} < d \leq \frac{7}{6}, \\ \frac{1}{3 - 2d}, & \frac{7}{6} < d \leq \frac{5}{4}. \end{cases} \quad (5)$$

Theorem 1.4 (Simpler sufficient packing condition). *Let $E \subset \mathbb{R}^2$ be Borel. If $1 < d = \dim_H E \leq 5/4$ and*

$$\dim_P E < B_U(d),$$

then $|\Delta_y(E)| > 0$ for some $y \in E$.

The proof constructs separated compact source and pin subsets of E . A source probability has absolutely continuous pinned distance measures for almost every pin under the selected pin probability. Distance images of Borel sets are analytic, hence Lebesgue measurable.

For example,

$$d = \frac{31}{25} = 1.24 \implies D < \frac{25}{13} = 1.923076923 \dots \text{ is sufficient.}$$

At $d = 5/4$, the condition is $D < 2$; the equality case $D = 2$ is not included. For $d > 5/4$, GIOW already gives the conclusion with no packing restriction [3]. The endpoints of all branches in (5) agree, and the packing inequality is strict throughout.

At $d = 109/100 = 1.09$, $D = 1181/1000 = 1.181$, the exact new profile cost is $4619/51529$, with margin $1861/5152900$. At $d = 23/20 = 1.15$, $D = 7/5 = 1.40$, its value is $5/36$, with margin $1/90$. The graph illustrates the exact formulas; it is not used to prove these inequalities.

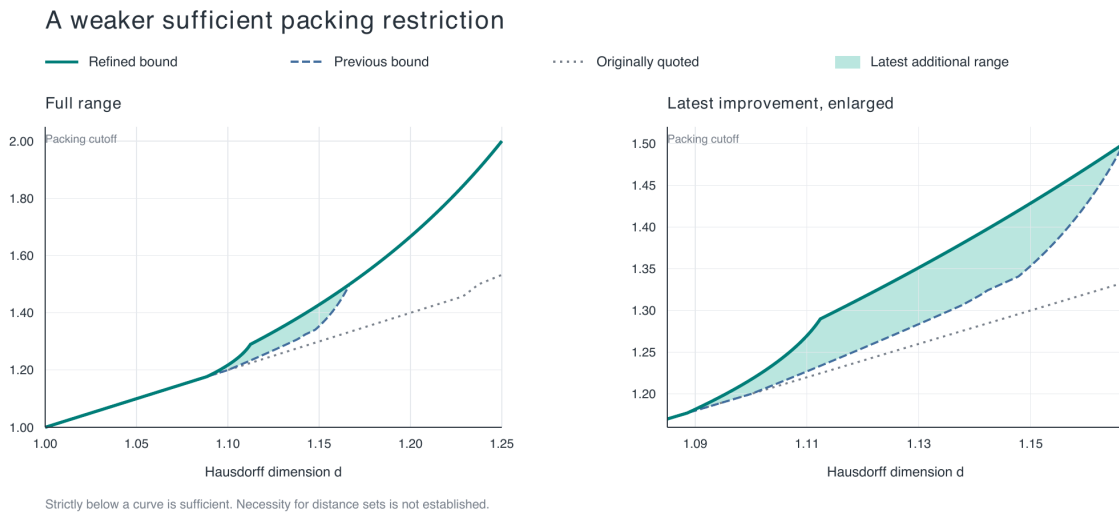


Figure 1: The refined sufficient curve, the preceding unforced curve, and the originally quoted curve. The second panel isolates the latest improvement. Values strictly below a curve are covered. No curve is asserted to be necessary.

1.1 Definitions and established inputs

A probability μ is s -Frostman if $\mu(B(x, r)) \leq Cr^s$ for $0 < r \leq 1$. Write

$$I_a(\mu) = \iint |x - x'|^{-a} d\mu(x) d\mu(x').$$

An s -Frostman probability of bounded support has finite a -energy whenever $0 < a < s$, by summing spatial annuli. The external inputs are as follows.

1. Frostman's lemma for Borel subsets of Euclidean space, and the countable bounded-cover characterization of packing dimension using upper box dimension. Closures preserve bounded upper box dimension; positive-mass compact restrictions are available by inner regularity.
2. Orponen's averaged radial-projection integrability [1], in the form of GIOW Theorem 3.7 or Keleti–Shmerkin Theorem 3.11. For separated compact Frostman probabilities of exponents greater than one, radial projections have L^q densities for some $q > 1$, with integrable q -th powers of their norms.
3. Plancherel, the Riesz energy identity, polar coordinates and their projection consequences, with Fourier normalization $\widehat{f}(\xi) = \int e^{-2\pi i x \cdot \xi} f(x) dx$.
4. Keleti–Shmerkin Lemma 3.4 and Corollary 3.5 [2], used only for finite terminal-cube restrictions, not to extract an infinite regular subset. Their Lemma 5.4 identifies the optimal total drop for piecewise affine profiles from their hard components; the coordinate reversal and endpoint correction used here are derived explicitly below.
5. The elementary packet localization of GIOW Section 3 [3], Liu's cap reconstruction (Lemma 4.2 of [6]), and the pinned quadratic identity [5]. The variable-chain inflation multiplier is derived below.

All constants may depend on the fixed compact supports, positive source-pin separation and chosen auxiliary parameters. They are uniform in frequency, regularized component, cube and cap. The notation $\text{RapDec}(R)$ means a quantity bounded by $C_M R^{-M}$ for every fixed $M > 0$, uniformly in those indices. Summing polynomially many such errors preserves this property.

2 Coherent positive linearizations and a conditional convergence theorem

This section proves the original branch of the bound, rather than assuming Proposition E.6 from the longer report. It uses positive affine approximations to distance and a summable first-norm comparison.

2.1 Angular regularity with a single exceptional set

Lemma 2.1 (Coupled-angle projection comparison). *Let $0 < \gamma < 1/2$, and let λ be a probability supported in $B(0, Cr)$, $0 < r \leq 1$, with $I_{1+2\gamma}(\lambda) < \infty$. For almost every $\theta \in S^1$, let $F(\theta) \in L^2(\mathbb{R})$ be the density of $(\pi_\theta)_*\lambda$, where $\pi_\theta(x) = x \cdot \theta$. There is a nonnegative function G with*

$$\|G\|_{L^2(S^1)}^2 \leq C_\gamma r^{2\gamma} I_{1+2\gamma}(\lambda)$$

such that, outside one angular null set, every pair satisfies

$$\|F(\theta) - F(\phi)\|_{L^2(\mathbb{R})} \leq C_\gamma d(\theta, \phi)^\gamma (G(\theta) + G(\phi)),$$

where d is circular arclength distance. In addition,

$$\int_{S^1} \sup_{|v| \leq Cr^2} \|F(\theta)(\cdot - v) - F(\theta)\|_2^2 d\theta \leq C_\gamma r^{4\gamma} I_{1+2\gamma}(\lambda).$$

Proof. We first prove the Hilbert-valued angular Sobolev estimate

$$\|F\|_{H^\gamma(S^1; L^2(\mathbb{R}))}^2 \leq C_\gamma r^{2\gamma} I_{1+2\gamma}(\lambda). \quad (6)$$

The projection-energy identity gives the projected densities and their joint second integrability, since finite $(1+2\gamma)$ -energy implies finite first energy on the bounded support. Fourier transform in the scalar projection variable. The transformed function is

$$f_\tau(\theta) = \widehat{\lambda}(\tau\theta).$$

Its angular derivative is a linear combination, with bounded angular coefficients, of $\widehat{\tau x_k \lambda}(\tau\theta)$, $k = 1, 2$. The Riesz energy identity for these signed measures gives

$$\int_{\mathbb{R}^2} |\widehat{x_k \lambda}(\xi)|^2 |\xi|^{2\gamma-1} d\xi \leq C_\gamma r^2 I_{1+2\gamma}(\lambda).$$

Indeed the spatial double integral has the factor $x_k x'_k$, whose absolute value is at most Cr^2 . Its absolute energy is finite, so approximation justifies the signed Fourier identity.

Angular Sobolev interpolation, or directly Holder on angular Fourier coefficients, gives

$$\|f_\tau\|_{H^\gamma}^2 \leq \|f_\tau\|_2^{2(1-\gamma)} \|f_\tau\|_{H^1}^{2\gamma}.$$

On $|\tau| \geq 1/r$, introduce the canceling weights

$$A_\tau = |\tau|^{2\gamma} \|f_\tau\|_2^2, \quad B_\tau = |\tau|^{-2(1-\gamma)} \|f_\tau\|_{H^1}^2.$$

Polar coordinates and the preceding signed-energy estimate show

$$\int_{|\tau| \geq 1/r} A_\tau d\tau \leq C_\gamma I_{1+2\gamma}(\lambda), \quad \int_{|\tau| \geq 1/r} B_\tau d\tau \leq C_\gamma r^2 I_{1+2\gamma}(\lambda).$$

For the undifferentiated part of B_τ , use $|\tau|^{-2} \leq r^2$; its derivative part has exactly the energy weight after the factor τ^2 is inserted. Holder in τ now bounds the integral of $\|f_\tau\|_{H^\gamma}^2$ by $C_\gamma r^{2\gamma} I_{1+2\gamma}(\lambda)$ on this region. When $|\tau| \leq 1/r$, both f_τ and its angular derivative are bounded uniformly, so the contribution is at most C/r . This is absorbed because

$$I_{1+2\gamma}(\lambda) \geq (Cr)^{-1-2\gamma}.$$

Plancherel in the scalar variable proves (6).

Choose a measurable Hilbert-valued representative and define

$$G(\theta)^2 = \int_{S^1} \frac{\|F(\theta) - F(z)\|_2^2}{d(\theta, z)^{1+2\gamma}} dz.$$

The angular Slobodeckij identity gives $\|G\|_2^2 \leq C_\gamma \|F\|_{H^\gamma}^2$. For completeness, expand in angular Fourier coefficients: translation invariance makes each nonzero coefficient contribute its squared Hilbert norm times

$$\int_{-\pi}^{\pi} \frac{|e^{ikh} - 1|^2}{|h|^{1+2\gamma}} dh \asymp_\gamma |k|^{2\gamma}.$$

Tonelli and Parseval prove the assertion also for Hilbert-valued functions.

Remove the null set where G is infinite, where F is undefined, or where it does not represent the projected density. Given two remaining angles at distance $\delta > 0$, take an arc J of length comparable to δ containing both, with every point of J within $C\delta$ of each endpoint. Average the triangle inequality through $z \in J$. Cauchy–Schwarz gives

$$\begin{aligned} \|F(\theta) - F(\phi)\|_2 &\leq |J|^{-1/2} \left[\left(\int_J \|F(\theta) - F(z)\|_2^2 dz \right)^{1/2} + \left(\int_J \|F(\phi) - F(z)\|_2^2 dz \right)^{1/2} \right] \\ &\leq C_\gamma \delta^\gamma (G(\theta) + G(\phi)). \end{aligned}$$

For large δ , the whole circle serves as J ; the diagonal case is immediate. This proves a single-null-set, all-pairs estimate, which can be evaluated on correlated angular laws.

Finally Plancherel bounds the translation expression, before angular integration, by

$$Cr^{4\gamma} \int_{\mathbb{R}} |\tau|^{2\gamma} |\widehat{\lambda}(\tau\theta)|^2 d\tau.$$

Here the supremum over $|v| \leq Cr^2$ was bounded inside the Fourier integral, using $|e^{-2\pi i\tau v} - 1|^2 \leq C_\gamma |\tau v|^{2\gamma}$. Polar coordinates give the required translation bound. $\square$

2.2 Consecutive positive linearizations

Let μ, ν be compact probabilities with positively separated supports, satisfying Frostman bounds with exponents $s, t > 1$. Choose

$$0 < \gamma < \min\left(\frac{1}{2}, \frac{s-1}{2}\right).$$

For a positive-mass dyadic source square Q , write $p_Q = \mu(Q)$, $\mu_Q = p_Q^{-1}\mu|_Q$. Orponen's theorem, in the GIOW Theorem 3.7 form stated in the preliminaries [1, 3], supplies $q > 1$ and

$$(\Theta_x)_* \nu = \rho_x d\sigma, \quad \Theta_x(y) = \frac{x-y}{|x-y|}, \quad B = \int \|\rho_x\|_q^q d\mu(x) < \infty,$$

where σ is normalized arclength. The hypotheses follow by choosing a common Frostman exponent between one and $\min(s, t)$. In every node choose $x_Q \in Q \cap \text{supp } \mu$ at which the density exists and

$$F_Q := \|\rho_{x_Q}\|_q^q \leq \frac{2}{p_Q} \int_Q \|\rho_x\|_q^q d\mu(x).$$

There are countably many nodes, and these choices give

$$\sum_{Q \text{ at level } n} p_Q F_Q \leq 2B \quad \text{at every level.}$$

Define the affine approximation

$$L_Q(x, y) = \Theta_{x_Q}(y) \cdot (x - y).$$

At level n , push the original positive pair probability by $(x, y) \mapsto (y, L_{Q_n(x)}(x, y))$. It has a nonnegative density f_n relative to $\nu(dy)dt$. To see this, each μ_Q has finite first energy and therefore second-integrable projected densities for almost every angle. Its chosen center's angular pin law is absolutely continuous, so the assertion holds for almost every pin, simultaneously at all countably many nodes. The conditional densities can be chosen jointly measurably. Each f_n has mass one, and Taylor's theorem gives

$$|L_{Q_n(x)}(x, y) - |x - y|| \leq C2^{-2n}$$

uniformly, once the squares are smaller than the fixed separation.

Proposition 2.2 (Coherent first-norm comparison). *For $r = 2^{-n}$ sufficiently small and every $A \geq 1$,*

$$\|f_{n+1} - f_n\|_{L^1(\nu \times dt)} \leq C \left[Ar^{1+4\gamma} \sum_{Q \text{ at level } n+1} p_Q I_{1+2\gamma}(\mu_Q) \right]^{1/2} + CBA^{1-q}. \quad (7)$$

Constants depend on the fixed support geometry and separation, the exponents and Frostman bounds, but not on n, A .

Proof. Let Q be a child of P , and apply both affine maps to the same conditional source μ_Q . Set $b = x_Q$, and recenter this source at b . Put $\theta = \Theta_{x_P}(y)$, $\phi = \Theta_b(y)$. Their separation is $O(r)$, and

$$L_P(x, y) = \theta \cdot (x - b) + \theta \cdot (b - y), \quad L_Q(x, y) = \phi \cdot (x - b) + |b - y|.$$

The constants differ quadratically:

$$|\theta \cdot (b - y) - |b - y|| = |b - y| |\theta \cdot \phi - 1| \leq Cr^2.$$

Recentring is essential here; estimating the uncentered translations separately would lose a first-order term.

Keep those pins for which both angular densities at θ and ϕ are at most A . The resulting joint angular law has both marginals bounded by $A\sigma$, while its deleted pin mass is at most

$$A^{1-q}(F_P + F_Q).$$

No independence of the angles or of angular and radial pin coordinates is used. Apply Lemma 2.1 to the translated conditional source. Its pointwise all-pairs bound is valid on the coupled angles, since both marginals avoid the single exceptional null set. Integrating the square and using the marginal bounds gives $CAr^{4\gamma} I_{1+2\gamma}(\mu_Q)$. The pin-dependent scalar translation has size

at most Cr^2 ; the lemma's translation estimate, with the relevant bounded angular marginal, gives the same bound. By the triangle inequality, the integrated squared second-norm difference of the two conditional affine densities is therefore at most

$$CAr^{4\gamma}I_{1+2\gamma}(\mu_Q).$$

For each pin both densities lie in a common interval of length Cr . Cauchy–Schwarz converts their second norm to their first norm with factor $Cr^{1/2}$. On deleted pins the first-norm difference of two probability densities is at most two. Decompose each parent conditional source into its children, sum with weights p_Q , and use Cauchy–Schwarz over those weights and retained pins. The good terms give the square root in (7). The bad terms sum to at most CBA^{1-q} , because

$$\sum_Q p_Q F_Q \leq 2B, \quad \sum_{Q \text{ at level } n+1} p_Q F_{\text{parent}(Q)} = \sum_{P \text{ at level } n} p_P F_P \leq 2B.$$

This proves the estimate. $\square$

2.3 The convergence criterion and its scope

Theorem 2.3 (Conditional-energy criterion). *Under the preceding assumptions, set*

$$Z_n = 2^{-n(1+4\gamma)} \sum_{Q \text{ at level } n+1} p_Q I_{1+2\gamma}(\mu_Q), \quad \eta_q = \frac{q-1}{2q-1}.$$

If $\sum_n Z_n^{\eta_q} < \infty$, then $(d_y)_ \mu$ is absolutely continuous for ν -almost every y .*

Proof. Enlarge B to at least one and omit finitely many scales so $Z_n \leq 1$. In Proposition 2.2 choose

$$A_n = (B/\sqrt{Z_n})^{1/(q-1/2)} \geq 1.$$

Both terms are bounded by $CB^{1/(2q-1)}Z_n^{\eta_q}$. Thus f_n is Cauchy in $L^1(\nu \times dt)$. Its nonnegative limit has mass one. Uniform approximation of the affine maps to distance identifies its weak measure limit with the pushforward of $\mu \times \nu$ by $(x, y) \mapsto (y, |x-y|)$. Uniqueness of disintegration then shows that, for almost every pin, the actual pinned law has the resulting density. In particular the conclusion is about the raw positive distance laws, not signed approximations. $\square$

2.4 The covering and Borel consequences

Proposition 2.4 (A covering-number sufficient condition). *Suppose additionally that the number of occupied source squares of side r is at most Cr^{-u} , uniformly for small dyadic r . If $u < 2s-1$, then the preceding criterion holds for a suitable γ . In particular an s -Ahlfors regular source, $s > 1$, satisfies this sufficient condition when the separated pin measure has a Frostman exponent greater than one.*

Proof. For $a < s$, integration of the source Frostman ball bound within a square of diameter $O(r)$ gives, for each x in that square,

$$\int_Q |x-x'|^{-a} d\mu(x') \leq Cr^{s-a}.$$

Integrate over $x \in Q$ and normalize twice. This proves

$$I_a(\mu_Q) \leq Cr^{s-a}/p_Q.$$

Taking $a = 1 + 2\gamma < s$ and summing over occupied child squares yields

$$\sum_Q p_Q I_{1+2\gamma}(\mu_Q) \leq C r^{s-1-2\gamma-u}, \quad Z_n \leq C r^{s-u+2\gamma}.$$

The strict assumption $u < 2s-1$ permits a choice $0 < \gamma < \min(1/2, (s-1)/2)$ with $s-u+2\gamma > 0$. The series then converges geometrically. An s -Ahlfors regular support has covering number $O(r^{-s})$, so one may take $u = s$. $\square$

For comparison, Keleti–Shmerkin [2, Theorem 1.2] obtain full Hausdorff dimension of pinned distance sets when the source packing dimension is at most twice its Hausdorff dimension minus one. The absolute-continuity assertion below is derived from the preceding positive-density comparison; the cited dimension theorem is not an absolute-continuity input.

Proposition 2.5 (Borel-set consequence). *Let $E, F \subset \mathbb{R}^2$ be Borel sets such that*

$$\dim_{\mathrm{H}} E > 1, \quad \dim_{\mathrm{P}} E < 2 \dim_{\mathrm{H}} E - 1, \quad \dim_{\mathrm{H}} F > 1.$$

Then $|\Delta_y(E)| > 0$ for some $y \in F$. More precisely, one can choose a compactly supported Frostman probability μ on a compact subset of E so that, for any prescribed compactly supported t -Frostman pin probability ν on F , $t > 1$, the law $(d_y)_\mu$ is absolutely continuous for ν -almost every pin. The source measure here is a selected restriction, not an assertion about an arbitrary original measure on E .*

Proof. Choose $1 < s < \dim_{\mathrm{H}} E$ and $u > \dim_{\mathrm{P}} E$ with $u < 2s - 1$. Frostman’s lemma gives an s -Frostman probability μ_0 compactly supported on E . Choose u_0 strictly between $\dim_{\mathrm{P}} E$ and u . The countable-cover characterization of packing dimension gives a cover by bounded sets of upper box dimension at most u_0 . Replacing these sets by their closures preserves upper box dimension and makes them compact. At least one member has positive μ_0 -mass. By inner regularity, choose a compact subset K of its intersection with E having positive μ_0 -mass. Set $\mu = \mu_0|_K / \mu_0(K)$. It is still s -Frostman, and its occupied-square count is $O(r^{-u})$, since $\dim_{\mathrm{B}} K \leq u_0 < u$.

It remains to remove the separation condition without changing this selected measure. Cover the complement of the diagonal in $\mathbb{R}^2 \times \mathbb{R}^2$ by countably many products of closed bounded rational balls $U \times V$ with positive separation. The interiors of such products already cover the complement. On each positive-mass product, normalize the restrictions of μ and the prescribed ν . These probabilities satisfy the Frostman and covering assumptions, have compact separated supports, and Proposition 2.4 applies. Their joint pinned-distance pushforward is absolutely continuous with respect to $\nu(dy)dt$.

The diagonal has $\mu \times \nu$ -mass zero because μ has no atoms. A set of zero $\nu \times dt$ -measure therefore has zero preimage mass on every member of the countable cover and hence under the full pair probability. Its full joint distance law is absolutely continuous. Disintegration proves the claimed almost-everywhere pinned assertion. Since these laws have mass one and are supported on $\Delta_y(K) \subset \Delta_y(E)$, their supports have positive length. Finally $\dim_{\mathrm{H}} F > 1$ supplies a compactly supported pin Frostman probability with exponent greater than one. $\square$

3 The finite-profile branch

For $1 < s \leq 5/4$ and $s \leq u \leq 2$, define

$$C(s, u) = U(s - 1, u - 1), \quad U(a, b) = \begin{cases} \frac{(b - a)(1 - a)}{2(2b - a)}, & a \leq b \leq 1/2, \\ \frac{b - a}{1 + 2b}, & 1/2 \leq b \leq 1. \end{cases} \quad (8)$$

The parameter a lies in $(0, 1/4]$, so all denominators are positive. The two expressions agree at $b = 1/2$.

Theorem 3.1 (Finite-profile criterion). *Let $E \subset \mathbb{R}^2$ be Borel, and write $d = \dim_{\mathbb{H}} E$, $D = \dim_{\mathbb{P}} E$. If*

$$1 < d \leq 5/4, \quad C(d, D) < d - 1, \quad (9)$$

then $|\Delta_y(E)| > 0$ for some $y \in E$.

3.1 The profile optimization

If g is a continuous function on $[0, N]$, put

$$c_g(m, n) = g(m) - \min_{m \leq x \leq n} g(x), \quad 0 \leq m < n \leq N.$$

The direction of this difference matters: the left endpoint is the larger physical cell. Call an edge $[m, n]$ admissible if $2n - m \leq N$.

Lemma 3.2 (A bounded-length chain). *Let N be a positive integer. Suppose $g(0) = 0$, g is 1-Lipschitz and piecewise linear on the integer grid, and*

$$ax \leq g(x) \leq bx, \quad 0 < a \leq b \leq 1, \quad b \geq \frac{1}{2}.$$

Given an integer $0 \leq n_0 < N$, there is an admissible decreasing chain from n_0 to zero, of at most

$$3 \left\lceil \log_2 \frac{N}{N - n_0} \right\rceil + 5$$

edges, with total cost at most $(bN - g(N))/(1 + 2b) + 3$. On a grid of mesh T , replace the additive constant by $3T$.

Proof. Define

$$L(x) = 2bx - bN - g(x), \quad V(x) = \frac{\max\{L(x), 0\}}{1 + 2b}.$$

The function L is nondecreasing. On $\{L \geq 0\}$, almost everywhere,

$$(-g')_+ \leq \frac{2b - g'}{1 + 2b}.$$

For $g' \geq 0$ this follows from $2b \geq 1$; for $g' < 0$ it is equivalent to $g' \geq -1$. Also

$$c_g(m, n) \leq \int_m^n (-g')_+ dx.$$

Let q be the largest integer with $L(q) \leq 0$. From $n_0 > q + 1$, repeatedly replace n by $\max\{q + 1, 2n - N\}$. These admissible edges double $N - n$, except possibly the last. Their total cost is

at most $V(n_0) - V(q + 1)$. If required, the edge from $q + 1$ to q costs at most one. If $n_0 \leq q$, omit this part.

In the region $L \leq 0$, for $n > N/2$ set $m_0 = 2n - N$. Then

$$g(m_0) \leq bm_0 \leq g(n).$$

Choose the leftmost grid minimum on $[m_0, n]$. It occurs before n , gives a zero-cost admissible edge, and remains in $L \leq 0$. If $n \leq N/2$, the edge to zero has zero cost since $g \geq 0$. Thus a finite zero-cost continuation exists. Merge consecutive edges greedily whenever their union is admissible. Their union still has zero cost. Maximality implies that every two merged edges more than double $N - n$, except at the end. This gives the stated edge count. Finally $V(n_0) \leq V(N) = (bN - g(N))/(1 + 2b)$. Rescaling proves the mesh version. $\square$

3.2 The unforced scale-profile estimate

An edge from n to $m < n$ in $[0, N]$ is admissible when $2n - m \leq N$, and its cost is

$$c_g(m, n) = g(m) - \min_{[m, n]} g.$$

No intermediate endpoint is prescribed in this section. This distinction is essential: the following estimate can be used in a distance argument only after the analytic transfer has been justified for such unforced chains.

Lemma 3.3 (Unforced profile bound). *Let $0 < a \leq b \leq 1$, and let $g : [0, N] \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$ be 1-Lipschitz with $ax \leq g(x) \leq bx$. For every $0 \leq n_0 < N$, an admissible decreasing chain from n_0 to zero exists with at most*

$$K \leq C \left(1 + \log \frac{N}{N - n_0} \right)$$

edges and total cost at most $NU(a, b)$, where

$$U(a, b) = \begin{cases} \frac{(b-a)(1-a)}{2(2b-a)}, & b \leq 1/2, \\ \frac{b-a}{1+2b}, & b \geq 1/2. \end{cases} \quad (10)$$

The formulas agree at $b = 1/2$. On a grid of mesh T containing $0, n_0, N$, the endpoints can be chosen on the grid with additional $O(KT)$ cost. If the barriers hold with uniform additive error ϵN , the additional cost is $O(K\epsilon N + KT)$.

Proof. The case $b \geq 1/2$ is the bounded-length unforced chain estimate of Lemma 3.2, followed by the grid limit described below. We prove the additional case $b \leq 1/2$, normalizing $N = 1$. Set

$$q = \frac{b}{2b-a}, \quad r = 2q - 1 = \frac{a}{2b-a}.$$

Then $1/2 < q \leq 1$ and $0 < r \leq 1$.

First observe that every endpoint $n \leq q$ admits free continuation to zero. For $1/2 < n \leq q$,

$$g(2n - 1) \leq b(2n - 1) \leq an \leq g(n), \quad (11)$$

because $(2b - a)n \leq b$. Choosing the leftmost minimum of g on $[2n - 1, n]$ gives an admissible zero-cost edge with endpoint less than n . When $n \leq 1/2$, the edge directly to zero is admissible and costs zero since $g(0) = 0$ and $g \geq 0$. On a finite grid the procedure terminates. Consecutive zero-cost intervals can be merged whenever their union is admissible, and their union remains

zero-cost. Every two consecutive unmergeable intervals more than double the complementary depth, so the retained zero-cost chain has the required logarithmic length. If $a = b$, then $q = 1$, and this argument already proves the result with zero cost. It also handles any starting point $n_0 \leq q$.

For the remaining initial portion, define on $[r, 1]$

$$H(z) = \frac{z}{2} + \left(b - \frac{1}{2}\right)r.$$

This majorizes bz , since

$$H(z) - bz = \left(\frac{1}{2} - b\right)(z - r) \geq 0.$$

For $x \geq q$, put

$$\Lambda(x) = H(2x - 1) - g(x) = x - \frac{1}{2} + \left(b - \frac{1}{2}\right)r - g(x).$$

The function Λ is nondecreasing, and

$$\Lambda(q) = H(r) - g(q) = br - g(q) = aq - g(q) \leq 0.$$

Almost everywhere,

$$(-g')_+ \leq \frac{1 - g'}{2} = \frac{\Lambda'}{2}.$$

Use maximal admissible downward jumps through $\{\Lambda > 0\}$, shortening the last jump if necessary to reach its lower boundary. Their costs sum to at most $\Lambda(n_0)_+/2$, because each edge cost is bounded by the negative variation of g over its interval. This is at most $\Lambda(1)/2$.

For a subsequent endpoint $n \geq q$ with $\Lambda(n) \leq 0$, the majorant is valid at $2n - 1 \geq r$, and gives

$$g(2n - 1) \leq H(2n - 1) \leq g(n).$$

Choose a leftmost minimum on $[2n - 1, n]$ to take a zero-cost edge. Continue until the endpoint becomes at most q ; it need not equal q . Below q , use (11) to continue for free. The maximal jumps in the positive region double complementary depth except at the last jump. Compressing the zero-cost intervals as above gives the claimed bound on the total number of edges.

Finally, $H(1) \geq g(1) \geq a$, and therefore

$$\frac{\Lambda(1)}{2} \leq \frac{1/2 + (b - 1/2)r - a}{2} = \frac{(b - a)(1 - a)}{2(2b - a)}.$$

This proves the cost bound.

For precision about arbitrary continuous profiles, first run the construction on piecewise affine interpolants on grids with mesh tending to zero. The interpolants retain both barriers and the Lipschitz constant. If n_0 is not a grid point, first jump to the nearest grid point below it; for sufficiently small mesh this is admissible and costs at most the mesh. Rounding the potential sign change and the threshold q requires at most a bounded number of grid crossings, each costing $O(T)$. For example, one stops the positive-potential construction at the first grid point above its lower boundary, then takes the adjacent grid edge across that boundary. Below q , the barrier argument applies directly. The edge-count bound is independent of the mesh. Pad endpoint lists by repeated endpoints and extract a convergent subsequence. Interval minima vary continuously with the profile and endpoints, and admissibility is closed. Removing repeated endpoints gives the exact continuous statement. This also proves the asserted fixed-mesh error bound.

For approximate barriers, clamp the profile between ax and bx and interpolate its grid values. This preserves the 1-Lipschitz property and changes the profile uniformly by $O(\epsilon N + T)$. Every edge cost changes by at most twice this amount. The resulting total error is $O(K\epsilon N + KT)$, as claimed. $\square$

The improvement over the global slope-1/2 majorant is quantified by

$$\frac{1/2 - a}{2} - U(a, b) = \frac{a(1/2 - b)}{2(2b - a)} \geq 0 \quad (b \leq 1/2).$$

The gain is strict below $b = 1/2$. This estimate is not asserted to be optimal in the small-slope range.

3.3 Finite regularization of the original pin measure

The constants in losses $R^{C_K h}$ below are independent of the regularization block size T ; fixed annular ratios depending on T change only multiplicative constants.

We prove a measure version of Theorem 3.1. Let μ, ν be probabilities on separated compact sets, normalized by a common translation and dilation into the interior of one unit dyadic cube. This preserves positive source-pin separation and both dimension exponents. Suppose both are t -Frostman for some $t > s > 1$, and

$$N(\text{supp } \nu, r) \leq Cr^{-u}, \quad 0 < r \leq 1. \quad (12)$$

We will prove

$$C(s, u) < s - 1 \implies (d_y)_* \mu \ll \mathcal{L}^1 \quad \text{for } \nu\text{-almost every } y. \quad (13)$$

Constants can depend on these fixed measures and their separation. The radial-projection theorem of Orponen, in the form of GIOW Theorem 3.7 or Keleti–Shmerkin Theorem 3.11, supplies $q > 1$ such that

$$B = \int \|\pi_*^y \mu\|_{L^q(S^1)}^q d\nu(y) < \infty. \quad (14)$$

Here $\pi^y(x) = (x - y)/|x - y|$. We also have $I_s(\mu) < \infty$.

Fix a large integer T . Use a smooth partition of frequency space into a low-frequency ball and annuli indexed by $R = 2^N$, $N = 4T\ell$. The annular ratios depend only on T ; all localization constants below may do so as well. Write P_R for the annular multiplier, including a fixed smooth spatial cutoff equal to one near $\text{supp } \mu$ and supported a positive distance from $\text{supp } \nu$. These multipliers have uniformly bounded convolution-kernel first norms, with constants depending on T .

Apply Keleti–Shmerkin’s finite regularization, Lemma 3.4 and Corollary 3.5, at depth N . More precisely, first distribute each depth- N cube mass uniformly within that cube. The lemma partitions all but mass $2^{-\epsilon N}$ into disjoint unions X_i of terminal cubes. Retain the *original* restrictions

$$w_i = \nu(X_i), \quad \sigma_i = w_i^{-1} \nu|_{X_i}.$$

They have the same coarser cube masses as the regularized measures. With

$$\Gamma = \epsilon + \frac{\log_2(4T + 2) + 2}{T},$$

we have $w_i \geq R^{-\Gamma}$. For each i , a function f_i , linear on the T -grid with slopes in $[0, 2]$, satisfies $f_i(0) = 0$ and, for every occupied cube of block depth k ,

$$2^{-f_i(k) - N/T} \leq \sigma_i(Q) \leq 2^{-f_i(k)}. \quad (15)$$

This follows directly by multiplying the one-step mass ratios in the definition of a regular measure. Also

$$sk - CTN - C_T \leq f_i(k) \leq uk + C_T. \quad (16)$$

For the first inequality use $\sigma_i \leq R^\Gamma \nu$, the Frostman bound, and the lower estimate in (15). For the second, the upper estimate in (15) forces at least $2^{f_i(k)}$ occupied cubes, whereas (12) bounds their number by $C2^{u_k}$. Interpolation extends the barriers with $O(T)$ error. Finally,

$$\int \|\pi_*^y \mu\|_q^q d\sigma_i(y) \leq BR^\Gamma. \quad (17)$$

Put $g_i = f_i - \text{id}$. Apply Lemma 3.3 with $a = s - 1$, $b = u - 1$. Start at the T -grid point immediately below $(1 - \zeta)N$, where $0 < \zeta < 1/8$ is fixed. We obtain a chain, common to the entire component,

$$n_0 > n_1 > \cdots > n_K = 0, \quad 2n_j - n_{j+1} \leq N, \quad (18)$$

$$K \leq C \log(1/\zeta) + C, \quad \sum_{j < K} c_{i,j} \leq C(s, u)N + CKTN + C_{T,K}, \quad (19)$$

$$c_{i,j} = g_i(n_{j+1}) - \min_{[n_{j+1}, n_j]} g_i.$$

No intermediate endpoint is prescribed. Admissibility of the final edge implies $n_{K-1} \leq N/2$, which is all that the final Fourier estimate will need. Grid interpolation in the clamping step only changes the last constant. The source μ is never restricted or regularized in this process.

3.4 Truncated conditional energies and deletion

For one edge write $m = n_{j+1}$, $n = n_j$, $b = 2^{-m}$, $a = 2^{-n}$, and $\rho = a/b$. A cube is called active when its σ_i -mass is positive. Only active cubes and their ancestors occur below.

Let Q be an active depth- m cube. For any concentric enlargement Q^+ by a factor between one and $R^{C_K h}$, set $\lambda = (\sigma_i)_{Q^+}$. For $m \leq k \leq n$, covering a ball by boundedly many dyadic cubes and using (15) gives

$$\lambda(B(z, 2^{-k})) \leq CR^{CT} 2^{f_i(m) - f_i(k)}.$$

Indeed, the denominator is at least the mass of the original active cube Q ; this avoids any boundary-sliver assumption about Q^+ . For intermediate radii between consecutive block-grid points, use the mass bound at the coarser grid point. The ratio between adjacent radii is at most 2^T , so this changes the estimate by a multiplicative constant depending only on T (one may take $O(2^{2T})$). It introduces no additional power of R . Summing dyadic annuli yields

$$J_\lambda(\rho) := \iint \min\{\rho^{-1}, b/|y - z|\} d\lambda(y) d\lambda(z) \leq C(N + 1)R^{CT} 2^{c_{i,j}}. \quad (20)$$

For separations larger than b , use the bound one. For the other annuli the summand is at most

$$CR^{CT} 2^{k - m + f_i(m) - f_i(k)} = CR^{CT} 2^{g_i(m) - g_i(k)}.$$

The innermost ball satisfies the same estimate. Replacing b , the tube width, or the truncation parameter by factors at most $R^{C_K h}$ changes (20) by at most another factor $R^{C_K h}$. This follows directly from the minimum kernel; no infinite conditional energy is used.

Here is the deletion argument with its multiplier exposed. If a probability λ is in a ball of radius b , take a ρ -net of unoriented directions and, in each direction, a bounded-overlap cover by ρb -wide tubes. Pair counting gives

$$\sum_T \lambda(T)^2 \leq C J_\lambda(\rho). \quad (21)$$

For fixed y, z , at most $C \min\{\rho^{-1}, b/|y-z|\}$ directions can place both points in such a tube; the spatial tube multiplicity in one direction is bounded. Integrating this statement proves (21). Enlarged supports and tubes introduce only powers of the enlargement factor.

For each pin, delete source directions whose angular maximal density exceeds a threshold L . The maximal inequality on the circle and Holder's inequality imply

$$(\mu \times \sigma_i)(\text{source-heavy pairs}) \leq C_q L^{1-q} B R^\Gamma. \quad (22)$$

For completeness, if v_y is the angular density, then $\int_{\{M v_y > L\}} v_y \leq C_q L^{1-q} \|v_y\|_q^q$: bound the length of that set by $C_q L^{-q} \|v_y\|_q^q$, then use Holder. Intervals centered at a retained direction therefore have mass at most a constant times their length times L .

Now declare a pin tube heavy when $\lambda(T) > H\rho$. Associate to it the unit-length source tube in the same direction, widened to angular width $C\rho$. If this tube contains any pair not source-heavy, its source mass is at most $CL\rho$. The fixed source-pin separation justifies this correspondence. Consequently the retained mass of pairs using heavy pin tubes is at most

$$CL\rho \sum_{\lambda(T) > H\rho} \lambda(T) \leq \frac{CL}{H} \sum_T \lambda(T)^2 \leq \frac{CL}{H} J_\lambda(\rho). \quad (23)$$

One can discretize all tube centers and directions here: replacing a tube by a containing member of a grid changes widths by fixed factors. Directions within $O(\rho)$ have the same containing tube after this enlargement. Thus the estimate also bounds the union over the finer angular caps used below, without paying their number.

Sum (23) over active parents with weights $\sigma_i(Q^+)$. Concentric enlarged cubes at a fixed scale have overlap at most the square of their dilation factor. Equations (20)–(23) therefore remain valid with an additional $R^{C_K h}$. Choose

$$L = R^{D_1 h}, \quad H_{i,j} = R^{D_2 h + C\Gamma} 2^{c_{i,j}}. \quad (24)$$

Here D_1 is sufficiently large in terms of q, K , and D_2 is sufficiently large compared with D_1, K . Then, for Γ sufficiently small compared with h , the deleted pair mass is at most $CR^{-c_1 h}$. The constant c_1 can be chosen larger than any fixed geometric overlap exponent needed below, by increasing D_1, D_2 . If $H_{i,j}\rho \geq 1$, there are no heavy pin tubes. Factors caused by an enlargement are covered by increasing D_1, D_2 ; their dependence on K, q is permitted.

3.5 Fourier iteration with no prescribed midpoint

We use the regularized component σ_i , the conditional energy estimate (20), and the deletion estimates (22)–(23). The chain required in this subsection has the following properties:

$$\begin{aligned} n_0 > n_1 > \dots > n_K = 0, \quad 2n_j - n_{j+1} \leq N, \quad n_0 = (1 - \zeta)N + O(T), \\ K \leq K_0, \quad \sum_{j < K} c_{i,j} \leq \mathcal{C}N + CK\Gamma N + C_{T,K}, \quad c_{i,j} = g_i(n_{j+1}) - \min_{[n_{j+1}, n_j]} g_i. \end{aligned} \quad (25)$$

Here $0 < \zeta < 1/8$, K_0 is fixed independently of $R = 2^N$, and the depths lie on the T -grid. The exponent $\mathcal{C}$ is any bound supplied by a profile argument with the stated edge count and perturbation errors. For the original finite-profile criterion it is $C(s, u)$ in (8); for the minimum refinement it is $V(s-1, u-1)$ in (40). No depth is required to equal $N/2$. We retain $N \in 4T\mathbb{N}$, so the standard angular scale used below is dyadic.

Put

$$a_j = 2^{-n_j}, \quad r_j = Ra_j, \quad \delta_j = r_j^{-1}, \quad \rho_j = \frac{a_j}{a_{j+1}}, \quad \delta_* = R^{-1/2}.$$

The two elementary inequalities

$$\delta_j \leq \rho_j, \quad \delta_* \leq \rho_j \quad (0 \leq j < K) \quad (26)$$

have different roles. The first is equivalent to $r_{j+1} \leq r_j^2$. For the second, admissibility and $n_{j+1} \geq 0$ give

$$n_j - n_{j+1} \leq \min\{n_j, N - n_j\} \leq N/2.$$

The last edge also gives $n_{K-1} \leq N/2$, hence $\delta_{K-1} \leq \delta_*$. The second inequality in (26) permits the standard source wave packets to be retained even when the auxiliary Fourier caps become narrower than δ_* .

A fixed source packet decomposition and a separate label tree

Fix a smooth annular multiplier at the scale R . First partition it into the usual smooth standard-cap multipliers $\psi_{R,S}$, with angular width δ_* . The label S has a nominal dyadic angular arc of that length; its multiplier is supported in a fixed enlargement of the arc, and these supports have bounded overlap. These standard multipliers are fixed before any finer partition is made.

Use their usual source wave packets, with spatial tubes of width $R^{-1/2+h}$ and fixed bounded length. Choose the longitudinal span to cover the common normalized source and pin region, with its cutoff outside that region. Thus remoteness there is transverse separation, not an artifact of a tube endpoint. Write

$$M_T \mu = \chi \eta_T (\psi_{R,S(T)} \hat{\mu})^\vee.$$

Here χ is a fixed smooth compact source cutoff, equal to one on a neighborhood of $\text{supp } \mu$, and with support separated from the pin set. For each standard label the smooth spatial functions η_T form a partition of unity on $\text{supp } \chi$. Thus summing all standard packets gives precisely $P_R \mu$, with the source cutoff convention used above. All packet localization estimates are applied only to these smooth standard multipliers and these standard spatial tubes.

We now define a separate angular tree for Fourier estimates. For each level with $\delta_j \geq \delta_*$, its labels group whole standard labels according to their nominal dyadic ancestors of width δ_j . Their multipliers are sums of the corresponding $\psi_{R,S}$. For $\delta_j < \delta_*$, a level label is a pair (S, I) , where I is a dyadic angular interval of length δ_j meeting the support of $\psi_{R,S}$; its multiplier is

$$\psi_{R,S}(\xi) \mathbf{1}_I(\xi/|\xi|).$$

The intervals partition the entire angular support of the standard multiplier, including the part outside its nominal arc. Consequently each such interval is within angular distance $O(\delta_*)$ of the standard label's direction. Use half-open angular intervals to specify the partition at endpoints. The endpoint choices do not affect any circular integral.

After the standard scale, parents keep the same label S and group the finer dyadic intervals. Before it, parents group whole standard labels. If an edge of the spatial chain crosses the standard angular scale, insert that scale in the angular tree only. This creates no additional spatial level and no additional inflation factor. The notation $\theta \prec \alpha$ below means descent in this label tree. It is a relation between labels; overlapping smooth standard supports cause no ambiguity in this relation.

Every level- j multiplier has angular support of width $O(\delta_j)$, and the supports have bounded overlap at each level. For fine labels this follows because at each direction only boundedly many standard multipliers are nonzero, and the dyadic intervals partition that direction separately for each such multiplier. For coarse labels it follows by grouping adjacent standard labels. No differentiability of a fine angular indicator will be used: these indicators partition spectral measures on circles, not source packets.

Coarsened marks and their bad-pair estimate

For a level- j Fourier label θ , define its effective label to be θ itself if $\delta_j \geq \delta_*$, and its standard parent S otherwise. Its angular width is

$$\bar{\delta}_j = \max\{\delta_j, \delta_*\} \leq \rho_j.$$

For each active a_j -cube $Q_j \subset Q_{j+1}$, mark an effective label bad when the enlarged a_j -by- a_{j+1} test tube, centered at Q_j and directed along that effective label, has mass greater than $H_{i,j}\rho_j$ under $(\sigma_i)_{Q_{j+1}^+}$. All Fourier labels with the same effective label receive the same mark. Descendant spatial cubes inherit the mark from their unique level- j ancestor. Use the thresholds (24).

For definiteness, the averaging cubes and test dilations may be chosen as

$$Q_j^+ = R^{(2j+2)h}Q_j, \quad \text{test-tube dilation } R^{(4K_0+20)h}.$$

For large R , child averaging cubes and their further R^h localizations fit inside the corresponding enlarged parent. Additional fixed geometric factors are absorbed into these dilations or their constants. The same enlarged parent is used in the marking condition, the truncated conditional energy, and the Fourier iteration.

These marks are unions of whole standard source-cap labels. At coarse levels this is true by their definition as groups of standard labels; at fine levels all descendants of S share the mark of S . For an initial pin cube Q_0 , remove a standard source packet when its enlarged tube $2T$ meets Q_0 and its standard label has any inherited bad mark. Call the retained source function G_{R,i,Q_0} .

The deletion estimates already proved apply to these marks. Indeed, directions within $O(\bar{\delta}_j)$ of an effective direction are within $O(\rho_j)$, so the same ρ_j -net of directions and the same containing tube grid cover the marked tubes. Their widths and conditional mass normalization are exactly those used in (20)–(23), up to the permitted enlargements. Source-heavy directions remain only an auxiliary device for estimating the bad mass; they are not additional Fourier marks.

The standard packet estimates give $\|M_T\mu\|_1 \lesssim \mu(CT) + \text{RapDec}(R)$, and rapidly small pinned first norm outside an enlarged T . A separated source-pin pair lies in only $R^{O(h)}$ enlarged standard packet tubes: their directions are within $O(R^{-1/2+h})$ of the connecting line, and the standard directions have spacing comparable to $R^{-1/2}$. Spatial tube multiplicity for a fixed direction is bounded. When a removed packet contributes to such a pair, its standard label and its effective bad label differ in direction by $O(\bar{\delta}_j)$; its packet uncertainty is $O(R^h\delta_*)$. By (26), both fit inside the enlarged conditional test tube based on that pair.

It follows, with $\text{Bad}_{R,i}$ the union of bad pairs estimated by the deletion argument, that

$$\int \|(d_y)_*(P_R\mu - G_{R,i,Q_0(y)})\|_1 d\sigma_i(y) \leq CR^{C_{K_0}h}(\mu \times \sigma_i)(\text{Bad}_{R,i}) + \text{RapDec}(R). \quad (27)$$

Only standard packets were summed here. There is no multiplicity equal to the number of auxiliary fine Fourier labels in a standard cap. Taking D_1, D_2 sufficiently large in terms of q, K_0 , and then Γ sufficiently small compared with h , makes the right side at most CR^{-c} for some $c > 0$, uniformly in the component.

For later reference, put $G_{R,y} = G_{R,i,Q_0(y)}$ on the component X_i , and zero on the discarded pin remainder. Multiplying by the component weights and summing proves

$$\int \|(d_y)_*(P_R\mu - G_{R,y})\|_1 d\nu(y) \leq CR^{-c'} \quad (c' > 0). \quad (28)$$

On the discarded remainder use $\|P_R\mu\|_1 \leq C_T$ and its mass at most $R^{-\epsilon}$. This uses the first norm of the whole annular multiplier, rather than a sum of absolute packet norms there.

Initial reconstruction and the exact inherited identity

Fix a circle radius $r \asymp_T R$, and let ω_r be its normalized arclength measure. Choose a nonnegative compactly supported smooth frequency function ψ whose inverse transform is bounded away from zero on the fixed pin region. For every terminal Fourier label ℓ , with multiplier $\psi_{R,\ell}$ specified by the tree above, set

$$F_\ell = ((\psi_{R,\ell} \widehat{\mu} d\omega_r) * \psi)^\vee.$$

The terminal label is a standard label if its width equals δ_* , and a pair (S, I) otherwise. The fixed frequency convolution makes these functions smooth, even when the fine angular partition uses indicators. Define coarser functions by summing terminal descendants. In particular, summing all terminal descendants of S gives the original standard-cap function exactly.

On Q_0 , the circular extension of the retained standard packets, multiplied by $\check{\psi}$, agrees up to a rapid error with the sum of the retained full standard-cap functions. To verify this statement, sum all packets of each standard label first. A packet with $2T \cap Q_0 = \emptyset$ has rapidly small circular extension on Q_0 , by the standard integration-by-parts packet estimate used in Liu's Lemma 4.2. Therefore retaining those remote packets from a bad standard label changes the extension there by only a rapid error.

The fixed source cutoff does not change this conclusion. The kernel of a smooth standard annular-cap multiplier is concentrated at transverse scale $R^{-1/2}$ and longitudinal scale R^{-1} . Outside a fixed neighborhood of $\text{supp } \mu$, that multiplier applied to μ , together with any prescribed finite number of derivatives, is rapidly small in integrable norms. Consequently replacing $\chi(\psi_{R,S} \widehat{\mu})^\vee$ by $(\psi_{R,S} \widehat{\mu})^\vee$ changes its circular extension by a rapid error, uniformly for the radii in question. All source functions used for pinned densities still include χ , preserving their fixed compact support and source-pin separation.

All terminal descendants of a standard label have the same survival decision at Q_0 . Thus, only after this whole-standard-cap reconstruction, partition each retained standard spectral measure into its terminal Fourier descendants. It follows that

$$\check{\psi}(y)(G_{R,i,Q_0} * \widehat{\omega}_r)(y) = F_{Q_0,\text{root}}(y) + \text{RapDec}(R), \quad y \in Q_0, \quad (29)$$

where the function on the right is the sum of surviving terminal labels. No fine angular cutoff has been applied to an individual source packet. In particular, no localization assertion about the spatial tails of such an individual fine piece is needed.

More generally, for an active level- j cube and a parent angular label α , define $F_{Q_j,\alpha}$ to be the sum of terminal descendants of α with no inherited bad mark at levels $j, j+1, \dots, K-1$. Level zero has a single parent label, the root. At level K , no marks remain, so $F_{Q_K,\ell} = F_\ell$. The level- j mark is constant on each level- j Fourier label; future marks are inherited from the parent cube. Hence

$$F_{Q_j,\alpha} = \sum_{\substack{\theta \prec \alpha \text{ at level } j \\ \theta \text{ good for } Q_j}} F_{Q_{j+1},\theta}. \quad (30)$$

This is an exact partition of terminal labels. The function on the right for a fixed parent and label is independent of the child cube. After the standard angular scale, every future mark depends only on the standard parent S ; there a fixed fine function is simply retained or omitted as a whole. This is compatible with the exact identity.

One threshold factor per inflation step

Let m_Q be normalized Lebesgue measure on Q , and define

$$\mathcal{E}_j = \sum_{Q_j \text{ active}} \sigma_i(Q_j^+) \sum_{\alpha \text{ at level } j-1} \int |F_{Q_j, \alpha}|^2 dm_{Q_j^+}.$$

The level-zero angular sum consists only of the root. Initial localization and (29) give

$$\int |G_{R, i, Q_0(y)} * \widehat{\omega}_r(y)|^2 d\sigma_i(y) \leq C_T R^{C\zeta + C_{K_0}h} \mathcal{E}_0 + \text{RapDec}(R).$$

Indeed each initial Fourier function has frequencies of size $O_T(R)$. Its pointwise square is controlled by a normalized average on an R^{-1} -ball with rapidly decreasing tails. Replacing that ball by an enlarged initial cube costs at most its area ratio $R^{2\zeta + O(T/N) + O_{K_0}(h)}$. Multiplication by its pin cube mass and summation give the displayed bound without any regularity assumption on the conditional pin measure.

We prove

$$\mathcal{E}_j \leq C_T R^{C_{K_0}h} H_{i,j} \mathcal{E}_{j+1} + \text{RapDec}(R). \quad (31)$$

Fix a parent cube $P = Q_{j+1}$ and a parent angular label. Proposition 16.1 below gives a full selected-subset Plancherel and weighted-kernel proof of the step; we describe its geometry here in the notation of this iteration. For its level- j descendants, the Fourier supports of the functions on the right of (30) lie in balls of radius $O_T(R/r_j)$ with bounded overlap. The fixed frequency smoothing preserves this assertion, since $R/r_j = 2^{n_j} \geq 1$. Local quadratic orthogonality on cubes of side $a_j = r_j/R$, followed by a cover of their enlargements, reduces the square in (30) to the sum of squares, with a loss $R^{O_{K_0}(h)}$ and a rapidly decreasing global-norm error.

For a fixed label θ , the support of $F_{P, \theta}$ lies in a rectangle of tangential width $O_T(R/r_j)$ and normal width $O_T(R/r_{j+1})$. The circular arc has normal width $O_T(R/r_j^2)$, at most $O_T(R/r_{j+1})$ by admissibility; the fixed frequency smoothing adds only bounded width, which is absorbed since $r_{j+1} \leq R$. Therefore local constancy applies on its dual tubes of dimensions a_j by a_{j+1} , oriented along the actual Fourier label.

Cover the parent by such tubes with bounded overlap. For any covering tube that meets good children, choose one of those good children. Its effective marking direction differs from the actual Fourier direction by $O(\bar{\delta}_j)$. In view of $\bar{\delta}_j \leq a_j/a_{j+1}$, the enlarged test tube of that child contains the covering tube and the enlarged children contributing to it, after the prescribed dilation factors. All these children lie in P^+ . Their enlargement multiplicity is at most a power $R^{C_{K_0}h}$. Thus their total weight is bounded by

$$R^{C_{K_0}h} H_{i,j} \frac{a_j}{a_{j+1}} \sigma_i(P^+).$$

This is exactly the conditional good-tube mass bound, with the same normalization as in deletion.

Local constancy bounds the squared supremum on a dual tube by its average on an R^h -enlargement, with a small-power loss and rapid tails. Relative to the parent average, the area ratio is $R^{O_{K_0}(h)} a_{j+1}/a_j$. It cancels the ratio in the last display. The tube cover and its enlarged localizations have multiplicity at most $R^{O_{K_0}(h)}$, and fit in P^+ under the choices of dilations above. Summing them gives the right side of (31) for this parent and cap. Adding omitted bad tubes on this nonnegative upper-bound side, and then summing all parent cubes and caps, proves (31).

At fixed K_0, T, h , the numbers of source packets, Fourier labels, and spatial cubes are polynomial in R . All relevant global Fourier norms also have polynomial bounds: the spectral densities

are bounded by a constant times $|\widehat{\mu}|$, the standard multipliers have bounded overlap, and the smoothing is fixed. The source functions are finite sums of standard packets with polynomial derivative bounds. One can therefore choose the rapidly decreasing localization errors to remain negligible after every sum in the argument. Hard fine angular partitions require no derivative bounds for these estimates.

The terminal estimate and the chain cost

Iterating (31), using (25) and (24), gives the multiplicative loss

$$R^{C+C\zeta+C_{q,K_0}h+CK\Gamma}.$$

At level K , the spatial scale is one and the functions are the terminal Fourier functions F_ℓ with no remaining marks. Their global Lebesgue norms bound the remaining unit-scale averages, up to the allowed enlargement factors. By Plancherel and Cauchy–Schwarz,

$$\sum_\ell \|F_\ell\|_2^2 \leq C_T R^{-1} \int_{S^1} |\widehat{\mu}(r\omega)|^2 d\omega. \quad (32)$$

For clarity, the normalized mass of the circle in a fixed-radius frequency ball is $O_T(R^{-1})$. For each terminal label, apply Cauchy–Schwarz to the convolution defining F_ℓ , using this mass bound. Integrate in frequency and sum the squared multipliers; their bounded overlap proves (32). This reasoning is valid for all terminal widths $\delta_{K-1} \leq R^{-1/2}$, including strictly finer widths. It does not introduce their number as a factor.

We conclude

$$\int |G_{R,i,Q_0(y)} * \widehat{\omega}_r(y)|^2 d\sigma_i(y) \leq C_T R^{-1+C+C\zeta+C_{q,K_0}h+CK\Gamma} \int_{S^1} |\widehat{\mu}(r\omega)|^2 d\omega + \text{RapDec}(R). \quad (33)$$

Together with (28), this supplies the two shell estimates needed in the following summation argument. Its parameter choices may be made in the same order: first ζ , fixing K_0 ; then the threshold constants in terms of q, K_0 ; then h ; and finally T, ϵ , making Γ sufficiently small. Fixed constants depending on the resulting annular ratio are absorbed for sufficiently large R .

In particular the proved transfer uses the cost of the unforced chain (25). The source packet decomposition remains at the standard scale throughout; only the spectral functions used for quadratic inflation are refined past that scale.

3.6 Summation, absolute continuity, and the Borel reduction

Fix $\eta > 0$ with $C(s, u) + \eta < s - 1$. Choose ζ so that $C\zeta < \eta/4$, fixing a bound for K . Next choose the constants D_1, D_2 in (24). Choose h small enough that all $C_{q,K}h$ losses are below $\eta/4$, and finally choose T large and ϵ small so that $\Gamma \ll h$ and $CK\Gamma < \eta/4$. These choices are fixed independently of R . Logarithms and fixed T, K constants are absorbed for sufficiently large R .

For $y \in X_i$ set $G_{R,y} = G_{R,i,Q_0(y)}$, and on the discarded pin remainder set $G_{R,y} = 0$. Equation (27) and the parameter choices give

$$\int \|(d_y)_*(P_R\mu - G_{R,y})\|_1 d\nu(y) \leq CR^{-c}, \quad c > 0. \quad (34)$$

On the remainder, use the uniformly bounded first norm of the *whole annular multiplier*; push-forward decreases total variation, so its contribution is at most $C_T 2^{-\epsilon N}$. One must not estimate it by the sum of absolute values of all packets.

Liu's pinned quadratic identity [5] bounds the radial density's squared norm by a constant times

$$\int_0^\infty |G_{R,y} * \widehat{\omega}_r(y)|^2 r \, dr.$$

The source-pin distances lie in a fixed interval bounded away from zero, so its radial weights are equivalent to the unweighted first-dimensional density norm. The identity is applied separately at each pin and therefore permits the dependence of $G_{R,y}$ on y .

Here is an explicit uniform bound for the omitted frequencies. A standard source packet has the form $\chi\eta_T(\psi_{R,S}\widehat{\mu})^\vee$, with $\|D^L(\chi\eta_T)\|_1 \leq C_L R^{L/2}$. Outside a fixed enlarged annulus, the distance to every $\text{supp } \psi_{R,S}$ is comparable to $R + |\xi|$. Integrating the convolution in frequency, using $|\widehat{\mu}| \leq 1$ and the polynomial number of packets, gives

$$|\widehat{G}_{R,y}(\xi)| \leq C_L R^{C+L/2} (R + |\xi|)^{-L}.$$

The constant C is independent of L , of the pin, and of all packet selections. Since ω_r is normalized, the corresponding omitted circular energy is at most

$$C_L R^{2C+L} \int_0^\infty (R+r)^{-2L} r \, dr \leq C_L R^{2C+2-L}.$$

Taking L arbitrarily large justifies the rapidly decreasing error uniformly over all components and pins. Integrating (33) over the remaining annulus and using

$$\int_{|\xi| \asymp_T R} |\widehat{\mu}(\xi)|^2 \, d\xi \leq C_T R^{2-s} I_s(\mu)$$

now gives

$$\int \|(d_y)_* G_{R,y}\|_2^2 \, d\nu(y) \leq C R^{1-s+C(s,u)+\eta} I_s(\mu). \quad (35)$$

To combine components, multiply their bounds by w_i and sum. The sets X_i are disjoint, and $\sum_i w_i \leq 1$; no factor counting the components appears.

The exponents in (34) and (35) imply convergence of the bad shell densities in $L^1(d\nu \, dt)$, and of the good shell densities in $L^2(d\nu \, dt)$. All source functions have the same fixed compact support, so the radial variable ranges over a bounded interval. Include the smooth low-frequency density. Their sum is an integrable joint density.

To identify it, finite shell sums reconstruct μ as a distribution. If $\Phi(y, t)$ is a smooth test function, then

$$x \longmapsto \chi(x) \int \Phi(y, |x-y|) \, d\nu(y)$$

is a smooth compactly supported test function: the cutoff χ keeps source and pins separated. Distributional reconstruction, followed by the stated norm convergence, identifies the joint density with the measure induced by $(y, x) \mapsto (y, |x-y|)$ on $\nu \times \mu$. Uniqueness of disintegration proves (13). In particular these pinned probabilities are nonzero and supported on the corresponding compact distance sets.

Finally suppose (9) holds. By continuity and strictness choose

$$1 < s < t < d, \quad D \leq u \leq 2, \quad C(s, u) < s - 1,$$

where $u > D$ if $D < 2$, and $u = 2$ if $D = 2$. Take a compactly supported t -Frostman probability on E . When $D < 2$, the packing-dimension covering characterization covers E by countably many bounded pieces of upper box dimension less than u . Taking their closures and intersecting with E makes a Borel cover without changing the upper box bounds. At least one piece has

positive Frostman mass. By inner regularity take a compact subset of positive mass there. When $D = 2$, the original compact support already has the universal covering bound with $u = 2$. In either case split the compact set into two separated compact subsets of positive mass. Their normalized restrictions μ, ν retain the t -Frostman estimate; the pin support satisfies (12). Equation (13) supplies the required pin in E . This proves Theorem 3.1.

Only the unforced cost bound is used at each regularized component. No midpoint or minimum-location condition remains in the measure theorem. The algebra leading to the explicit dimension curve follows in the next section.

4 Refinement using the actual minima

4.1 Parameters and statement

Throughout this section assume

$$\frac{1}{8} \leq a \leq \frac{1}{6}, \quad 2a \leq b \leq \frac{1}{2}. \quad (36)$$

Define

$$\begin{aligned} k &= 2b - a, & q &= \frac{b}{k}, & h &= \frac{1+q}{2}, \\ \lambda &= \frac{1-2b}{4b}, & L_0 &= \frac{1-2a}{4}, & E_1 &= \frac{1-q}{3}, \\ E_2 &= \frac{(b-a)(1+6b-4a)}{6k}, & & & A_E &= \frac{1-a-3b}{3}, \\ \sigma_E &= \frac{6b-1-2a}{3a}, & S_F &= \frac{1-a}{3} - h, & \sigma_F &= \frac{a+2}{3a}, \\ S_V &= \frac{1-a}{3} - \frac{(1-b)h}{2}, & \sigma_V &= \frac{1-a}{6a}. \end{aligned}$$

All three quantities $\sigma_E, \sigma_F, \sigma_V$ are strictly positive. For σ_E , use $6b-1-2a \geq 10a-1 \geq 1/4$. Set

$$J_E = \frac{\sigma_E L_0 + \lambda A_E}{\sigma_E + \lambda} = \frac{(1-a)(b-a)(6b-1)}{24b^2 - 14ab + 3a - 4b}, \quad (37)$$

$$J_F = \frac{\sigma_F L_0 + \lambda S_F}{\sigma_F + \lambda}, \quad (38)$$

$$J_V = \frac{\sigma_V L_0 + \lambda S_V}{\sigma_V + \lambda}. \quad (39)$$

In particular, all the denominators in these expressions are positive. The refined cost is the explicit continuous function

$$V(a, b) = \max\{\min(E_2, J_E), \min(J_F, J_V)\}. \quad (40)$$

Lemma 4.1 (Profile bound retaining two actual minima). *Assume (36). Let $g : [0, N] \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$ be 1-Lipschitz, with $ax \leq g(x) \leq bx$. If $7N/8 \leq n_0 < N$, there is an admissible decreasing chain from n_0 to zero, without a prescribed intermediate endpoint, whose cost is at most $NV(a, b)$. Its number of edges satisfies*

$$K \leq C \left(1 + \log \frac{N}{N - n_0} \right)$$

with an absolute constant C . On a grid of mesh T containing $0, n_0, N$, the additional cost is $O(KT)$. Additive barrier errors of size ϵN increase this to $O(K\epsilon N + KT)$.

The proof is elementary. It uses an affine potential, the location and value of a minimum on $[q, 1]$, and a reflection that raises successive new minima to the same height. We provide the construction, including its bounded-length and stability assertions.

4.2 Two reusable chain constructions

Normalize $N = 1$. Write $\text{Var}^-(g; I)$ for the negative variation of g on an interval I , in the direction of increasing coordinate. Every edge cost is at most this negative variation on its interval. Since a Lipschitz function is absolutely continuous,

$$\text{Var}^-(g; [v, w]) = \int_v^w (-g')_+ \leq \frac{w - v + g(v) - g(w)}{2}. \quad (41)$$

The following potential construction will be used twice. Suppose that $H(z) = cz + d$, where $c \geq 1/2$, majorizes the profile at all left endpoints being considered. Define

$$\Lambda(x) = H(2x - 1) - g(x).$$

Then Λ is nondecreasing, and almost everywhere

$$(-g')_+ \leq \frac{2c - g'}{2c + 1} = \frac{\Lambda'}{2c + 1}. \quad (42)$$

Indeed, for $g' \geq 0$ the inequality is immediate, while for $g' \leq 0$ it reduces to $g' \geq -1$. Through the region $\Lambda > 0$, use maximal admissible downward edges, shortening the last edge to the lower boundary of that region. The cost is at most $\Lambda(n_0)_+/(2c + 1)$, by (41) and (42). If $\Lambda(n) \leq 0$, then

$$g(2n - 1) \leq H(2n - 1) \leq g(n),$$

so moving to a leftmost minimum on $[2n - 1, n]$ gives a zero-cost edge. Each such endpoint is strictly smaller unless the desired terminal point has already been reached.

In particular, suppose that t is a minimum of g on $[t, 1]$, with $g(t) = m$, and put $e = g(1)$. The cone $H(z) = m + z - t$ majorizes g on $[t, 1]$. Its potential is nonpositive at $(1 + t)/2$. The preceding construction, with $c = 1$, followed by a free jump to t as soon as the current endpoint is at most $(1 + t)/2$, gives a chain to t , whenever $n_0 \geq t$, of cost at most

$$\frac{1 - t + m - e}{3}. \quad (43)$$

This quantity is nonnegative by the Lipschitz inequality. No linear upper barrier is needed for this cone construction. Zero-cost steps before its last jump stay in $[t, 1]$, since their left endpoints are at least t .

Here and below, the construction can first be performed for a piecewise affine profile. A chosen interval minimum is either a breakpoint or the left endpoint of the interval, except for constant pieces, where the leftmost convention again chooses a breakpoint or the left endpoint. There are consequently finitely many steps: steps that do not encounter a new breakpoint double the complementary depth $1 - n$. The general continuous case follows by the compactness argument at the end of the proof. This avoids assuming termination of an arbitrary infinite sequence of successive minima.

4.3 The expanded free interval

For $n \leq q$, a free continuation to zero is always possible. If $1/2 < n \leq q$, then

$$g(2n - 1) \leq b(2n - 1) \leq an \leq g(n).$$

Choose a leftmost interval minimum to obtain a zero-cost edge. When $n \leq 1/2$, jump directly to zero. This jump is free since $g(0) = 0$ and $g \geq 0$.

Choose a minimum point t of g on $[q, 1]$, and write

$$m = g(t), \quad e = g(1).$$

We shall retain the following relations, rather than immediately replacing the minimum by the lower barrier:

$$t \geq q, \quad at \leq m \leq bq, \quad m \leq e, \quad e \geq a. \quad (44)$$

Define

$$Q_m = \frac{1 + m/b}{2}.$$

Then $q \leq Q_m \leq h$. For $q < n \leq Q_m$,

$$g(2n-1) \leq b(2n-1) \leq m \leq g(n).$$

Thus the free interval actually extends to Q_m , by the same leftmost-minimum construction and the already proved free continuation below q .

On $z \geq m/b$, the affine function

$$H_m(z) = \frac{z}{2} + \left(b - \frac{1}{2}\right) \frac{m}{b}$$

majorizes bz . Its potential at Q_m is $m - g(Q_m) \leq 0$. Apply the potential construction with $c = 1/2$ down to the expanded free interval, then continue for free. This gives an always available chain of cost at most

$$L(m, e) = \frac{1-2e}{4} - \lambda m \leq L_0 - \lambda m. \quad (45)$$

The first expression is nonnegative: it is $(H_m(1) - g(1))/2$. If the initial point is already in the free interval, its zero cost satisfies the same estimate.

We will compare this chain with chains whose costs increase with m . For any $\sigma > 0$, $\lambda \geq 0$, and real A , the elementary intersection inequality is

$$\min\{L_0 - \lambda m, A + \sigma m\} \leq \frac{\sigma L_0 + \lambda A}{\sigma + \lambda} \quad (m \in \mathbb{R}). \quad (46)$$

To check it, split at $m = (L_0 - A)/(\sigma + \lambda)$. To the left, use the increasing line; to the right, use the decreasing line. The argument includes $\lambda = 0$.

4.4 An early minimum

Suppose first that $t \leq h$. In the parameter range (36), $q \leq 2/3$, so $h \leq 5/6 < 7/8 \leq n_0$. The cone construction (43) can therefore reach t . Choose a minimum point v on $[2t-1, q]$. This interval is nonempty because $t \leq h$. The edge $t \rightarrow v$ is admissible and has cost

$$(g(v) - m)_+ \leq (b(2t-1) - m)_+.$$

Indeed, $g \geq m$ on $[q, t]$, and $g(v)$ is the minimum on $[v, q]$. Below q we continue for free. This yields cost

$$\frac{1-t+m-e}{3} + (b(2t-1) - m)_+. \quad (47)$$

If the positive part vanishes, $m \leq e$ implies that this cost is at most $(1-t)/3 \leq E_1$. Otherwise it is

$$A = \frac{1-e-3b+(6b-1)t-2m}{3}.$$

Since $e \geq a$, $m \geq at$, and $t \leq h$,

$$A \leq \frac{1-a-3b+(6b-1-2a)h}{3} = E_2. \quad (48)$$

Alternatively $t \leq m/a$ and $6b-1 > 0$ give

$$A \leq A_E + \sigma_E m.$$

Comparison with (45), using (46), bounds the cheaper chain by J_E . Consequently the early case has cost at most

$$\max\{E_1, \min(E_2, J_E)\}. \quad (49)$$

4.5 A late minimum and reflection

Now suppose $t > h$. Choose a minimum point u on $[q, h]$, and put

$$w = g(u), \quad z = b(2u - 1).$$

Here $q \leq u \leq h$, $w \geq m$, and $2u - 1 \leq q$. We distinguish whether the terminal left interval is certainly free.

First suppose $w \leq z$. Define a nondecreasing function

$$r(x) = \begin{cases} 0, & x \leq u, \\ w - \min_{[u, x]} g, & x \geq u, \end{cases} \quad f(x) = g(x) + r(x).$$

The reflected function f is 1-Lipschitz. Here is a direct check. For $u \leq x < y$, if the running minimum does not decrease on $[x, y]$, then $r(x) = r(y)$, so the assertion follows for g . Otherwise a new minimum is attained at some $v \in [x, y]$, and

$$f(y) = g(y) + w - g(v), \quad f(x) \geq w.$$

It follows that $f(y) - f(x) \leq y - v \leq y - x$. The lower bound follows from $r(y) \geq r(x)$ and $g(y) - g(x) \geq -(y - x)$. Gluing at u handles intervals crossing u .

Moreover, $f \geq w = f(u)$ on $[q, 1]$ and $f(1) = e + w - m$. Apply the cone construction to f , reaching $u < n_0$ with cost at most

$$\frac{1 - u - e + m}{3}.$$

The function is unchanged to the left of u . A terminal jump to a minimum on $[2u - 1, q]$ has cost at most $(z - w)_+$, after which the original free continuation below q applies. The reflection need not satisfy the original linear upper barrier to the right of u : the cone uses only its Lipschitz property and its minimum, while the terminal and free portions use its unchanged left part.

For every edge $n \rightarrow v$, monotonicity of r gives

$$c_g(v, n) \leq c_f(v, n) + r(n) - r(v).$$

The extra terms telescope over the entire chain, to at most $r(n_0) \leq w - m$. We have therefore constructed a chain for g of cost at most

$$\frac{1 - u - e - 2m}{3} + \max(w, z). \tag{50}$$

In the present case $w \leq z$, this is

$$\frac{1 - e - 3b + (6b - 1)u - 2m}{3} \leq E_2,$$

using $e \geq a$, $u \leq h$, $m \geq at \geq ah$, and $6b - 1 \geq 0$. The floor chain also costs at most $L_0 - \lambda ah$. At $m = ah$, the increasing line $A_E + \sigma_E m$ has value E_2 . Consequently (46) implies

$$\min\{E_2, L_0 - \lambda ah\} \leq J_E.$$

The late case with $w \leq z$ is bounded by $\min(E_2, J_E)$.

4.6 A free terminal interval: length and variation

It remains to consider $t > h$ and $w \geq z$. If $t \leq n_0$, use the cone to reach t , then maximal admissible edges to reach h . The edge $h \rightarrow u$ is admissible since $u \geq q = 2h - 1$, and it is free since u minimizes g on $[q, h]$. The next edge to a minimum on $[2u - 1, q]$ is also free: its cost is at most $(z - w)_+ = 0$. Finish with the free continuation below q .

The middle chain from t to h has cost at most $t - h$. Combining with the cone yields

$$\frac{1 - t + m - e}{3} + t - h = \frac{1 - e - 3h + 2t + m}{3} \leq S_F + \sigma_F m,$$

where the last step uses $e \geq a$ and $t \leq m/a$. Comparison with the floor chain proves the bound J_F .

For the same middle chain, (41) gives the sharper alternative

$$\text{Var}^-(g; [h, t]) \leq \frac{t - h + g(h) - m}{2} \leq \frac{t - h + bh - m}{2}.$$

Its total cost with the cone is therefore at most

$$\frac{1 - e}{3} - \frac{(1 - b)h}{2} + \frac{t - m}{6} \leq S_V + \sigma_V m.$$

Comparison with the floor chain proves the bound J_V .

If $t > n_0$, omit the cone and start the middle chain at n_0 . Its length is at most $t - h$ and its negative variation is at most $\text{Var}^-(g; [h, t])$. The omitted cone cost $(1 - t + m - e)/3$ is nonnegative. Both displayed upper bounds thus remain valid. In all cases $n_0 > h$, as checked in the early case. The late case with $w \geq z$ is bounded by $\min(J_F, J_V)$.

4.7 Removing a redundant term and controlling the chain

The cases proved so far give cost at most

$$\max\{E_1, \min(E_2, J_E), \min(J_F, J_V)\}.$$

In fact E_1 is redundant. First,

$$\frac{E_2}{E_1} = \frac{1 + 6b - 4a}{2} \geq 1.$$

Second, the numerator of $L_0 - \lambda ah - E_1$, after multiplication by its positive denominator $24b(2b - a)$, is

$$(4 - 6a)b^2 + (6a^2 - 7a)b + 3a^2.$$

Writing $b = 2a + x$, $x \geq 0$, this is

$$a^2(5 - 12a) + 9a(1 - 2a)x + (4 - 6a)x^2 \geq 0.$$

At $m = ah$, both lines used to define J_E consequently have value at least E_1 . Their intersection value is at least their minimum at any specified point, by (46). Thus $J_E \geq E_1$, proving precisely the cost (40).

Each positive-potential or middle portion consists of maximal edges $n \rightarrow 2n - 1$, apart from a bounded number of terminal shortened edges. Such a maximal edge doubles $1 - n$. Consecutive zero-cost edges can be merged whenever their union is admissible; the union still has zero cost because its lower endpoint is a minimum on both constituent intervals. After all possible adjacent merges, any two consecutive retained edges, with endpoints $n_i > n_{i+1} > n_{i+2}$, satisfy

$$2n_i - n_{i+2} > 1, \quad \text{hence} \quad 1 - n_{i+2} > 2(1 - n_i).$$

Every construction above has only a bounded number of such portions and special terminal edges. It follows that its number of edges is at most $C(1 + \log(1/(1 - n_0)))$.

To justify the continuous assertion fully, interpolate the given profile on finer and finer partitions containing 0, n_0 , 1. Linear interpolation preserves both linear barriers and the Lipschitz constant. Run the finite piecewise affine constructions proved above. Their costs obey the same bound, and their lengths have the uniform bound just established. Pad endpoint lists by repeated endpoints and pass to a subsequence. The profiles converge uniformly. Minima on intervals vary continuously under uniform convergence and convergence of their endpoints. Admissibility is closed. The limiting chain therefore has the asserted cost and length; removing repeated endpoints gives a strictly decreasing chain.

For a prescribed grid of mesh T , round every endpoint down. If $m < n$, $m \geq 2n - N$, and N/T is integral, then

$$\left\lfloor \frac{m}{T} \right\rfloor \geq \left\lfloor \frac{2n - N}{T} \right\rfloor \geq 2 \left\lfloor \frac{n}{T} \right\rfloor - \frac{N}{T}.$$

Thus admissibility is preserved. An endpoint moves by at most T , and the minimum of a 1-Lipschitz function changes by at most T under this change of interval. The increase in cost is at most $2T$ per edge. Remove repetitions. Finally, clamping between ax and bx preserves the Lipschitz constant and changes a profile with approximate barriers uniformly by at most ϵN . Each edge cost changes by at most twice this amount. These arguments prove all stability and length claims in Lemma 4.1.

4.8 The exact cutoff is a unique root

Proposition 4.2. *For every $a \in [1/8, 1/6]$, there is a unique $b_*(a) \in [2a, 1/2]$ such that $V(a, b_*(a)) = a$. The function b_* is continuous,*

$$b_*(1/8) = 1/4, \quad b_*(1/6) = 1/2,$$

and $2a < b_*(a) < 1/2$ in the interior. For parameters (36),

$$V(a, b) < a \iff b < b_*(a).$$

Proof. We first show that $V(a, b)$ is strictly increasing in b , for fixed a . Both factors $(b - a)/(2b - a)$ and $1 + 6b - 4a$ are positive and strictly increasing, so E_2 is strictly increasing. Writing $D_E = 24b^2 - 14ab + 3a - 4b > 0$, differentiation gives

$$\frac{\partial J_E}{\partial b} = \frac{a(1 - a)(60b^2 - 12b + 1 - 4a)}{D_E^2} > 0.$$

For the last sign, the quadratic in b is increasing for $b \geq 2a \geq 1/4$; at $b = 2a$ it is $240a^2 - 28a + 1 \geq 5/4$, since its derivative in a is positive for $a \geq 1/8$.

For J_F, J_V , the corresponding σ is independent of b , $\lambda'(b) < 0$, and S_F, S_V are strictly increasing in b . Indeed,

$$q'(b) = -\frac{a}{(2b - a)^2} < 0, \quad h' = q'/2 < 0,$$

so $S'_F = -h' > 0$, and $S'_V = h/2 - (1 - b)h'/2 > 0$. Both S_F and S_V are less than L_0 . The former is negative; for the latter,

$$S_V - L_0 = \frac{1 + 2a}{12} - \frac{(1 - b)h}{2} \leq \frac{1}{9} - \frac{3}{16} < 0,$$

using $h \geq 3/4$. Thus the derivative of either intersection value $J = (\sigma L_0 + \lambda S)/(\sigma + \lambda)$ is

$$J' = \frac{\sigma \lambda' (S - L_0) + \lambda (\sigma + \lambda) S'}{(\sigma + \lambda)^2} > 0.$$

The minimum or maximum of finitely many strictly increasing functions is strictly increasing: compare all their values at two ordered arguments. This proves the strict monotonicity and continuity of V .

At $b = 2a$, direct substitution gives

$$E_2 = \frac{1 + 8a}{18} < a, \quad J_F = \frac{5 - 2a}{2(19 - 4a)}, \quad J_V = \frac{3 - 2a - 16a^2}{4(7 - 16a)}.$$

In the stated range $J_V \leq a$, with equality only at $a = 1/8$: the numerator of $J_V - a$ is $3(1 - 8a)(1 - 2a)$. At $a = 1/8$, $J_F > a$, so $V(1/8, 1/4) = 1/8$; in the interior $V(a, 2a) < a$. At $b = 1/2$,

$$J_E = J_F = J_V = L_0, \quad E_2 = \frac{1 - 2a}{3} > L_0,$$

and hence $V(a, 1/2) = (1 - 2a)/4 \geq a$, with equality only at $a = 1/6$. The intermediate value theorem and strict monotonicity give the unique root and the claimed endpoint and inequality statements.

For continuity, let $a_j \rightarrow a$ and take any convergent subsequence of $b_*(a_j)$, with limit b . The parameter constraints pass to the limit, and joint continuity gives $V(a, b) = a$. Uniqueness implies $b = b_*(a)$. Compactness then proves continuity of the full sequence, including at the endpoints. $\square$

4.9 Comparison, an exact example, and numerical values

The new bound improves the previous low-slope cost

$$U(a, b) = \frac{(b - a)(1 - a)}{2(2b - a)} = \frac{(1 - a)(1 - q)}{2}.$$

Here is an algebraic check that uses no numerical optimization. At $m = aq$, the decreasing floor line has value U ; the increasing early line has value $2U/3$, while the increasing free-terminal line has value

$$S_F + \sigma_F a q = -\frac{(1 + 2a)(1 - q)}{6} < 0.$$

Both intersections therefore occur to the right of aq . Their values satisfy $J_E, J_F \leq U$, strictly when $b < 1/2$ because then $\lambda > 0$. Consequently

$$V(a, b) \leq U(a, b), \quad V(a, b) < U(a, b) \quad \text{if } b < 1/2. \quad (51)$$

At $a = 3/20$, $b = 7/20$, exact arithmetic gives

$$E_2 = \frac{5}{33}, \quad J_E = \frac{187}{1255}, \quad J_F = \frac{1000}{6919}, \quad J_V = \frac{937}{6424}.$$

It follows by rational comparison that

$$V(3/20, 7/20) = \frac{187}{1255}, \quad \frac{3}{20} - V(3/20, 7/20) = \frac{1}{1004} > 0.$$

This is the exact profile margin used for the example in the main theorem. The cutoff at this dimension also has a simple exact expression:

$$b_*(3/20) = \frac{7 + \sqrt{13}}{30}, \quad B_M(23/20) = \frac{37 + \sqrt{13}}{30}. \quad (52)$$

To verify the root identification, put $b = (7 + \sqrt{13})/30$. Substitution gives $J_E = 3/20$ and $E_2 - 3/20 = (2\sqrt{13} - 7)/60 > 0$. Also $b < 9/25$, and strict monotonicity together with the exact calculation

$$J_F(3/20, 9/25) - 3/20 = -\frac{136}{51015} < 0$$

shows that $\min(J_F, J_V) < 3/20$. Thus $V(3/20, b) = 3/20$, and Proposition 4.2 identifies the claimed unique root.

For convenient evaluation, the level equations for E_2, J_E, J_F, J_V to equal a , after clearing positive denominators, are respectively

$$\begin{aligned} 0 &= 6b^2 + (1 - 22a)b + 10a^2 - a, \\ 0 &= (6 - 30a)b^2 + (20a^2 - a - 1)b + a - 4a^2, \\ 0 &= (8a^2 - 34a + 8)b^2 + (-4a^3 + 4a^2 - 9a)b + a^2 + 8a^3, \\ 0 &= -18ab^3 + (4 - 17a + 94a^2)b^2 - (3a + 19a^2 + 44a^3)b + 16a^3 - a^2. \end{aligned}$$

One can alternatively evaluate (40) directly and use monotone bisection. The following decimals are illustrative evaluations of the unique root; they play no role in the proof or in the definition of b_* .

a	$b_*(a)$, approximately	Expression attaining the root
0.125	0.250000000	J_V
0.130	0.269213180	J_V
0.135	0.289846951	J_V
0.140	0.312168690	J_V
0.142	0.322586562	J_F
0.145	0.332270658	E_2
0.150	0.353518376	J_E
0.155	0.386846972	J_E
0.160	0.427797338	J_E
0.165	0.479534898	J_E
1/6	0.500000000	$J_E = J_F = J_V$

Numerically, the active expressions change near $a = 0.140503259, 0.142267709$, and 0.147793654 , in the order J_V, J_F, E_2, J_E . These approximate transition locations are not assertions of an additional piecewise algebraic theorem; the proved, continuous, unique-root definition already covers the full interval.

Remark 4.3 (Distinction from the usual total-drop orientation). Keleti–Shmerkin’s total-drop framework [2, Definition 5.1 and Proposition 5.2] also combines interval minima with dyadically related endpoints. Its admissible partitions have neighboring scales in ratio at most two, and its summands subtract an interval minimum from the value at the smaller scale. Reflecting our coordinate, $x = 1 - n$, turns our admissibility into $x_{i+1} \leq 2x_i$, but turns our cost into $f(x_{i+1}) - \min_{[x_i, x_{i+1}]} f$, which uses the larger endpoint. The affine barriers are also reflected. Thus that proposition cannot be substituted with the same parameters for the lemma proved here. The proof in this section establishes the required orientation directly. The later hard-gap argument uses their separate hard-component identity with an explicit endpoint correction to obtain sharp bounds in the relevant range.

5 Endpoint normalization and adaptive intervals

5.1 An exact optimized cost

Throughout this section put

$$\frac{1}{10} \leq a \leq \frac{1}{6}, \quad 2a \leq b \leq \frac{1}{2}, \quad 0 \leq \theta \leq 1. \quad (53)$$

The parameter θ interpolates between a fixed head interval and an interval determined by the actual tail minimum. Define

$$\begin{aligned} k &= 2b - a, & q &= \frac{b}{k}, & h_\theta &= \frac{1+q}{2} - \frac{\theta a}{4k}, & r_\theta &= \frac{\theta}{4b}, \\ L_0 &= \frac{1-2a}{4}, & \lambda &= \frac{1-2b}{4b}, & A_0 &= \frac{1-a-3b}{3}, & \gamma &= \frac{6b-1-2a}{3a}. \end{aligned}$$

Here $\gamma \geq 0$, and $\gamma + \lambda > 0$, including the corner $a = 1/10, b = 1/5$, where $\gamma = 0$. Set

$$m_\theta = \frac{ah_\theta}{1-ar_\theta}, \quad E_\theta = A_0 + \gamma m_\theta, \quad J_E = \frac{\gamma L_0 + \lambda A_0}{\gamma + \lambda}, \quad (54)$$

$$F = \frac{(1-a)(b-a)}{4(2b-a)(1-b)}, \quad Z = \min \left\{ \frac{1-q}{3}, F \right\}. \quad (55)$$

For the two late routes, indexed by v (variation) and ℓ (length), put

$$\begin{aligned} A_v &= \frac{1-a}{3} - \frac{(1-b)h_\theta}{2}, & \sigma_v &= \frac{1-a}{6a} - \frac{(1-b)r_\theta}{2}, \\ A_\ell &= \frac{1-a}{3} - h_\theta, & \sigma_\ell &= \frac{a+2}{3a} - r_\theta, \\ P_i &= A_i + a\sigma_i, & J_i &= \frac{\sigma_i L_0 + \lambda A_i}{\sigma_i + \lambda} \quad (i = v, \ell). \end{aligned}$$

Both σ_i are strictly positive: for example $\sigma_v \geq (5-5a)/(48a) > 0$, using $b \geq 2a$. Also $1-ar_\theta \geq 7/8$. Thus all denominators are positive. Our new cost and its compact optimization are

$$C_\theta(a, b) = \max \{ Z, \min(E_\theta, J_E), \min(P_v, J_v, P_\ell, J_\ell) \}, \quad (56)$$

$$C_A(a, b) = \min_{0 \leq \theta \leq 1} C_\theta(a, b). \quad (57)$$

These are exact real expressions. The last minimum exists by continuity on the compact interval; it is not an assumption about a numerical optimizer.

Lemma 5.1 (Normalized adaptive profile bound). *Under (53), let $g : [0, N] \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$ be 1-Lipschitz and $ax \leq g(x) \leq bx$. For $15N/16 \leq n_0 < N$, there is an admissible chain from n_0 to zero of cost at most $NC_\theta(a, b)$, and hence one of cost at most $NC_A(a, b)$. The number of edges is $O(1 + \log(N/(N-n_0)))$, uniformly in θ . Grid and approximate barrier errors are $O(KT + K\epsilon N)$, as in Lemma 4.1.*

5.2 Endpoint normalization and free continuation

Normalize $N = 1$. Replace $g(x)$ by $\tilde{g}(x) = \min\{g(x), 1+a-x\}$. This preserves the barriers and the Lipschitz constant, and sets $\tilde{g}(1) = a$. Every edge cost increases. Indeed, if its left endpoint v is unchanged, the interval minimum can only decrease. Otherwise

$$c_{\tilde{g}}(v, n) \geq (1+a-v) - (1+a-n) = n-v \geq c_g(v, n).$$

It is therefore enough to construct chains for a profile with $g(1) = a$.

Let t minimize g on $[q, 1]$, and write $m = g(t)$. Then

$$aq \leq at \leq m \leq a, \quad m \leq bq. \quad (58)$$

Every endpoint below q has a free continuation, by $g(2n-1) \leq b(2n-1) \leq an \leq g(n)$ for $1/2 < n \leq q$, and the free jump to zero below $1/2$. The free region extends to

$$Q_m = \frac{1 + m/b}{2},$$

because $g(2n-1) \leq m \leq g(n)$ when $q < n \leq Q_m$. Set

$$Q_\theta = (1 - \theta)q + \theta Q_m, \quad H_\theta = \frac{1 + Q_\theta}{2} = h_\theta + r_\theta m.$$

Thus every endpoint below Q_θ has a free continuation, $q \leq Q_\theta \leq Q_m$, and $H_\theta \leq (3 + q)/4 \leq 11/12 < n_0$.

The affine majorant $z/2 + (b - 1/2)m/b$, applied above Q_m , has nonpositive potential at Q_m . The potential construction (42) therefore supplies, independently of all later cases, a chain with cost

$$L(m) = L_0 - \lambda m. \quad (59)$$

5.3 Early minima and the supporting line

If $t \leq Q_\theta$, the cone chain to t followed by free continuation costs at most $(1 - t + m - a)/3$. If $Q_\theta < t \leq H_\theta$, jump after that cone to a minimum on $[2t - 1, Q_\theta]$, and then continue freely. The cost is at most

$$\frac{1 - t + m - a}{3} + (b(2t - 1) - m)_+. \quad (60)$$

When the terminal contribution is zero, the cone bound is at most $(1 - q)/3$. A second construction gives F . On $[t, 1]$, $g(z) \leq \min\{bz, m + z - t\}$. These two lines meet at $z_* = (t - m)/(1 - b)$. The affine function

$$H(z) = \frac{z}{2} + \left(b - \frac{1}{2}\right) z_*$$

majorizes their minimum. Its potential bounds the cost down to $(1 + t)/2$, followed by a free jump to t , by

$$\frac{H(1) - a}{2} = \frac{1/2 - a - \kappa(t - m)}{2}, \quad \kappa = \frac{1/2 - b}{1 - b} \geq 0.$$

Here the construction can stop with positive remaining potential: its discarded value is nonnegative. If the potential reaches zero first, use zero-cost minimum steps until the terminal jump is admissible. All left endpoints where the majorant is used are at least t . Since $t - m \geq q - a$, the displayed expression is at most F , by direct substitution. The zero-terminal case thus has cost at most Z .

If the terminal contribution in (60) is positive, the bound becomes

$$A(t, m) = \frac{1 - a - 3b + (6b - 1)t - 2m}{3}.$$

Using $t \leq m/a$ gives the increasing line $A_0 + \gamma m$. Using $t \leq H_\theta$ gives a decreasing line, whose slope is $((6b - 1)r_\theta - 2)/3 < 0$. They intersect at m_θ , with common value E_θ . Comparing the increasing line with the independent floor (59) also gives J_E . Hence this case has cost at most $\min(E_\theta, J_E)$.

5.4 Late minima: reflection and two terminal routes

Suppose $t > H_\theta$, and let u minimize g on $[Q_\theta, H_\theta]$. Put $w = g(u)$, $z = b(2u - 1)$. Then $w \geq m$, $2u - 1 \leq Q_\theta$, and $m \geq at > aH_\theta$, so $m > m_\theta$.

If $w \leq z$, use the running-minimum reflection from the preceding section: set $r = 0$ before u , $r(x) = w - \min_{[u,x]} g$ after u , and $f = g + r$. It is 1-Lipschitz, has minimum w on $[Q_\theta, 1]$, and $f(1) = a + w - m$. The edge inequality $c_g(v, n) \leq c_f(v, n) + r(n) - r(v)$ transfers a cone chain to u , its terminal jump, and free continuation, with total cost at most

$$\frac{1 - u - a - 2m}{3} + \max(w, z) = \frac{1 - a - 3b + (6b - 1)u - 2m}{3}.$$

Since $u \leq H_\theta < m/a$, both previous affine bounds apply; the decreasing one is evaluated to the right of m_θ . The bound is again $\min(E_\theta, J_E)$.

If $w \geq z$, the interval below H_θ is free: jump first to u , then to a minimum on $[2u - 1, Q_\theta]$, then continue freely. Above it, use the cone to t and an admissible chain from t to H_θ . Bounding this middle part by negative variation or by its length gives respectively

$$\frac{1 - a}{3} - \frac{(1 - b)H_\theta}{2} + \frac{t - m}{6}, \quad \frac{1 - a}{3} - H_\theta + \frac{2t + m}{3}.$$

The relation $t \leq m/a$ bounds these by $A_i + \sigma_i m$, $i = v, \ell$. If $t > n_0$, omit the cone and restrict the middle variation or length to $[H_\theta, n_0]$; the omitted cone allowance is nonnegative, so the bounds remain valid. Since $m \leq a$, each increasing line is at most P_i . Intersecting it with the decreasing floor gives J_i . The late free-terminal case therefore has cost at most $\min(P_v, J_v, P_\ell, J_\ell)$, completing the cost proof.

There are a bounded number of chain portions. For clarity, compression does not require that their edges be free: for $l < m < n$,

$$c_g(l, n) \leq c_g(l, m) + c_g(m, n).$$

This follows by comparing the two interval minima and using $\min_{[l,m]} g \leq g(m)$. Merge any adjacent pair whose union is admissible. In a chain with no further such merge, complementary depth more than doubles every two edges, giving the claimed logarithmic count. For piecewise affine profiles the constructions terminate; approximate a general Lipschitz profile by piecewise affine interpolation and pass to a convergent subsequence of uniformly bounded endpoint lists. Costs, minima and admissibility pass to the limit. Rounding down and clamping the barriers give the stated errors exactly as before. All bounds are uniform in θ ; this proves Lemma 5.1.

5.5 The unique root and the dimension curve

Lemma 5.2. *The function C_A is continuous and strictly increasing in b for fixed a in (53). There is a unique continuous $\beta(a) \in [2a, 1/2]$ satisfying $C_A(a, \beta(a)) = a$. Its endpoint values are $\beta(1/10) = 1/5$, $\beta(1/6) = 1/2$, and $\beta(a) > 2a$ for $1/10 < a \leq 1/6$.*

Proof. All expressions are jointly continuous with positive denominators; minimizing over a fixed compact interval preserves continuity. We check strict increase of every ingredient in (56). Both terms defining Z increase strictly. Write

$$E_\theta = \frac{b - a}{3(2b - a)} T, \quad T = \frac{12b^2 + (2 - 8a)b - \theta a(1 - a)}{4b - \theta a}.$$

The first factor increases strictly. We have $T > 0$, and its derivative has positive numerator $48b^2 - 24ab\theta + 2a\theta + 4a^2\theta$. Thus E_θ increases strictly. For J_E , its derivative is a positive factor times $60b^2 - 12b + 1 - 4a$. Substitute $b = 2a + x$, $x \geq 0$, to obtain

$$240a^2 - 28a + 1 + (240a - 12)x + 60x^2 > 0.$$

Indeed, the constant term is increasing for $a \geq 1/10$ and is $3/5$ at $a = 1/10$. Thus J_E increases strictly.

For the late bounds, regard $H_\theta(m) = h_\theta + r_\theta m$ as a function of b at fixed $a, \theta, m > 0$. Then

$$\partial_b H_\theta(m) = -\frac{a(1-\theta)}{2(2b-a)^2} - \frac{\theta m}{4b^2} < 0.$$

Both route lines $A_i + \sigma_i m$ therefore increase strictly in b , as does $L(m)$, since $\partial_b L(m) = m/(4b^2) > 0$. At $m = aq$, the differences between the floor and the two route lines are

$$\frac{(b-a)(5-2a-9b)}{12(2b-a)} > 0, \quad \frac{(4-a)(b-a)}{6(2b-a)} > 0.$$

Their intersections are consequently at positive m . To compare intersection values at two upper slopes, evaluate the two new lines at the old intersection: both values have increased strictly. The maximum of the minimum of a decreasing and an increasing affine line is their intersection value, so J_i increases strictly. Evaluating the route lines at $m = a$ similarly proves this for P_i . Finite minima and maxima preserve strict increase. Finally, choosing a minimizing θ at the larger upper slope proves strict increase of C_A itself.

For the lower endpoint, use $\theta = 1, b = 2a$. Direct substitution gives a zero-terminal bound $(1-a)/(12(1-2a)) < a$, an early bound at most $(1+11a)/21$, and a late bound at most $(1+6a)/16$. The latter two are at most a , strictly so for $a > 1/10$. At $a = 1/10, b = 1/5, \gamma = 0$ forces the early bound to be exactly a for every θ , establishing equality there.

At $b = 1/2, \lambda = 0$, so all three intersection values equal L_0 . The other early bound is at least $E_0 = 4L_0/3$. The zero-terminal bound is at most $F = L_0$, while $P_\ell \geq L_0$ and $P_v \geq L_0$. Consequently $C_\theta(a, 1/2) = L_0$ for every θ . Now $L_0 \geq a$, with equality only at $a = 1/6$. The intermediate value theorem and strict increase give the unique root. Continuity of the root follows by taking convergent subsequences in the compact interval and using uniqueness, including the two endpoints. $\square$

This gives the new curve B_A stated at the beginning of the manuscript. It dominates B_M : on the latter's nontrivial middle range, $\theta = 0$ gives the same early bounds as V , no larger late bounds, and $Z \leq (1-q)/3 \leq \min(E_2, J_E)$. Thus $C_A \leq C_0 \leq V$. Below that range the previous curve is $2d - 1$; above it the two displayed curves agree.

An exact new example, requiring no optimization, is

$$a = \frac{11}{100}, \quad b = \frac{9}{40}, \quad \theta = 1, \quad C_1(a, b) = \frac{644}{5925}, \quad a - C_1(a, b) = \frac{31}{23700} > 0.$$

The fully interpolated construction also covers $a = 7/50, b = 11/35, \theta = 1/3$, with cost $452437/3234750$ and margin $214/1617375$. These are rational checks of strict inequalities, not numerical evidence substituting for the profile or analytic proof.

6 Sharp profile bounds from hard-component gaps

6.1 Statement of the sharp profile estimates

For an admissible edge $n \rightarrow m < n$ in $[0, N]$, recall that $2n - m \leq N$ and

$$c_g(m, n) = g(m) - \min_{[m, n]} g.$$

All chains in this section are finite, decreasing, and have no prescribed intermediate endpoint. Define

$$b_c(a) = \frac{1 + 2a}{4 + 2a}, \quad (61)$$

$$R(a, b) = 4(1 + a)b^2 - 4(a + 2)b + 1 + 3a, \quad (62)$$

$$C_1(a, b) = \frac{b - a}{1 + 2b}, \quad (63a)$$

$$C_2(a, b) = \frac{(b - a)(2 + a - 2b - 4ab)}{(1 - a)(1 + 2b)^2}. \quad (63b)$$

The additional low-side guard is

$$b \leq b_c(a), \quad R(a, b) \leq 0. \quad (64)$$

Theorem 6.1 (Sharp estimates from hard gaps). *Let $0 < a < b \leq 1/2$, and let $g : [0, N] \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$ be 1-Lipschitz with $ax \leq g(x) \leq bx$. For every $0 \leq n_0 < N$, an admissible chain from n_0 to zero exists with total cost at most*

$$\begin{cases} NC_2(a, b), & b \leq b_c(a) \text{ and } R(a, b) \leq 0, \\ NC_1(a, b), & b \geq b_c(a). \end{cases}$$

Its number of edges is at most

$$K \leq C \left(1 + \log \frac{N}{N - n_0} \right)$$

with an absolute constant. If a grid of mesh T contains $0, n_0, N$, its endpoints may be chosen on that grid with additional $O(KT)$ cost. Uniform additive barrier errors of size ϵN give additional cost $O(K\epsilon N + KT)$.

Both bounds are sharp as universal profile estimates in their respective stated domains: after normalizing $N = 1$, the supremum over admissible profiles of the limiting optimal cost as $n_0 \uparrow 1$ equals the displayed $C_i(a, b)$. This is sharpness of the profile model, not a necessary condition for positive-length distance sets.

The previously proved profile estimate handles $b \geq 1/2$. We prove the theorem by analyzing complementary intervals of the hard-point set, and by giving explicit nonnegative linear combinations of their constraints. No numerical optimization is used in the proof.

6.2 Endpoint normalization

Normalize $N = 1$. Replace g by

$$\tilde{g}(x) = \min\{g(x), 1 + a - x\}.$$

This function is 1-Lipschitz and has the same barriers: the additional upper bound majorizes ax , since $1 + a - x - ax = (1 + a)(1 - x) \geq 0$. It has endpoint value $\tilde{g}(1) = a$. More importantly,

$$c_g(m, n) \leq c_{\tilde{g}}(m, n) \quad (0 \leq m < n \leq 1). \quad (65)$$

If $g(m) \leq 1 + a - m$, the lower-endpoint value is unchanged and the interval minimum can only decrease. Otherwise

$$c_{\tilde{g}}(m, n) \geq (1 + a - m) - (1 + a - n) = n - m \geq c_g(m, n),$$

where the last step uses the Lipschitz property. Thus a chain constructed for the normalized profile gives no greater cost for the original one, with identical endpoints and length. Henceforth assume $g(1) = a$.

6.3 Reversal and the hard-component identity

For $0 < \zeta \leq 1$, let $\Phi_\zeta(g)$ be the infimum of the costs of admissible chains from $1 - \zeta$ to zero. Put

$$f(t) = g(1 - t) - a, \quad f(0) = 0, \quad f(1) = -a.$$

If an original edge has endpoints $n > m$, write $x = 1 - n$, $y = 1 - m$. Its admissibility is exactly $y \leq 2x$. Its original cost becomes $f(y) - \min_{[x, y]} f$, whereas the usual total-drop summand is $f(x) - \min_{[x, y]} f$. Their difference is $f(y) - f(x)$.

Let $T_\zeta(f)$ be the infimum of the usual total drop over finite partitions of $[\zeta, 1]$ whose neighboring endpoints have ratio at most two. Reversal gives a bijection of these partitions with the original chains, and telescoping yields

$$\Phi_\zeta(g) = T_\zeta(f) - g(1 - \zeta). \quad (66)$$

Let $T(f)$ denote the infimum of total drop over infinite good partitions of $[0, 1]$, in the sense of Keleti–Shmerkin [2, Definition 5.1]. Extending a finite partition below ζ by successive halvings adds at most ζ to its cost. Conversely, truncate an almost optimal infinite partition at the interval crossing ζ , replacing that interval's lower endpoint by ζ . The ratio condition is preserved, and the Lipschitz property changes the crossing cost by at most 2ζ ; later costs are nonnegative and can be discarded. Consequently

$$T(f) - \zeta \leq T_\zeta(f) \leq T(f) + 2\zeta.$$

Equation (66) proves

$$\Phi_0(g) := \lim_{\zeta \downarrow 0} \Phi_\zeta(g) = T(f) - a. \quad (67)$$

Suppose for now that g is piecewise affine with finitely many pieces. Its hard-point set in the original coordinate is

$$H_g = \left\{ x \in [0, 1] : g(x) = \min_{[x, (1+x)/2]} g \right\}.$$

It is a finite union of closed interval components, possibly degenerate. Both zero and one belong to it. Under $t = 1 - x$, this is exactly the hard-point set $\{t : f(t) = \min_{[t/2, t]} f\}$ of f . On each original component $[p, q]$, the function g is nondecreasing. This also follows directly: for sufficiently close $x < y$ in a hard interval, hardness at x gives $g(y) \geq g(x)$, and subdivision and continuity give the assertion throughout the interval.

Keleti–Shmerkin's hard-point formula [2, Lemma 5.4] applies to this piecewise affine function. A component $[p, q]$ corresponds to $[1 - q, 1 - p]$, whose drop is $f(1 - q) - f(1 - p) = g(q) - g(p)$. Therefore

$$\Phi_0(g) = \sum_{[p, q] \text{ component of } H_g} (g(q) - g(p)) - a. \quad (68)$$

The subtraction of a is the endpoint correction in (67); omitting it would change the problem.

6.4 Gaps, their drops, and two tail estimates

Lemma 6.2 (A gap ends at its minimum). *If (q, p) is a gap between consecutive components of H_g , then*

$$g(x) \geq g(p) \quad (q < x < p), \quad g(q) \geq g(p).$$

Writing $u = g(q)$, $v = g(p)$, and $\delta = u - v \geq 0$, every gap with $\delta > 0$ satisfies

$$\delta \leq p - \frac{1+q}{2}. \quad (69)$$

Proof. If $g(x) < g(p)$ for some $x \in (q, p)$, choose a minimum point z on $[x, p]$. Then $z < p$, and $g(z) < g(p)$. On $[z, p]$ the profile is at least $g(z)$. Any part of $[z, (1+z)/2]$ lying after p is contained in $[p, (1+p)/2]$, where hardness of p gives $g \geq g(p) > g(z)$. Thus z is hard, a contradiction. Continuity gives $g(q) \geq g(p)$.

If $\delta > 0$, hardness of q forces $p > (1+q)/2$, and $g((1+q)/2) \geq u$. The Lipschitz bound between $(1+q)/2$ and p gives (69). $\square$

Telescoping all hard-component increases and the intervening gap changes, using $g(0) = 0$, $g(1) = a$, turns (68) into

$$\Phi_0(g) = \sum_{\text{gaps}} \delta. \quad (70)$$

All terms are nonnegative. We may omit gaps with zero drop. The retained positive gaps remain ordered and disjoint, and all Lipschitz and barrier constraints at their endpoints remain valid.

Lemma 6.3 (Two estimates after a specified endpoint). *Suppose $g(p) = v$, and let T be the sum of the drops of positive gaps contained in $[p, 1]$. Then*

$$T \leq \frac{1-p}{2}, \quad T \leq \frac{1-p+v-a}{2}. \quad (71)$$

In particular, for $0 \leq \chi \leq 1/2$,

$$T \leq \frac{1-p}{2} + \chi(v-a). \quad (72)$$

Proof. For a positive gap (q_j, p_j) ,

$$\delta_j \leq p_j - \frac{1+q_j}{2} = \frac{p_j - q_j}{2} - \frac{1-p_j}{2} \leq \frac{p_j - q_j}{2}.$$

Sum over the disjoint intervals to obtain the first bound. Independently, each drop is at most the negative variation on its gap. A 1-Lipschitz function has total variation at most the interval length, so

$$T \leq \text{Var}^-(g; [p, 1]) \leq \frac{1-p+g(p)-g(1)}{2}.$$

This is the second bound. Their convex combination with weights $1-2\chi$ and 2χ proves (72). $\square$

If there is just one positive gap, the barriers and (69) give

$$\delta \leq \min \left\{ p - \frac{1+q}{2}, bq - ap \right\} \leq \frac{(2b-a)p-b}{1+2b} \leq C_1(a, b). \quad (73)$$

The middle inequality follows by intersecting the decreasing and increasing affine bounds in q ; the last follows from $p \leq 1$. With no positive gaps, the cost is zero.

6.5 The two-collapse upper bound

Assume $b \leq b_c(a)$ and $R(a, b) \leq 0$. Put

$$s = 1 + 2b, \quad D = (1 - a)s^2, \quad \chi = \frac{1 + a - 4ab + 4b^2 - 2b}{D}.$$

The numerator is $1 - 2b + a + 4b(b - a) > 0$, while

$$\chi - \frac{1}{2} = \frac{R(a, b)}{2D} \leq 0. \quad (74)$$

Thus $0 < \chi \leq 1/2$, and the blended tail bound is applicable.

Suppose there are at least two positive gaps, and denote the first two by (q_i, p_i) , with $u_i = g(q_i)$, $v_i = g(p_i)$, and $\delta_i = u_i - v_i$, for $i = 1, 2$. They obey

$$\begin{aligned} u_1 - bq_1 &\leq 0, & ap_1 - v_1 &\leq 0, \\ q_1 - 2p_1 + 2\delta_1 &\leq -1, & u_2 - v_1 - q_2 + p_1 &\leq 0, \\ u_2 - bq_2 &\leq 0, & q_2 - 2p_2 + 2\delta_2 &\leq -1, \\ p_2 &\leq 1. \end{aligned} \quad (75)$$

The fourth inequality uses Lipschitz continuity between p_1 and q_2 , regardless of any omitted zero-drop gaps.

In the displayed order, multiply the seven constraints by

$$\begin{aligned} w_1 &= \frac{1}{s}, & w_2 &= \frac{1 - 2b}{(1 - a)s}, & w_3 &= \frac{b}{s}, \\ w_4 &= \frac{2b - a}{(1 - a)s}, & w_5 &= \frac{1 + 2a - 4b - 2ab}{D}, & w_7 &= \frac{1 - \chi}{2}, \\ w_8 &= \frac{1}{2} - \chi. \end{aligned} \quad (76)$$

Every weight is nonnegative. The sign of w_5 is exactly $b \leq b_c(a)$; all other signs follow from the parameter range and (74). The subscripts are merely convenient names for these seven coefficients.

The identities

$$\begin{aligned} w_3 &= bw_1, & w_1 + 2w_3 &= 1, & aw_2 - 2w_3 + w_4 &= 0, \\ w_2 + 2w_3 + w_4 &= 1, & w_7 &= w_4 + bw_5, & w_4 + w_5 &= \chi, & 2w_7 &= 1 - \chi \end{aligned}$$

check every coefficient in the weighted sum. Its left side is $\delta_1 + \delta_2 - p_2/2 + \chi v_2$, and its right side is $-w_3 - w_7 + w_8 = -w_3 - \chi/2$. Therefore

$$\delta_1 + \delta_2 - \frac{p_2}{2} + \chi v_2 \leq -\frac{b}{1 + 2b} - \frac{\chi}{2}. \quad (77)$$

Apply (72) to all gaps after p_2 . Using (70) gives

$$\begin{aligned} \Phi_0(g) &\leq \delta_1 + \delta_2 + \frac{1 - p_2}{2} + \chi(v_2 - a) \\ &\leq \frac{1}{2} - \frac{b}{1 + 2b} - \left(a + \frac{1}{2}\right)\chi = C_2(a, b). \end{aligned}$$

The zero- and one-positive-gap cases follow from (73), since

$$C_2(a, b) - C_1(a, b) = \frac{(b - a)(1 + 2a - 4b - 2ab)}{(1 - a)(1 + 2b)^2} \geq 0. \quad (78)$$

This proves the low-side upper bound for piecewise affine profiles.

6.6 The single-collapse upper bound

Now assume $b \geq b_c(a)$. In addition to the constraints already established, the first two positive gaps satisfy

$$v_1 \leq u_2. \quad (79)$$

Indeed, between p_1 and q_2 the hard-component increases are nonnegative and all intervening gaps have zero drop. Telescoping gives $u_2 - v_1 \geq 0$. Pointwise monotonicity on that whole interval is neither asserted nor needed.

Use the following eight constraints, in order:

$$\begin{aligned} u_1 - bq_1 &\leq 0, \\ \delta_1 - p_1 + q_1/2 &\leq -1/2, \\ ap_1 - v_1 &\leq 0, \\ \delta_2 - p_2 + q_2/2 &\leq -1/2, \\ ap_2 - v_2 &\leq 0, \\ u_2 - v_1 - q_2 + p_1 &\leq 0, \\ p_2 &\leq 1, \\ v_1 - u_2 &\leq 0. \end{aligned} \quad (80)$$

With $D_1 = (1 + 2a)(1 + 2b)$, multiply them by

$$\begin{aligned} \omega_1 &= \frac{1}{1 + 2b}, & \omega_2 &= \frac{2b}{1 + 2b}, \\ \omega_3 &= \frac{2b}{D_1}, & \omega_4 &= \frac{4b(1 + a)}{D_1}, \\ \omega_5 &= \frac{1 + 2a - 2b}{D_1}, & \omega_6 &= \frac{2b(1 + a)}{D_1}, \\ \omega_7 &= \frac{(6 + 8a)b - (1 + 2a)^2}{2D_1}, & \omega_8 &= \frac{(2a + 4)b - (2a + 1)}{D_1}. \end{aligned} \quad (81)$$

All are nonnegative. The last has precisely the required threshold. The numerator of ω_7 increases with b , and at $b = b_c(a)$ it equals

$$\frac{(1 + a)(1 - 2a)(1 + 2a)}{a + 2} > 0.$$

The remaining signs follow from $0 < a < b \leq 1/2$.

Expanding the weighted sum of (80) gives exactly $\delta_1 + \delta_2 - p_2/2$ on the left. On the right it gives $-\omega_2/2 - \omega_4/2 + \omega_7$. Thus the first tail bound in (71) proves

$$\begin{aligned} \Phi_0(g) &\leq \delta_1 + \delta_2 + \frac{1 - p_2}{2} \\ &\leq \frac{1}{2} - \frac{\omega_2}{2} - \frac{\omega_4}{2} + \omega_7 = C_1(a, b). \end{aligned}$$

The cases with fewer than two positive gaps follow from (73). This proves the second upper bound for piecewise affine profiles.

6.7 Finite starts, uniform chain length, and stability

We now justify the finite-chain statement and extend the proof to all continuous profiles. First, $\Phi_\zeta(g)$ is nondecreasing as $\zeta \downarrow 0$. To compare starts $n_1 < n_2 < 1$, truncate a chain from n_2 at

its first crossing of n_1 , replacing the crossing edge by its subinterval from n_1 . The subinterval is admissible and has no greater cost. Conversely, maximal admissible edges bridge n_2 to n_1 , shortening the last edge if necessary, with total cost at most $n_2 - n_1$. Hence

$$0 \leq \Phi_0(g) - \Phi_\zeta(g) \leq \zeta. \quad (82)$$

In particular, the proved limiting upper estimates bound every finite-start infimum.

Any finite admissible chain can be compressed without increasing cost. For $l < m < n$,

$$c_g(l, n) \leq c_g(l, m) + c_g(m, n). \quad (83)$$

If $A = \min_{[l, m]} g$, $B = \min_{[m, n]} g$, the difference between the right and left sides is $g(m) - \max(A, B) \geq 0$. Merge adjacent edges whenever their union remains admissible. When no merge is possible, three consecutive endpoints satisfy

$$2n_i - n_{i+2} > 1, \quad 1 - n_{i+2} > 2(1 - n_i).$$

The complementary depth more than doubles every two edges. A start $n_0 = 1 - \zeta$ therefore yields at most $2\lceil \log_2(1/\zeta) \rceil + O(1)$ retained edges.

Take finite chains with costs approaching the finite-start infimum and compress them. Pad their endpoint lists by repetitions to a common bounded length and extract a convergent subsequence. Admissibility is closed, and interval minima vary continuously with the endpoints of their intervals. The limiting chain attains the infimum; removing repeated endpoints makes it strictly decreasing. Thus the desired upper cost is achieved by an actual chain of uniformly bounded length.

For a continuous 1-Lipschitz profile, first normalize its endpoint as above, then interpolate on partitions of mesh tending to zero, containing $0, n_0, 1$. The interpolants preserve both linear barriers, the Lipschitz constant, and the value $g(1) = a$. The preceding argument provides chains of uniformly bounded length with the asserted cost for each interpolant. Their endpoint lists have a convergent subsequence, and the interpolants converge uniformly. Interval minima and costs pass to the limit, as does admissibility. This gives the asserted chain for the continuous profile. Equation (65) returns it to the original profile if normalization was needed.

For grid rounding, rescale back to $[0, N]$. Round every endpoint down to a multiple of T . If $m \geq 2n - N$ and N/T is integral, then

$$\left\lfloor \frac{m}{T} \right\rfloor \geq \left\lfloor \frac{2n - N}{T} \right\rfloor \geq 2 \left\lfloor \frac{n}{T} \right\rfloor - \frac{N}{T}.$$

Thus admissibility is preserved. Endpoints move by at most T , and the interval minimum of a 1-Lipschitz function changes by at most T . Each cost changes by at most $2T$; discard repetitions.

If the barriers hold with additive error ϵN , clamp the profile between ax and bx first. This preserves the Lipschitz constant and changes the profile uniformly by at most ϵN . Each edge cost changes by at most $2\epsilon N$. Normalize the clamped profile afterwards; that step only increases edge costs and does not add an error. The resulting total error is $O(K\epsilon N + KT)$, proving all claims concerning finite chains and perturbations in Theorem 6.1.

6.8 A matching two-collapse witness

We give the full hard-set calculation for the lower bound. Suppose $0 < a < b \leq b_c(a)$, and define

$$k = 2b - a, \quad q_0 = \frac{b}{k}, \quad Q(v) = \frac{2(1+a)v - 1}{1 + 2b}.$$

Set

$$q = Q(1) = \frac{1+2a}{1+2b}, \quad t = \frac{(1-b)q}{1-a}, \quad r = Q(t),$$

and consider

$$g(x) = \min\{bx, at + |x - t|, 1 + a - x\}. \quad (84)$$

This is 1-Lipschitz. Each function in the minimum majorizes ax : for the middle one, its difference from ax is $(1+a)(t-x)$ when $x \leq t$, and $(1-a)(x-t)$ when $x \geq t$. The last function has difference $(1+a)(1-x)$. Thus the profile has both barriers, and $g(1) = a$.

The parameter restriction gives $q_0 \leq t < q < 1$; the first inequality is equivalent to $1+2a-4b-2ab \geq 0$. Put

$$L = \frac{(1+a)t}{1+b}, \quad P = \frac{1+a}{1+b}.$$

Then $L < t < q < P < 1$, and the consecutive affine pieces are

$$g(x) = \begin{cases} bx, & 0 \leq x \leq L, \\ (1+a)t - x, & L \leq x \leq t, \\ x - (1-a)t, & t \leq x \leq q, \\ bx, & q \leq x \leq P, \\ 1+a-x, & P \leq x \leq 1. \end{cases} \quad (85)$$

The increasing cone after t meets bx exactly at q , because $(1-a)t = (1-b)q$.

The hard set has exactly the nondegenerate components

$$[0, r] \quad \text{and} \quad [t, q], \quad (86)$$

together with the isolated endpoint one. To check this, first note

$$r - L = \frac{(1+a)t - (1+b)}{(1+b)(1+2b)} < 0, \quad \frac{1+r}{2} \leq t,$$

where the second inequality is equivalent to $t \geq q_0$. Also

$$br = (1+a)t - \frac{1+r}{2}, \quad br - at = \frac{kt - b}{1+2b} \geq 0.$$

For $x \leq r$, the interval $[x, (1+x)/2]$ either stays on the initial increasing segment or enters its following descent with endpoint value at least bx . Thus these points are hard. For $r < x < L$, once its future endpoint is on that descent it has value below bx ; if the interval reaches t , its value $at < bx$ gives the same conclusion. The relevant endpoint is already on or beyond the descent at $x = r$, since

$$\frac{1+r}{2} - L = \frac{b(1+b - (1+a)t)}{(1+b)(1+2b)} \geq 0.$$

For $L \leq x < t$, immediate strict decrease rules out hardness. There are consequently no hard points in (r, t) .

For $t \leq x \leq q$, the profile initially increases. If its future interval enters the final descent, the difference between the final-descent value at $(1+x)/2$ and $g(x)$ equals

$$1+a - \frac{1+x}{2} - (x - (1-a)t) = \frac{3}{2}(q - x) \geq 0.$$

Thus these points are hard. For $q < x \leq P$, the same future endpoint lies on the final descent and has value strictly below bx . Indeed,

$$\frac{1+q}{2} - P = \frac{b(b-a)}{(1+2b)(1+b)} > 0.$$

For $P \leq x < 1$, strict decrease again rules out hardness. This proves (86), including the boundary case $t = q_0$, where the first gap has zero drop.

The identity (68) now gives

$$\Phi_0(g) = br + (bq - at) - a = C_2(a, b).$$

Thus the low-side upper estimate is attained by a concrete piecewise affine profile wherever its hypotheses hold.

6.9 A matching single-collapse witness

For all $0 < a < b \leq 1$, the profile

$$g(x) = \min\{bx, 1 + a - x\}$$

is admissible and endpoint-normalized. Its only nondegenerate hard component is

$$\left[0, \frac{1 + 2a}{1 + 2b}\right].$$

Indeed, on the initial increasing segment the boundary is the solution of $bx = 1 + a - (1 + x)/2$; beyond it the future descent has smaller value, and the final decreasing segment has no hard points except the endpoint one. Therefore

$$\Phi_0(g) = b \frac{1 + 2a}{1 + 2b} - a = C_1(a, b).$$

This proves sharpness on the high-side domain and completes the proof of Theorem 6.1. By (78), the two sharp formulas agree at $b = b_c(a)$.

6.10 The explicit dimension curve

Put

$$\alpha = \frac{3 - \sqrt{7}}{4}, \quad a_c = \frac{\sqrt{6} - 2}{4}, \quad b_c(a) = \frac{1 + 2a}{4 + 2a}, \quad b_F(a) = \frac{2a}{1 - 2a}.$$

Thus $d_\alpha = 1 + \alpha$, $d_c = 1 + a_c$. The relevant threshold can now be evaluated exactly, rather than by compact optimization.

First consider $\alpha \leq a \leq a_c$ and $2a \leq b \leq b_c(a)$. The two-gap guard holds strictly throughout this region. Indeed, $\partial_b R = 8(1 + a)b - 4(a + 2) < 0$ for $b \leq 1/2$, and

$$R(a, 2a) = 16a^3 + 8a^2 - 13a + 1.$$

This last polynomial decreases for $\alpha \leq a \leq 1/6$, while

$$R(\alpha, 2\alpha) = 3(11\alpha - 1) < 0.$$

The last sign follows from $\alpha < 1/11$, equivalently $29 < 11\sqrt{7}$, whose squares are $841 < 847$.

For fixed a , the derivative of C_2 on this region is

$$\partial_b C_2 = \frac{2 + 11a + 8a^2 - (8 + 14a + 8a^2)b}{(1 - a)(1 + 2b)^3} > 0.$$

Its numerator decreases with b , and multiplying its value at $b_c(a)$ by $4 + 2a$ gives $18a(1 + a) > 0$. At the lower endpoint,

$$C_2(a, 2a) - a = \frac{a(1 + 2a)(8a^2 - 12a + 1)}{(1 - a)(1 + 4a)^2}. \quad (87)$$

This vanishes at $a = \alpha$ and is negative for $\alpha < a \leq a_c$. At the upper endpoint, $C_2 = C_1$, and

$$C_1(a, b) < a \iff b < b_F(a).$$

The equality $b_F(a) = b_c(a)$ occurs at $a = a_c$, since it is equivalent to $8a^2 + 8a - 1 = 0$. For $a < a_c$, the left side is smaller; consequently $C_2(a, b_c(a)) > a$.

It follows that $C_2(a, b) = a$ has a unique root in $[2a, b_c(a)]$, with the appropriate endpoint equalities. Clearing positive denominators gives

$$(4a^2 - 8a - 2)b^2 + (8a^2 - a + 2)b - 3a = 0.$$

Its smaller root is exactly $r_2(a)$ in (2). Existence of the crossing and the strictly positive derivative at it show that the discriminant is positive; the stated radical is therefore real on the full closed interval. The root is continuous and strictly larger than $2a$ for $\alpha < a \leq a_c$. Its endpoint values are

$$r_2(\alpha) = 2\alpha, \quad r_2(a_c) = b_c(a_c) = \frac{\sqrt{6} - 1}{5}.$$

Thus the dimension branches agree at the two joins; at the second join their common value is $(4 + \sqrt{6})/5$.

For $a_c \leq a \leq 1/4$, the cutoff is $b_F(a)$. To verify that no lower-slope interval is missed, suppose $2a \leq b \leq b_c(a)$. The inequality $2a \leq b_c(a)$ forces $a \leq (\sqrt{13} - 3)/4 < 1/6$. The same guard calculation above applies, and monotonicity gives

$$C_2(a, b) \leq C_2(a, b_c(a)) = C_1(a, b_c(a)) \leq a,$$

strictly except at $a = a_c, b = b_c(a_c)$. For $b \geq b_c(a)$, the single-collapse upper bound gives $C_1 < a$ precisely for $b < b_F$; above $b = 1/2$ the earlier high-slope estimate supplies the same bound. The cases $b < 2a$ are already covered by the coherent criterion.

Proof of Theorem 1.1. For $1 < d \leq d_\alpha$, or whenever $D < 2d - 1$, use Proposition 2.5. In every remaining case of $D < B_H(d)$, the preceding calculation gives a universal profile cost strictly below $a = d - 1$, using C_2 or C_1 with $b = D - 1$. The two formulas agree at $b = b_c(a)$, and the two-gap guard is strict wherever that branch is used here. Continuity and strictness therefore allow $s < d, u > D$, with $1 < s < 5/4, s < u < 2$, still in the certified region and with the corresponding cost below $s - 1$.

The hard-gap profile theorem gives the same bounded number of edges, admissibility and $O(KT + K\epsilon N)$ perturbation error required by Theorem 3.1. Substitute its cost in that proof. The compact restrictions, finite regularization, deletion, Fourier iteration and summable shell limit are unchanged. They give a compact source subset and a family of pins in E of full measure for the selected Frostman pin probability, with absolutely continuous pinned distance measures. In particular one $y \in E$ has $|\Delta_y(E)| > 0$. $\square$

6.11 Precisely what is optimal here

For $0 < a \leq 1/4, a \leq b \leq 1$, define

$$\mathcal{M}(a, b) = \sup_g \lim_{\zeta \downarrow 0} \inf_{\text{finite admissible chains}} \sum_{1-\zeta \text{ to } 0} c_g,$$

where the supremum is over all 1-Lipschitz profiles with $ax \leq g(x) \leq bx$. Consider the following precisely specified combination of sufficient tests:

$$b < 2a \quad \text{or} \quad \mathcal{M}(a, b) < a. \tag{88}$$

The first is the coherent test; the second is the limiting universal chain-cost test used in the analytic transfer. The new curve is the exact threshold for this combination:

$$(88) \iff 1 + b < B_H(1 + a). \quad (89)$$

We have proved the sufficient direction. For the converse, when $0 < a \leq \alpha$, the two-collapse profile with upper slope $2a$ has cost at least a , by (87). It is also admissible under every larger upper barrier, so $\mathcal{M}(a, b) \geq a$ for $b \geq 2a$. When $\alpha < a < a_c$, the matching two-collapse profiles give $\mathcal{M} \geq C_2 \geq a$ from $r_2(a)$ to $b_c(a)$. Above $b_c(a)$, the single-collapse profiles give $\mathcal{M} \geq C_1 \geq a$. Finally, for $a \geq a_c$, those same single-collapse profiles give $\mathcal{M} \geq a$ whenever $b \geq b_F(a)$. The profile lower bounds include equality at all displayed thresholds. This proves (89).

This optimality concerns exactly (88). It gives no set E whose pinned distances have zero length. Better analytic information, a more selective family of profiles, or a different distance-set argument could still enlarge the sufficient region. In particular, it does not determine the weakest possible Hausdorff-packing condition for the distance theorem itself.

For comparison with the preceding manuscript, its profile constructions give universal costs, so $\mathcal{M} \leq C_A$ wherever that function was used. Equation (89) therefore shows that B_H includes the entire preceding curve B_A . The new curve also has a direct closed-form description.

Two exact examples illustrate the strict inequalities:

$$C_2\left(\frac{9}{100}, \frac{181}{1000}\right) = \frac{4619}{51529}, \quad \frac{9}{100} - \frac{4619}{51529} = \frac{1861}{5152900} > 0,$$

$$C_1\left(\frac{3}{20}, \frac{2}{5}\right) = \frac{5}{36}, \quad \frac{3}{20} - \frac{5}{36} = \frac{1}{90} > 0.$$

Also $r_2(1/10) = 5/23$, so the exact cutoff at Hausdorff dimension $11/10$ is $28/23$; at dimension $23/20$ it is $10/7$.

7 Algebra and proof of the dimension criterion

Put $a = s - 1$ and $b = u - 1$. For $0 < a \leq 1/4$, the unforced cost $U(a, b)$ is continuous across $b = 1/2$. On each side it is increasing in b . The derivatives are respectively

$$\frac{a(1-a)}{2(2b-a)^2}, \quad \frac{1+2a}{(1+2b)^2}.$$

In the low-slope region, direct multiplication gives

$$U(a, b) < a \iff b(1-5a) < a(1-3a).$$

When $1/7 < a \leq 1/6$, this is precisely

$$b < \frac{a(1-3a)}{1-5a}.$$

The right side is at most $1/2$, because that comparison is equivalent to $(6a-1)(a-1) \geq 0$. In dimension variables its cutoff is $(2+2s-3s^2)/(6-5s)$. Its improvement over $2s-1$ follows from

$$\frac{a(1-3a)}{1-5a} - 2a = \frac{a(7a-1)}{1-5a} > 0.$$

For $b \geq 1/2$, the high-slope condition is

$$\frac{b-a}{1+2b} < a \iff b < \frac{2a}{1-2a}.$$

For $1/6 < a \leq 1/4$ the right side exceeds $1/2$, and its dimension cutoff is $1/(3-2s)$. All $b \leq 1/2$ are covered in this range, since

$$U(a, b) \leq U(a, 1/2) = \frac{1-2a}{4} < a.$$

At $a = 1/6$, strict $b < 1/2$ also gives $U < a$. The joins at $d = 8/7$ and $d = 7/6$ have values $9/7$ and $3/2$, respectively.

Proof of Theorem 1.4. For $1 < d \leq 8/7$, apply the coherent criterion, Proposition 2.5, with both sets equal to E . For $8/7 < d \leq 5/4$, the preceding algebra shows that $D < B_U(d)$ implies $U(d-1, D-1) < d-1$. The unforced finite-profile criterion, Theorem 3.1, gives the required pin. Its compact restrictions are subsets of E , so the pin lies in E . Strictness and continuity supply every exponent slack used in that theorem's Borel reduction. $\square$

Proof of Theorem 1.3. For $1 < d \leq 9/8$, use Proposition 2.5. For $9/8 < d < 7/6$, first use that proposition if $D < 2d-1$. Otherwise put $a = d-1$, $b = D-1$. The root characterization in Section 4 gives $V(a, b) < a$, with $1/8 < a < 1/6$ and $2a \leq b < 1/2$. The profile estimate proved there supplies exactly the same bounded-length chains, admissibility, and perturbation errors as Lemma 3.3. Thus the proof of the finite-profile criterion applies with $C(s, u) = V(s-1, u-1)$. Explicitly, continuity and strictness allow $s < d$ and $u > D$, still with $1/8 < s-1 < 1/6$, $2(s-1) < u-1 < 1/2$, and $V(s-1, u-1) < s-1$. Use these parameters in the compact restriction, finite regularization, deletion, Fourier iteration, and shell summation of Section 3. The error and parameter choices are unchanged. For $7/6 \leq d \leq 5/4$, apply Theorem 1.4. $\square$

Proof of Theorem 1.2. For $1 < d \leq 11/10$, use Proposition 2.5. For $11/10 < d < 7/6$, the same proposition covers $D < 2d-1$. Otherwise put $a = d-1$, $b = D-1$. Lemma 5.2 gives $C_A(a, b) < a$, and a minimizing parameter θ has $C_\theta(a, b) < a$. Keep this parameter fixed. Joint continuity and strictness allow $s < d$, $u > D$, with $1/10 < s-1 < 1/6$, $2(s-1) < u-1 < 1/2$, and $C_\theta(s-1, u-1) < s-1$. Use Lemma 5.1 in the finite-profile criterion, Theorem 3.1, choosing its fixed initial loss below $1/16$. The chain count, rounding error and approximate-barrier error are precisely those required there. The same compact restriction, finite regularization, deletion, Fourier iteration and shell summation give a pin in E . For $7/6 \leq d \leq 5/4$, use Theorem 1.4. $\square$

8 Subquadratic integrability from the profile decomposition

The strict finite-profile criterion gives more than absolute continuity: the original joint distance law has a density in some L^p with $p > 1$. This conclusion uses a variable deletion threshold. It does not weaken the criterion on the dimensions. We first prove the elementary norm estimate and then keep track of the discarded pin remainder.

8.1 A parameterized decomposition estimate

For a measurable function on a measure space (X, m) , use the weak quasinorm

$$\|F\|_{p,\infty} = \sup_{t>0} t m\{|F| > t\}^{1/p}.$$

Lemma 8.1. *Suppose $\|F\|_1 \leq 1$, $A > 0$, $\gamma > 0$, $K > 0$, and, for every $\Lambda \geq 1$, there is a decomposition*

$$F = G_\Lambda + B_\Lambda, \quad \|B_\Lambda\|_1 \leq \Lambda^{-\gamma}, \quad \|G_\Lambda\|_2^2 \leq A\Lambda^K.$$

Put $\theta = \gamma/(K + \gamma)$ and $p_0 = 1 + \theta = (K + 2\gamma)/(K + \gamma)$. Then

$$\sup_{t>0} t^{p_0} m\{|F| > t\} \leq 6A^\theta, \quad \|F\|_{p_0,\infty} \leq 6^{1/p_0} A^{\gamma/(K+2\gamma)}. \quad (90)$$

If F is bounded, it suffices to have these decompositions for

$$1 \leq \Lambda \leq \max\{1, (\|F\|_\infty/A)^{1/(K+\gamma)}\}.$$

Fixed multiplicative constants in the assumptions change only the conclusion's multiplicative constant.

Proof. For $t \leq A$, Markov gives $t^{p_0} m\{|F| > t\} \leq t^{p_0-1} \leq A^\theta$. For $t > A$, choose $\Lambda = (t/A)^{1/(K+\gamma)}$. The triangle inequality and Chebyshev give

$$m\{|F| > t\} \leq 4A\Lambda^K t^{-2} + 2\Lambda^{-\gamma} t^{-1} = 6A^\theta t^{-p_0}.$$

Values $t > \|F\|_\infty$ have zero superlevel measure, proving the finite-range assertion. Rescaling F , and changing the constant multiplying A , handles fixed constants in the hypotheses. $\square$

We also record two direct consequences of the distribution bound. If F is supported in a region of measure $V < \infty$, then, for $1 \leq p < p_0$,

$$\|F\|_p \leq \left(\frac{p_0}{p_0 - p}\right)^{1/p} V^{1/p-1/p_0} \|F\|_{p_0,\infty}. \quad (91)$$

For any measurable A of finite measure,

$$\int_A |F| dm \leq \frac{p_0}{p_0 - 1} \|F\|_{p_0,\infty} m(A)^{1-1/p_0}. \quad (92)$$

Both follow by integrating the smaller of the trivial set-measure bound and the weak distribution bound, splitting the level integral where they are equal. Thus no interpolation or Lorentz-space theorem is needed.

8.2 Varying the deletion thresholds

Theorem 8.2 (A stronger conclusion under the strict profile criterion). *Assume the separated-probability hypotheses of the finite-profile measure argument, and suppose that the bounded-chain estimate (25) holds with $C < s - 1$. Then the joint distance law induced by $(y, x) \mapsto (y, |x - y|)$ on $\nu \times \mu$ has a density in $L^p(d\nu dt)$ for some $p > 1$. In particular, its pinned densities belong to $L^p(dt)$ for ν -almost every pin.*

More precisely, make any fixed parameter choices in the strict proof leaving a negative good-shell exponent $-\kappa < 0$, a chain-length bound $K \geq 1$, and discarded pin mass at most $CR^{-\epsilon_{\text{reg}}}$, with $\epsilon_{\text{reg}} > 0$. Let $q > 1$ be the radial-projection exponent and put

$$\gamma = \frac{q-1}{q}, \quad p_0 = \frac{K+2\gamma}{K+\gamma}.$$

The conclusion holds for every

$$1 < p < \min\{p_0, 1 + \epsilon_{\text{reg}}/2\}. \quad (93)$$

Proof. At each frequency fix the finite regularization, its components, and all spatial chains before changing any deletion thresholds. Let Ω_R be the union of the retained pin components. With $L(1), H_{i,j}(1)$ the original thresholds in (24), use

$$L(\Lambda) = L(1)\Lambda^{1/q}, \quad H_{i,j}(\Lambda) = H_{i,j}(1)\Lambda, \quad \Lambda \geq 1. \quad (94)$$

The source-heavy mass estimate (22) changes by the factor $\Lambda^{(1-q)/q} = \Lambda^{-\gamma}$. In (23), the ratio of source and pin thresholds changes by $\Lambda^{1/q-1} = \Lambda^{-\gamma}$. Thus both deletion contributions acquire the same factor. The source-heavy directions still serve only as an auxiliary estimate; no new source cutoff is introduced.

There is one pin-threshold factor in each Fourier inflation step. Consequently the squared good-shell estimate changes by at most Λ^K . Write

$$F_R(y, t) = \frac{d(d_y)_*(P_R\mu)}{dt}$$

for the full smooth annular density. On Ω_R , the construction therefore supplies a decomposition

$$\begin{aligned} F_R \mathbf{1}_{\Omega_R} &= G_{R,\Lambda} + B_{R,\Lambda}, & \|G_{R,\Lambda}\|_2^2 &\leq CR^{-\kappa}\Lambda^K, \\ \|B_{R,\Lambda}\|_1 &\leq CR^{-c}\Lambda^{-\gamma} + \text{RapDec}(R), & c &> 0. \end{aligned} \quad (95)$$

Here and below the norms are on the joint pin-distance space. The component weights sum to at most one, so there is no component-count loss.

For precision, these bounds are uniform when $1 \leq \Lambda \leq R^M$, for any fixed M , after choosing sufficiently high orders in the localization estimates. All thresholds select subsets of the same fixed standard packet family. Its size and its global derivative bounds are polynomial in R , uniformly over the subset. The initial reconstruction, inherited identities, and selected-label embedding are unchanged. The extra products of thresholds amplify an error by at most R^{MK} . Arbitrarily high integration-by-parts decay absorbs this and every other fixed polynomial factor. Thus the error order can be chosen after M ; there is no requirement of uniformity for superpolynomial thresholds. Any residual rapid term in the good estimate is likewise absorbed in its displayed main bound.

The entire annular multiplier has a uniformly bounded first kernel norm. Pushforward contracts total variation, uniformly in the pin. Its spatial kernel has supremum at most $C_T R^2$. The source

cutoff is fixed, and the radii under consideration lie in a fixed bounded interval. Integration of that bounded spatial density over a circle proves

$$\sup_y \|F_R(y, \cdot)\|_1 \leq C_T, \quad \|F_R\|_\infty \leq C_T R^2. \quad (96)$$

In particular the joint first norm of $F_R \mathbf{1}_{\Omega_R}$ is uniformly bounded.

Choose once and for all

$$M > \frac{2 + \kappa}{K + \gamma} + 1.$$

The finite parameter range in Lemma 8.1, with $A = CR^{-\kappa}$, is then contained in $[1, R^M]$ for large R . Choose the rapid-error first norm in (95) at most $R^{-M\gamma-1}$. Throughout the needed parameter range it is bounded by $\Lambda^{-\gamma}$. Applying the lemma, with fixed constants absorbed, gives

$$\|F_R \mathbf{1}_{\Omega_R}\|_{p_0, \infty} \leq CR^{-\kappa\gamma/(K+2\gamma)}. \quad (97)$$

The discarded pins have to be treated separately. The good function is zero there at every threshold, so their contribution does not gain a factor $\Lambda^{-\gamma}$. Their measure and (96) instead give

$$\|F_R \mathbf{1}_{\Omega_R^c}\|_1 \leq CR^{-\epsilon_{\text{reg}}}, \quad \|F_R \mathbf{1}_{\Omega_R^c}\|_\infty \leq CR^2.$$

For $p > 1$, bound $p - 1$ factors of the integrand by its supremum and integrate the remaining factor. This yields

$$\|F_R \mathbf{1}_{\Omega_R^c}\|_p \leq C_p R^{[2(p-1)-\epsilon_{\text{reg}}]/p}. \quad (98)$$

For p in (93), use (91) on the common bounded radial support in (97), and add (98). We obtain

$$\begin{aligned} \|F_R\|_p &\leq C_p R^{-c_p}, \\ c_p &= \min \left\{ \frac{\kappa\gamma}{K + 2\gamma}, \frac{\epsilon_{\text{reg}} - 2(p-1)}{p} \right\} > 0. \end{aligned} \quad (99)$$

The annular frequencies form a geometric sequence, so the shell norms are summable. The series, including the smooth low-frequency density, converges in L^p , hence in L^1 on the bounded joint support.

To identify the limit, test against a smooth function $\Phi(y, t)$. The spatial test

$$x \mapsto \chi(x) \int \Phi(y, |x - y|) d\nu(y)$$

is smooth and compactly supported because the source cutoff is separated from the pin support. Distributional reconstruction of the annular multipliers and first-norm convergence show that the limit is the joint distance law. It is therefore a nonnegative density. Disintegration and Fubini give the asserted almost-everywhere pinned conclusion. $\square$

The exponent in this theorem depends on the regularization choices as well as on q and K . In particular, the weak exponent p_0 proved for the retained pin region is not automatically the exponent of the full law: the discarded region imposes the second restriction in (93).

8.3 The frequency threshold is unchanged

Before using strictness, the leading squared good-shell factor is

$$A_R = R^{C-(s-1)+\eta}, \quad \eta > 0.$$

Lemma 8.1 raises this factor to a positive power. The sign of its exponent is unchanged. Thus the present interpolation closes under the same condition $\mathcal{C} < s - 1$.

The abstract estimate is sharp in its dependence on A . For $A \geq 1$, take $F_A = A\mathbf{1}_{[0,1/A]}$. Its first norm is one and its squared second norm is A . Choosing the entire function as the good part and zero as the bad part satisfies every hypothesis of the decomposition lemma, whereas

$$\|F_A\|_{p_0, \infty}^{p_0} = A^{p_0-1} = A^{\gamma/(K+\gamma)}.$$

This obstructs a better power from those hypotheses alone. It does not exclude a different subquadratic estimate using additional geometry.

For comparison, a single-threshold decomposition with $\|B_H\|_1 \leq J/H$ and $\|G_H\|_2^2 \leq HE$, $H \geq J$, gives $p_0 = 3/2$ by putting $\Lambda = H/J$. Its decisive factor is $A = JE$, so even this favorable case retains the original frequency sign.

8.4 A limitation of higher pin-tube moments

There is a similarly precise limitation to using higher moments estimated only by the maximum tube mass. Consider an ideal regular edge from depth n to depth $m < n$, and put

$$\ell = n - m, \quad \rho = 2^{-\ell}, \quad c = g(m) - \min_{[m,n]} g, \quad d_* = \min\{\ell, \ell + g(m) - g(n)\}.$$

Let λ be the normalized parent pin probability. A tube can be covered by $O(\rho^{-1})$ child-scale cubes. Regularity, together with the trivial mass bound, gives

$$\frac{\max_T \lambda(T)}{\rho} \lesssim 2^{d_*}.$$

The pair bound gives $J_2 = \sum_T \lambda(T)^2 \lesssim 2^c$. For $r \geq 2$, writing $M = \max_T \lambda(T)$, one has

$$\sum_T \lambda(T)^r \leq M^{r-2} J_2.$$

On a retained direction the source mass is at most $CL\rho$. The higher-moment replacement in the heavy-tube calculation is therefore

$$\text{BadMass} \lesssim L\rho(H\rho)^{1-r} \sum_T \lambda(T)^r \lesssim LH^{-(r-1)} 2^{c+(r-2)d_*}.$$

To get a small bad mass, this uses the base threshold exponent

$$c_r = \frac{c + (r-2)d_*}{r-1}.$$

Both entries defining d_* are at least c . The first follows from the Lipschitz bound. If z is a minimum point on the edge, then

$$\ell + g(m) - g(n) - c = \ell + g(z) - g(n) \geq \ell - (n - z) \geq 0.$$

Consequently $c_r \geq c$. The improved tail power is accompanied by a base inflation exponent no smaller than before. The finite regularization and geometric enlargement errors add the previously accounted small powers; they do not reverse this comparison. This limits this particular use of higher moments, not every possible higher-moment argument.

8.5 Strong integrability for the coherent branch

The other analytic branch also admits an integrability improvement. Unlike the frequency argument, this follows from the positive affine approximations.

Proposition 8.3. *Let μ, ν be probabilities on positively separated compact planar sets. Suppose μ is s -Frostman, its occupied-square count is $O(r^{-u})$, and ν has a Frostman exponent greater than one, where $1 < s \leq 2$ and $s \leq u < 2s - 1$. Let $q > 1$ be the averaged angular exponent in the coherent center construction. Put*

$$\eta = \frac{q-1}{2q-1}, \quad \delta = 2s-1-u.$$

The joint law of $(y, |x-y|)$ under $\mu \times \nu$ has a density in $L^p(d\nu dt)$ for every

$$1 < p < \left(1 - \eta \frac{\delta}{s}\right)^{-1}. \quad (100)$$

Proof. Set $v = 2 - 1/q$ and $q' = q/(q-1)$, so $v-1 = 1/q'$ and $(v-1)/v = \eta$. Retain the chosen centers and positive densities f_n from Section 2. For each occupied square Q at scale $r = 2^{-n}$, let $a_Q(y, t)$ be its conditional affine density, and let $h_Q(\theta, t)$ be the orthogonal projection density before translation in the scalar variable. The source weights and angular densities satisfy

$$p_Q = \mu(Q), \quad \mu_Q = p_Q^{-1} \mu|_Q, \quad F_Q = \|\rho_{x_Q}\|_q^q, \quad \sum_Q p_Q F_Q \leq 2B.$$

Probability interpolation and then angular Hölder give

$$\int |h_Q(\theta, t)|^v dt \leq \|h_Q(\theta, \cdot)\|_2^{2(v-1)}, \quad \|a_Q\|_v^v \leq C F_Q^{1/q} I_1(\mu_Q)^{1/q'}.$$

For the second inequality, use the angular pin law $\rho_{x_Q}(\theta) d\theta$, the equality $(v-1)q' = 1$, and the projection-energy identity. The pin-dependent translation preserves each scalar norm. The source Frostman bound inside Q gives $I_1(\mu_Q) \leq C r^{s-1}/p_Q$. Since $f_n = \sum_Q p_Q a_Q$, convexity and Hölder over the at most $C r^{-u}$ occupied squares yield

$$\begin{aligned} \|f_n\|_v^v &\leq C r^{(s-1)/q'} \sum_Q (p_Q F_Q)^{1/q} \leq C B^{1/q} r^{(s-1-u)/q'}, \\ \|f_n\|_v &\leq C r^{-A\eta}, \quad A = u + 1 - s > 0. \end{aligned} \quad (101)$$

No lower bound on an individual square mass was used.

Choose $0 < \gamma < \min\{1/2, (s-1)/2\}$ with $\tau = s-u+2\gamma > 0$. The optimized coherent comparison and the covering estimate in Proposition 2.4 give

$$\|f_{n+1} - f_n\|_1 \leq C r^{\tau\eta}, \quad \|f_{n+1} - f_n\|_v \leq C r^{-A\eta}.$$

For $1 < p < v$, set $\vartheta = (v-p)/(p(v-1))$, so $1/p = \vartheta + (1-\vartheta)/v$. Hölder interpolation gives

$$\|f_{n+1} - f_n\|_p \leq C r^{\eta[\tau\vartheta - A(1-\vartheta)]}.$$

The exponent is positive exactly when

$$p < \frac{v(\tau + A)}{\tau + vA} = \frac{v(1 + 2\gamma)}{s - u + 2\gamma + v(u + 1 - s)}.$$

Letting γ approach $(s-1)/2$ from below makes this upper bound tend to

$$\frac{vs}{\delta + v(s-\delta)} = \left(1 - \eta \frac{\delta}{s}\right)^{-1}.$$

Thus every p in (100) admits a fixed legal γ giving summable dyadic differences in L^p . The common pin-distance region has finite measure, and an initial approximation has finite v -norm by (101). Consequently f_n converges in L^p and L^1 . The uniform affine approximation to distance identifies this limit with the raw positive joint distance law, as in Theorem 2.3. $\square$

Theorem 8.4 (A stronger conclusion under the same dimension curve). *Under the hypotheses of Theorem 1.1, there are separated compact source and pin subsets of E , carrying probabilities μ, ν , and an exponent $p > 1$, such that the raw joint distance law has a density $f \in L^p(d\nu dt)$. In particular $(d_y)_*\mu$ has an L^p density for ν -almost every pin.*

Proof. In the coherent case, use the same strict Frostman and covering exponent choices and separated compact restrictions as in Proposition 2.5, followed by Proposition 8.3. In the other case, retain the strict profile-cost margin and compact restrictions in the proof of Theorem 1.1, and apply the preceding subquadratic frequency argument. Both give a strong exponent greater than one for the actual joint law. Fubini and its probability disintegration give the final assertion. No uniform exponent as the strict margin tends to zero is claimed. $\square$

This also gives a quantitative length statement for a positive proportion of the selected pins. If $M = \int \int f(y, t)^p dt d\nu(y)$, then pins in a set of ν -measure at least $1/2$ satisfy

$$|\Delta_y(E)| \geq (2M)^{-1/(p-1)}.$$

Indeed Markov bounds $\int f(y, t)^p dt$ by $2M$ on such a pin set, and Hölder applied to a density of mass one proves the lower bound. This improves integrability, not the dimensional cutoff or its strict endpoints.

9 Positive selection: a valid target and a finite-model gain

This section distinguishes two positive-selection targets. Vanishing total loss and a uniform bound for the full retained collision law would force the original joint law into L^2 , which is false for some prescribed Frostman probabilities. Retaining a fixed positive mass is sufficient for the desired distance conclusion. Persistent deletion is one possible implementation; nesting is not required. We then prove a sharper transverse estimate for the finite train-track test family. No improved dimension-only distance criterion follows without an additional geometric argument.

9.1 The compactness distinction

Let μ, ν be compactly supported planar probabilities and $\varphi \geq 0$ a smooth compactly supported probability on $\mathbb{R}$. Write $\varphi_\epsilon(t) = \epsilon^{-1}\varphi(t/\epsilon)$ and

$$\Lambda(dy, dt) = \nu(dy)(d_y)_*\mu(dt).$$

A positive interaction selection is a measurable kernel $\eta_{j,y} \leq \mu$. For $\epsilon_j \downarrow 0$, put

$$F_j(y, t) = \varphi_{\epsilon_j} * (d_y)_*\eta_{j,y}(t).$$

All radial supports lie in one fixed bounded interval for sufficiently large j . Fix an exponent $1 < q < \infty$, independently of j .

Proposition 9.1 (Positive-mass compactness). *Suppose $\sup_j \|F_j\|_{L^q(d\nu dt)} < \infty$. If*

$$\int \eta_{j,y}(\mathbb{R}^2) d\nu(y) \geq m_0 > 0,$$

then Λ has an absolutely continuous submeasure of mass at least m_0 , with density in $L^q(d\nu dt)$. Consequently a positive- ν family of pins has positive-length distances from $\text{supp } \mu$.

If, more strongly,

$$\int (1 - \eta_{j,y}(\mathbb{R}^2)) d\nu(y) \longrightarrow 0,$$

then the entire joint law Λ has an $L^q(d\nu dt)$ density.

Proof. Pass to a weakly convergent subsequence in the reflexive space $L^q(d\nu dt)$, with limit F . Positivity passes to the limit. All bounded test functions used below belong to the dual space on the fixed finite joint support. Testing against the indicator of an interval containing all radial supports shows $\int F d\nu dt \geq m_0$. The selected mollified laws are dominated by the full mollifications of Λ . Testing against any nonnegative continuous compactly supported function and taking the limit gives

$$F d\nu dt \leq \Lambda.$$

Disintegration gives $F(y, t)dt \leq (d_y)_*\mu$ for ν -almost every y . It is nonzero on a positive- ν set of pins and supported on the corresponding compact distance sets. Those sets therefore have positive Lebesgue measure.

Under the stronger hypothesis, the total variation difference between the selected and full mollified joint laws is at most the averaged deleted mass: convolution and pushforward contract total variation. This tends to zero. Full mollifications converge weakly to Λ , so the same test functions identify $F d\nu dt = \Lambda$. $\square$

Remark 9.2 (A false dimension-only extension). For $1 < s < 4/3$ and $3 - 2/s \leq u \leq 2$, the detailed companion [off-cluster collision note](#) constructs fixed separated probabilities with uniform s -Frostman and u -covering bounds whose fully mollified joint squared L^2 norms diverge along a sequence. Their support has Hausdorff and packing dimensions both s . A variant also has finite energy at the stated Frostman exponent.

The construction uses scaled train-track blocks with

$$\lambda_j = c2^{-j}, \quad \delta_j = 2^{-(j+j_0)^2}, \quad w_j \asymp \lambda_j^s, \quad \epsilon_j \asymp \lambda_j \delta_j,$$

and gives the positive collision lower bound

$$c\lambda_j^{3s-1}\delta_j^{3s/2-2} \longrightarrow \infty.$$

The uniform Frostman, covering, gluing, and collision proofs are supplied in that companion note; this finite construction is not reproduced here.

For this fixed pair, no positive selection with total deleted mass tending to zero can have uniformly bounded full-law collision norms, even along an arbitrary sequence of resolutions tending to zero. Otherwise Proposition 9.1, with $q = 2$, would put the original joint law in L^2 , and Young's convolution inequality would bound all its mollified norms, contradicting the displayed divergence. Thus a candidate asserting this conclusion for every prescribed pair is false for *any* vanishing deletion rate, not only a fast power rate. This is not an obstruction to positive-length distances.

The same distinction applies below exponent two. Section 5 of the [subquadratic transfer companion note](#) proves that the fixed train-track joint law has no weak L^q density whenever

$$q > \frac{2-s}{3-2s}, \quad 1 < s < 4/3.$$

It therefore cannot admit vanishing-loss selections uniformly bounded in strong L^q for such a fixed exponent, by Proposition 9.1. The cited construction and its quantitative weak-norm proof are not reproduced here. This supplies no obstruction for exponents sufficiently close to one.

A valid persistent implementation would choose discarded interaction sets $A_k \subset \text{supp } \mu \times \text{supp } \nu$ with

$$\sum_{k \geq k_0} (\mu \times \nu)(A_k) < 1$$

and retain

$$\eta_{j,y} = \mu|_{\{x:(x,y) \notin \bigcup_{k_0 \leq k \leq j} A_k\}}.$$

The mass stays uniformly positive. A uniform retained collision estimate would then suffice by Proposition 9.1. Such an estimate must use the accumulated selection: a uniform full-law bound after only a current-scale deletion whose mass vanishes would have the stronger, false consequence above.

For fixed measures, existence of a positive interaction restriction of positive mass with an L^2 joint distance density is equivalent to Λ having a nonzero absolutely continuous component. For the nontrivial direction, remove a null set carrying the singular part of Λ , truncate its remaining density to $0 < f \leq M$, and lift that restriction through $(y, x) \mapsto (y, |x - y|)$. A sufficiently large finite M retains positive mass with a bounded density. Allowing arbitrarily small *fixed* loss similarly characterizes absolute continuity; the L^2 constant may then deteriorate with the loss. The geometric construction of such a restriction is the substantive missing step.

9.2 The finite train-track model

Fix

$$1 < s < 4/3, \quad 3 - 2/s \leq u \leq 2, \quad \alpha = u - 1, \quad \beta = (s - 1)/2, \quad p = \beta/\alpha,$$

and, for small $\delta > 0$, put

$$a = \delta^p, \quad w = \delta^{1/2}, \quad h = \delta^{s/2}, \quad r_0 = h/w = \delta^\beta.$$

Thus $0 < \beta \leq p < 1/2$ and $a \gg w \gg h \gg \delta$. Take a maximal $3a$ -separated net $\{c_i\}_{i=1}^{N_T}$ in an α -Ahlfors regular subset of a fixed horizontal interval. With $m = N_T^{-1}$, standard disjoint-ball comparisons give

$$m \asymp a^\alpha = \delta^\beta, \quad \sum_{c_i \in J} m \leq C(|J|^\alpha + a^\alpha). \quad (102)$$

They also give a lower bound $c\rho^\alpha$ for track mass within radius ρ of any center when $C_0 a \leq \rho \leq c_0$, with fixed constants. This follows by covering the underlying regular set with net balls of radius $3a$ and comparing its regular mass with the upper mass of one ball.

In each track place $N_S \asymp h^{-1}$ slats at heights kh in a bounded interval. Each slat has $N_X \asymp w/\delta$ disjoint microscopic cells, with horizontal centers spaced by 4δ across width comparable to w . Each cell lies within $C\delta$ of its center and has mass $(N_T N_S N_X)^{-1} \asymp mh\delta/w$. Inside a cell use any compact probability supported there. Let μ_δ give equal mass to all cells and let ν_δ be its translate by $(0, 3)$, normalizing the vertical source interval so source–pin distances are bounded above and below. The regular microscopic tails giving the stated dimension and covering properties of the original example are one permitted choice. The following estimates only use the explicit geometry and counts just listed.

Lemma 9.3 (One-track estimate). *Fix a pin in the translated source region and a track at horizontal offset $r = |c_i - y_1| \gg w$. Its mollified pinned density f_i , at resolution $\epsilon \asymp \delta$, satisfies*

$$\|f_i\|_1 = m, \quad \|f_i\|_\infty \leq Cm(1 + r_0/r), \quad \|f_i\|_2 \leq Cm\sqrt{1 + r_0/r}.$$

Constants may depend on the fixed mollifier and resolution ratio.

Proof. Throughout the track the horizontal derivative of distance has constant sign and magnitude comparable to r . In one slat, a radial interval of width $C\delta$ therefore meets at most C/r cell centers. The slat contributes density at most $Cmh/(rw)$. Its whole radial image, after mollification, has length $O(rw + \delta)$, which is $O(rw)$ because $r \gg w$ and $w^2 = \delta$. Central radial values of successive slats are separated by at least ch , since vertical source–pin separation is bounded below. Thus at most $C(1 + rw/h)$ slats contribute at one radial value. Multiplication gives the asserted supremum bound, including when $rw < h$. Interpolation with the first norm proves the last bound. $\square$

Minkowski now gives, for any retained family of tracks with $r_i \gg w$,

$$\left\| \sum_i f_i \right\|_2 \leq C \left(1 + \sqrt{r_0} \sum_i m r_i^{-1/2} \right). \quad (103)$$

The source mass is at most one. Decomposing offsets into dyadic annuli and using (102), for $\rho \geq ca$, gives

$$\sum_{r_i \geq \rho} m r_i^{-1/2} \leq \begin{cases} C_\alpha \rho^{\alpha-1/2}, & \alpha < 1/2, \\ C \log(2/\rho), & \alpha = 1/2, \\ C_\alpha, & \alpha > 1/2. \end{cases} \quad (104)$$

Indeed each annulus contributes at most $C(2^j \rho)^{\alpha-1/2}$, and summing the geometric series gives these three cases.

Proposition 9.4 (A sharper positive finite-model selection). *If $u \geq 4/3$, deleting only the pin's own source track gives uniformly bounded mollified L^2 densities, with lost mass $m \asymp \delta^\beta$. If $u < 4/3$, deleting tracks at offsets less than a sufficiently large constant times*

$$\rho_* = r_0^{1/(1-2\alpha)}$$

gives uniformly bounded mollified L^2 densities, with lost mass at most $C\delta^{\alpha\beta/(1-2\alpha)}$. For the particular rule deleting only the own track, the transition $u = 4/3$ is exact: below it the retained averaged squared L^2 norm diverges, including its off-cell contribution.

Proof. After own-track deletion, the other offsets are at least $ca \gg w$. For $1/3 \leq \alpha < 1/2$, the potential factor in (103) is bounded because

$$\sqrt{r_0}a^{\alpha-1/2} = \delta^{\beta(3/2-1/(2\alpha))} \leq 1.$$

There is no logarithmic loss at $\alpha = 1/3$. At $\alpha = 1/2$, use boundedness of $\sqrt{r_0} \log(2/a)$; for $\alpha > 1/2$, use the constant bound in (104).

When $\alpha < 1/3$, one has $\rho_* \gg a \gg w$, and $\sqrt{r_0}\rho_*^{\alpha-1/2} = 1$. The same estimates give the norm bound, while (102) gives the removed mass $C\rho_*^\alpha$.

For the converse concerning own-track deletion, Ahlfors regularity and maximality of the net provide a different center at distance between $3a$ and Ca from each center. Indeed, for large fixed C , regular mass in the ball of radius Ca exceeds that in the ball of radius $6a$; a net point within $3a$ of a point in the difference is a suitable neighbor. A pin in the original track is therefore at offset comparable to a from a retained neighboring track. The latter's mollified radial support has length at most CN_Saw . Its mass is m , so Cauchy–Schwarz and positivity give

$$\|f_y^{\text{retained}}\|_2^2 \geq c \frac{m^2 h}{aw} \asymp \delta^{3\beta-p}.$$

The exponent $3\beta - p = \beta(3 - 1/\alpha)$ is negative exactly when $\alpha < 1/3$. Finally the same-cell contribution is at most

$$C\delta^{-1} \sum_{A \text{ cell}} \mu_\delta(A)^2 \lesssim \delta^{s-1} \longrightarrow 0,$$

since each cell has mass comparable to δ^s . The divergent remainder therefore comes from distinct cells. $\square$

9.3 A necessary deletion budget below the transition

The pinwise sufficient budget above differs from the following necessary one. For $\alpha < 1/3$, any positive selection with averaged squared L^2 norm bounded by a fixed C must delete average mass at least

$$c_C \delta^{2\alpha\beta/(1-\alpha)}. \tag{105}$$

Here is the proof. At offsets $ca \leq r_i \leq \rho$, with $\rho \gg a$, the initial track mass is at least $c\rho^\alpha$, and the number of tracks is at most $C\rho^\alpha/m$. If q_i is the retained mass of track i , its radial support has length at most $CN_S r_i w$; hence its squared norm is at least $cr_0 q_i^2 / r_i$. Positivity, weighted Cauchy–Schwarz, and a total deleted mass r_y at the pin give

$$\|f_y^{\text{retained}}\|_2^2 \geq cr_0 m \rho^{-1-\alpha} (c\rho^\alpha - r_y)_+^2.$$

Average and use Jensen. If the averaged deletion is at most $(c/2)\rho^\alpha$, the averaged norm is at least $c'r_0 m \rho^{\alpha-1}$. Choose $\rho = A_C(r_0 m)^{1/(1-\alpha)}$, with $A_C > 0$ fixed and small enough to exceed the

proposed norm bound. This radius still satisfies $\rho \gg a$ for small δ , precisely because $\alpha < 1/3$. The deletion must therefore exceed $(c/2)\rho^\alpha$, proving (105).

The pinwise sufficient and averaged necessary exponents agree at $\alpha = 1/3$, but not below it. The next subsection closes this gap for the averaged norm by using the common vertical slats. It does not assert a matching uniform bound at every pin. More substantially, the finite-model proof uses slat ordering, transverse radial derivatives, and explicit counts absent from dimension data alone. A dimension-only construction of positive-mass good interactions with a corresponding retained collision estimate remains unproved. The compactness criterion identifies a valid target; it does not supply that geometric input.

9.4 Sharp deletion order after averaging the pin slats

The preceding half-potential estimate is uniform at every pin. Averaging over the actual deterministic vertical pin slats allows a smaller deletion below $u = 4/3$. The result here concerns the same finite family, including arbitrary probabilities inside its microscopic cells. No random shifts or equidistribution of phases are assumed.

Theorem 9.5 (Sharp averaged finite-model selection). *Assume the finite model of Section 9.2, with $0 < \alpha < 1/3$, and mollify at any fixed resolution $\epsilon \asymp \delta$. For $Ca \leq \rho \leq r_0$, retain, at a pin in track j , exactly the source tracks satisfying $|c_i - c_j| \geq \rho$. Let f_y be the resulting mollified pinned density. The deleted source mass is at most $C\rho^\alpha$, and*

$$\int \|f_y\|_2^2 d\nu_\delta(y) \leq C(1 + mr_0\rho^{\alpha-1}). \quad (106)$$

The constants are independent of δ and ρ . Consequently the cutoff

$$\rho_{\text{opt}} = (mr_0)^{1/(1-\alpha)} \asymp r_0^{2/(1-\alpha)} \quad (107)$$

gives a uniformly bounded averaged squared L^2 norm with deleted mass at most

$$C(mr_0)^{\alpha/(1-\alpha)} \asymp C\delta^{2\alpha\beta/(1-\alpha)}. \quad (108)$$

This is the optimal order, up to constants depending on the norm bound, for arbitrary positive selections with bounded averaged squared norm, by the necessary estimate (105).

Proof. Fix a pin track j and use the center-to-center offsets $r_i = |c_i - c_j|$. Pins in its slat ℓ are within $O(w)$ horizontally and $O(\delta)$ vertically of $(c_j, 3 + \ell h)$. For every retained track $r_i \geq \rho \gg w$, put

$$t_{i,k,\ell} = \sqrt{r_i^2 + (3 + (\ell - k)h)^2}.$$

The cell count of Lemma 9.3 gives the uniform slat envelope

$$f_{i,y}(t) \leq C \frac{mh}{r_i w} \sum_k \mathbf{1}_{\{|t - t_{i,k,\ell}| \leq Cr_i w\}} \quad (y \text{ in pin track } j, \text{ slat } \ell). \quad (109)$$

To verify uniformity in the microscopic pin position, changing either horizontal coordinate by $O(w)$ changes distance by $O(r_i w + w^2) = O(r_i w)$. Vertical cell errors and mollification add $O(\delta)$, which is absorbed since $\delta = w^2$. The horizontal radial derivative has magnitude comparable to r_i , so at most C/r_i cells in a source slat contribute at one radial value. Their masses are $\asymp mh\delta/w$ and the mollifier's supremum is $O(\delta^{-1})$, proving the displayed amplitude. This argument does not condition the vertical slat distribution on the exact horizontal coordinate of a pin.

Tracks with $r_i \geq r_0$ have total density bounded pointwise by a constant, using Lemma 9.3 and the comparison of center offsets with actual offsets. Their total mass is at most one. They

contribute only a constant to the squared norm, including their cross term with the remaining tracks. It suffices to handle $\rho \leq r_i \leq r_0$.

We first prove the following conditional averaged cross-track estimate. For two such tracks, write $r = r_i \leq R = r_{i'} \leq r_0$ and $\Delta = R^2 - r^2$. Then

$$\frac{1}{m} \int_y \min_{\text{pin track } j} \int f_{i,y}(t) f_{i',y}(t) dt d\nu_\delta(y) \leq C m^2 \left(1 + \frac{r_0}{R} \mathbf{1}_{\{\Delta \leq CRw\}}\right). \quad (110)$$

The second term explicitly retains possible coherent equal-radius resonances.

Multiply the envelopes (109). An intersection of their radial intervals has length at most Crw , and is empty unless the centers are within CRw . Each pin slot has conditional mass $1/N_S$, so the left side of (110) is at most

$$C \frac{m^2 h^2}{Rw} \frac{1}{N_S} \sum_\ell \sum_{k,k'} \mathbf{1}_{\{|t_{i,k,\ell} - t_{i',k',\ell}| \leq CRw\}}. \quad (111)$$

The use of a supremum within each pin slot justifies this estimate for arbitrary microscopic cell probabilities.

Put $q = k' - k$ and $V = 3 + (\ell - k)h$. Both V and $V - qh$ lie in the fixed positive range of vertical source–pin separations. Squaring the two central radii, their collision condition implies exactly

$$|\Delta - qh(2V - qh)| \leq CRw. \quad (112)$$

If $q = 0$, this requires $\Delta \leq CRw$. There are at most N_S pairs $k = k'$ per pin slot. Their contribution to (111) is at most

$$C \frac{m^2 h^2}{Rw} N_S \mathbf{1}_{\{\Delta \leq CRw\}} \leq C m^2 \frac{r_0}{R} \mathbf{1}_{\{\Delta \leq CRw\}}.$$

Now fix $q \neq 0$ and k . Increasing ℓ by one changes the expression inside the absolute value in (112) by exactly $-2qh^2$. Thus at most

$$C \left(1 + \frac{Rw}{|q|h^2}\right)$$

pin slots can satisfy it. Any possible shift also obeys

$$|q|h \leq C(\Delta + Rw) \leq C(R^2 + Rw), \quad (113)$$

because $2V - qh = V + (V - qh)$ is bounded below by a positive constant. In particular

$$\frac{|q|h^2}{Rw} \leq C(Rr_0 + h) \leq C.$$

This absorbs the discrete counting error one. Since $N_S \asymp h^{-1}$, the fraction of pin slots satisfying the condition for each k, q is at most $CRw/(|q|h)$. Sum over k , and substitute in (111); this shift contributes at most $Cm^2/|q|$.

The possible nonzero shifts have bounded harmonic sum. If $\Delta > C_1 Rw$, with a sufficiently large fixed C_1 , (112) forces $q > 0$ and

$$c\Delta \leq qh \leq C\Delta.$$

These integers lie in an interval of fixed multiplicative ratio, so $\sum 1/q \lesssim 1$, including when that interval meets one. If $\Delta \leq C_1 Rw$, then (113) and $Rw \leq r_0 w = h$ bound $|q|$ by a fixed constant. The same conclusion holds. Hence all nonzero shifts contribute at most Cm^2 , proving (110). This is a lattice count for the actual pin slots, with no random-phase assumption.

It remains to sum the exceptional term. Its condition implies

$$|r_i - r_{i'}| \leq Cw,$$

since $\Delta = (R-r)(R+r)$. For each fixed j, i , only $O(1)$ centers $c_{i'}$ satisfy this: they lie in intervals of length $O(w)$ around c_i or its reflection $2c_j - c_i$. The centers are $3a$ -separated and $w/a \rightarrow 0$. This counts exact reflected pairs as well as the diagonal $i' = i$. Their radii are comparable to r_i , because $r_i \gg w$.

The baseline terms in (110) sum to a constant, since $N_T m = 1$. The exceptional terms sum to at most

$$Cm^2 r_0 \sum_{r_i \geq \rho} r_i^{-1}.$$

Dyadic annuli and (102), with $\alpha < 1$, give

$$\sum_{r_i \geq \rho} m r_i^{-1} \leq C_\alpha \rho^{\alpha-1} \quad (\rho \geq Ca).$$

Thus the conditional averaged squared norm in pin track j is at most $C(1 + m r_0 \rho^{\alpha-1})$, uniformly in j . Averaging these conditional estimates with track masses m , and adding the far-track contribution, proves (106).

The removed mass is at most $C(\rho^\alpha + a^\alpha)$, hence at most $C\rho^\alpha$. For (107), use $m \asymp a^\alpha \asymp r_0$ to check

$$\rho_{\text{opt}}/a \asymp a^{(3\alpha-1)/(1-\alpha)} \rightarrow \infty, \quad \rho_{\text{opt}}/r_0 \asymp r_0^{(1+\alpha)/(1-\alpha)} \rightarrow 0.$$

The cutoff is therefore in the required range and makes $m r_0 \rho^{\alpha-1} = 1$. This proves (108); the necessary bound (105) proves its asserted sharp order. $\square$

The improvement in (108) concerns the joint pin-averaged norm. Proposition 9.4 supplies a larger deletion budget but a bound at *every* pin; no improved uniform pinwise bound is asserted here. The finite configuration varies with δ . Consequently this theorem alone cannot be inserted into Proposition 9.1, which requires restrictions of one fixed pair of measures across the sequence of resolutions. A persistent construction for a general fixed fractal measure remains a separate missing step; no dimension-only distance theorem follows from this finite-model result.

10 A fixed positive angular selection and near-source collisions

The following estimate uses angular geometry absent from the scalar profile. It does not by itself improve the dimension condition: the far-source estimate specified below remains a separate hypothesis.

Let μ, ν be compactly supported planar probabilities with $a_0 \leq |x - y| \leq b_0$ on their product support, where $a_0 > 0$. Assume $\mu(B(x, r)) \leq C_F r^s$, with $s > 1$. Write $\Theta_x(y) = (y - x)/|y - x|$, and suppose

$$(\Theta_x)_* \nu = \rho_x(\theta) d\theta, \quad B = \int \int_{S^1} \rho_x(\theta)^q d\theta d\mu(x) < \infty, \quad q > 1. \quad (114)$$

The densities are needed only for μ -almost every source point. They have a jointly measurable version by the Radon–Nikodym theorem on source space times the circle. If both Frostman exponents exceed one, the averaged radial-projection theorem supplies (114) after reducing to a common exponent [3, Theorem 3.7].

Fix $A \geq 1$, independently of every subsequent resolution, and set

$$a_A(x, y) = \mathbf{1}_{\{\rho_x(\Theta_x(y)) \leq A\}}, \quad \eta_y^A(dx) = a_A(x, y) d\mu(x).$$

Assign selection zero on the exceptional null set of source points. These are positive measurable kernels, and

$$\iint (1 - a_A) d\mu d\nu \leq BA^{1-q}, \quad (\Theta_x)_*(a_A(x, \cdot)\nu) \leq A d\theta. \quad (115)$$

Indeed, the first integral equals $\int \int_{\{\rho_x > A\}} \rho_x d\theta d\mu(x)$, and the second density is exactly $\rho_x \mathbf{1}_{\{\rho_x \leq A\}}$. Thus a sufficiently large fixed A retains positive total mass. The loss is fixed; it does not tend to zero as the resolution increases.

Proposition 10.1 (Positive near-source collision bound). *For $0 < \varepsilon < r \leq 1$, define*

$$\begin{aligned} \mathcal{C}_{\varepsilon, \leq r}^A = \varepsilon^{-1} \iiint \mathbf{1}_{\{|x-x'| \leq r\}} \mathbf{1}_{\{||x-y|-|x'-y|| \leq \varepsilon\}} \\ \cdot a_A(x, y) a_A(x', y) d\mu(x) d\mu(x') d\nu(y). \end{aligned}$$

Then

$$\mathcal{C}_{\varepsilon, \leq r}^A \leq CA(\varepsilon^{-1}r^{s+1} + r^{s-1}), \quad (116)$$

where C depends only on the standing geometric and Frostman data.

Proof. Pairs with $|x - x'| \leq \varepsilon$ contribute at most $\varepsilon^{-1} \int \mu(B(x, \varepsilon)) d\mu(x) \leq C_F \varepsilon^{s-1}$. The diagonal has zero product mass. For $u = |x - x'| > \varepsilon$, put $e = (x' - x)/u$, $\ell = |y - x|$, and $\theta = \Theta_x(y)$. The squared-distance identity

$$|x' - y|^2 - |x - y|^2 = u^2 - 2u\ell e \cdot \theta$$

shows that a collision forces

$$|e \cdot \theta| \leq C_{a_0, b_0}(u + \varepsilon/u).$$

This set of directions has arclength at most $C \min\{1, u + \varepsilon/u\}$. Drop the second selection factor, which is at most one, and use the first factor's angular domination in (115). The retained pin mass for this source pair is at most $CA(u + \varepsilon/u)$.

Frostman growth, with dyadic annuli for the second integral, gives

$$\int_{0 < |x-x'| \leq r} |x - x'| d\mu(x') \leq C_F r^{s+1}, \quad \int_{0 < |x-x'| \leq r} \frac{d\mu(x')}{|x - x'|} \leq C_s C_F r^{s-1}.$$

Integrate the preceding pin bound and divide by ε . The smallest-separation contribution is absorbed because $A \geq 1$ and $\varepsilon^{s-1} \leq r^{s-1}$. Both collision factors throughout came from the same positive kernel; no arbitrary source-pair selection was substituted for that kernel. $\square$

At the parabolic radius the estimate becomes

$$\mathcal{C}_{\varepsilon, \leq \sqrt{\varepsilon}}^A \leq CA\varepsilon^{(s-1)/2}. \quad (117)$$

More generally, for fixed $1/(s+1) < \alpha < 1$ and $\kappa = \min\{\alpha(s+1) - 1, \alpha(s-1)\} > 0$,

$$\mathcal{C}_{\varepsilon, \leq \varepsilon^\alpha}^A \leq CA\varepsilon^\kappa. \quad (118)$$

These contributions are summable over dyadic resolutions. One may choose $\alpha < 1/2$, hence control clusters larger than the parabolic radius. No optimality of this cutoff is asserted.

Proposition 10.2 (The exact remaining far-source criterion). *Choose A with $m_0 = 1 - BA^{1-q} > 0$, and α as above. Define $\mathcal{C}_{\varepsilon, > r}^A$ by replacing $|x - x'| \leq r$ in Proposition 10.1 by $|x - x'| > r$, keeping both weights unchanged. If some sequence $\varepsilon_j \rightarrow 0$ satisfies*

$$\sup_j \mathcal{C}_{\varepsilon_j, > \varepsilon_j^\alpha}^A < \infty, \quad (119)$$

then $\nu(dy)(d_y)_ \eta_y^A(dt)$ has an $L^2(d\nu dt)$ density and mass at least m_0 . In particular a positive- ν set of pins has positive-length distance sets from $\text{supp } \mu$.*

Proof. Take a nonnegative smooth mollifier of integral one supported in $[-1/2, 1/2]$. The squared norm of its ε -smoothing of the selected radial law is at most a fixed constant times the full collision integral of width ε . Split into its near and far portions and apply (118) and (119). Weak compactness in the joint L^2 space and weak convergence of mollifications of the fixed positive measure identify its density. Equation (115) gives the retained mass, and disintegration and Cauchy–Schwarz give the distance conclusion. $\square$

Only (116) is supplied here by angular geometry. The far hypothesis is not deduced from dimensions. It concerns a fixed positive pair restriction, unlike the false vanishing-total-loss raw collision target. Estimating pin mass radially within the angular bands in the proof is the additional geometric input still required.

10.1 A conditional estimate using perpendicular bisectors

The following criterion retains the positions of source pairs, which are absent from the scale profile. Its mixed-norm hypothesis is not deduced from Hausdorff and packing dimensions here. In particular it is not a new dimensional sufficient condition.

Let μ, ν be compactly supported positive measures with $I_1(\mu) < \infty$ and $I_\tau(\nu) < \infty$, where $1 < \tau < 2$. For $x \neq x'$, define

$$\theta(x, x') = \frac{x - x'}{|x - x'|}, \quad c(x, x') = \frac{|x|^2 - |x'|^2}{2|x - x'|}.$$

Their perpendicular bisector has equation $y \cdot \theta = c$. The finite measure on oriented line space

$$\mathcal{B}_\mu = (\theta, c)_* (|x - x'|^{-1} \mu(dx) \mu(dx'))$$

has total mass $I_1(\mu)$. We use ordinary angular arclength below.

Proposition 10.3 (Mixed-norm bisector criterion). *Suppose*

$$\mathcal{B}_\mu = b_\mu(\theta, c) d\theta dc, \quad \|b_\mu\|_{L_\theta^2 L_c^{2/\tau}} < \infty.$$

Then the actual joint distance law has an $L^2(\nu \times dt)$ density. Writing $\eta_y = (d_y)_ \mu$, one has*

$$\int \|\eta_y\|_2^2 d\nu(y) \leq C_{\tau, K} (\nu(\mathbb{R}^2)^2 + I_\tau(\nu))^{1/2} \|b_\mu\|_{L_\theta^2 L_c^{2/\tau}}, \quad (120)$$

where K is a compact set containing both supports. Positive source mass therefore gives positive distance length for almost every pin.

Proof. For almost every θ , let v_θ be the density of the linear projection of ν in direction θ . The Fourier projection identity and polar coordinates imply

$$\int \|v_\theta\|_{H^{(\tau-1)/2}(\mathbb{R})}^2 d\theta \leq C_\tau (\nu(\mathbb{R}^2)^2 + I_\tau(\nu)).$$

Indeed the high-frequency weight is $|\xi|^{\tau-2}$ in the plane; the bounded-frequency part is controlled by the mass. One-dimensional Sobolev embedding and the Hardy–Littlewood maximal inequality give, for $q = 2/(2 - \tau)$,

$$\|Mv_\theta\|_{L_\theta^2 L_c^q} \leq C_\tau (\nu(\mathbb{R}^2)^2 + I_\tau(\nu))^{1/2}. \quad (121)$$

Here M is the centered interval maximal operator and $q' = 2/\tau$.

Choose a nonnegative smooth compactly supported line mollifier φ_ε of integral one. Expanding its squared convolution norm bounds $\int \|\eta_y * \varphi_\varepsilon\|_2^2 d\nu(y)$ by

$$C\varepsilon^{-1} \iint \nu\{y : ||x - y| - |x' - y|| \leq C\varepsilon\} d\mu(x) d\mu(x').$$

All distances are bounded above on K , and

$$|x - y|^2 - |x' - y|^2 = 2|x - x'| (c(x, x') - \theta(x, x') \cdot y).$$

Thus the integrand is at most $C_K |x - x'|^{-1} Mv_\theta(c)$. The exceptional angular null set has zero weighted source-pair mass by the assumed density of $\mathcal{B}_\mu$. The source diagonal also has zero mass, because finite first energy excludes atoms. Consequently the smoothed squared norm is bounded by

$$C_K \int b_\mu(\theta, c) Mv_\theta(c) dc d\theta.$$

Apply Hölder with q', q in c , followed by Cauchy–Schwarz in θ and (121). This proves (120) uniformly in ε . Weak compactness in the joint L^2 space identifies an actual density by testing against compactly supported continuous functions. Disintegration gives the pinned statement. No separation of the two supports is needed. $\square$

For a smooth source density f , the bisector density has an exact reflection formula:

$$b_\mu(\theta, c) = \int_{\mathbb{R}^2} f(x) f(\mathcal{R}_{\theta, c} x) dx, \quad \mathcal{R}_{\theta, c} x = x + 2(c - x \cdot \theta)\theta. \quad (122)$$

To check the normalization, put $x = z + r\theta/2$, $x' = z - r\theta/2$, and $z = c\theta + u\theta^\perp$, with $r > 0$. The pair Jacobian r cancels the reciprocal separation. Changing r to twice the normal displacement and using evenness of the product converts the integral over positive displacements into the integral over the whole normal line. This gives (122) with no additional factor.

For an s -Frostman source, $s > 1$, a sufficient finite-resolution version is the uniform bound

$$\sup_{0 < \delta < 1} \left\| \int f_\delta(x) f_\delta(\mathcal{R}_{\theta, c} x) dx \right\|_{L_\theta^2 L_c^{2/\tau}} < \infty, \quad f_\delta = \mu * \psi_\delta,$$

with a fixed positive smooth compactly supported planar mollifier. The smoothed measures retain the Frostman bound, also at radii below δ . Their weighted near-diagonal mass is uniformly $O(r^{s-1})$. Away from the diagonal, the bisector map is continuous, so these measures converge weakly to $\mathcal{B}_\mu$. Reflexivity of the mixed-norm space proves the stated implication.

For example, at $d = 23/20$, $D = 3/2$, which lies outside the current cutoff $B_H(23/20) = 10/7$, choose a pin energy exponent $\tau = 9/8$. The source reflection norm would be $L_\theta^2 L_c^{16/9}$, paired with $L_\theta^2 L_c^{16/7}$ for pin projections. Proving the required reflection bound for a positive source restriction under these dimensions remains an open step in this approach. The criterion has a raw quadratic conclusion, so the earlier counterexamples forbid asserting its hypothesis for arbitrary Frostman measures.

11 What the sharpness statement does and does not establish

The next proposition concerns only the scale profiles and the specified edge-cost model. It shows that a better limiting cost in the high-slope region needs information beyond the two linear barriers and Lipschitz condition. A different analytic method or additional geometric information could still weaken the dimension condition.

11.1 A sharp unforced profile obstruction above slope one half

The following example establishes sharpness only within the elementary profile problem. It is not a planar set with a null distance set and does not establish a necessary Hausdorff–packing condition.

Proposition 11.1 (Exact single-collapse cost). *For $0 < a < b \leq 1$, let*

$$g(x) = \min\{bx, 1 + a - x\} \quad (0 \leq x \leq 1), \quad C = \frac{b - a}{1 + 2b}.$$

This is a 1-Lipschitz profile with $ax \leq g(x) \leq bx$. For $0 < \zeta < C$, the infimum of the costs of all admissible chains from $1 - \zeta$ to zero, with no forced intermediate endpoint, is exactly $C - \zeta$. An attaining chain has $O(1 + \log(1/\zeta))$ edges.

Proof. The two affine pieces meet at

$$p = \frac{1 + a}{1 + b}.$$

Their slopes are b and -1 , so the Lipschitz assertion holds. The lower barrier on the terminal piece follows from $1 + a - x - ax = (1 + a)(1 - x) \geq 0$, and all other barrier comparisons are immediate. Put

$$s = 1 - C = \frac{1 + a + b}{1 + 2b}, \quad q = 2s - 1 = \frac{1 + 2a}{1 + 2b}.$$

The assumption $a < b$ gives $q < p < s$.

Consider any chain, and its first edge from $n > s$ to an endpoint $u \leq s$. Every preceding edge lies on the terminal affine piece of slope -1 , so the preceding costs sum to $1 - \zeta - n$. If $u \geq p$, the crossing edge costs $n - u \geq n - s$. If $u < p$, admissibility gives $u \geq 2n - 1 > q$. Since the profile has only one peak, its minimum over the crossing interval is at an endpoint, and the crossing cost is

$$(bu - (1 + a - n))_+ \geq (1 + 2b)(n - s).$$

In either case, the total cost through this crossing edge is at least $C - \zeta$. All subsequent costs are nonnegative, proving the lower bound.

For attainment, double the complementary depth from $1 - \zeta$ down to s , shortening the last jump if needed. This portion lies on the terminal descending piece and costs exactly $C - \zeta$. The next edge $s \rightarrow q$ is admissible with equality and has zero cost, because

$$g(s) = 1 + a - s = \frac{b(1 + 2a)}{1 + 2b} = g(q),$$

and the profile is above this common value between the endpoints. On $[0, q]$, the profile is increasing, so all downward edges cost zero. Maximal admissible jumps finish at zero without further cost. Their number, together with the initial doubling part, has the stated logarithmic bound. $\square$

For $b \geq 1/2$, the limit C in this example matches the universal upper bound in Lemma 3.3. Thus the limiting universal profile constant is sharp in that range. The example remains valid for $b < 1/2$, where equality with the universal minimax is not asserted. When $a = b$, the profile is simply ax and all costs are zero.

At $a = 1/4$, $b = 1$, the example has peak $p = 5/8$, critical endpoints $s = 3/4$, $q = 1/2$, and limiting cost $1/4$. It therefore reaches the strict source-margin boundary at the full-packing dimension pair $d = 5/4$, $D = 2$. This obstructs a uniform improvement of this particular profile constant. It does not rule out a different analytic argument, additional geometric information, or a different finite-scale balance, and it supplies no distance-set counterexample.

Proving a weakest possible condition for actual distance sets would require a necessity argument or counterexamples to positive-length pinned distances. None is supplied here. In particular, the sharp profile at $a = 1/4, b = 1$ explains why this method reaches the five-quarters boundary without crossing it; it does not establish the optimal Falconer threshold.

12 What optimizing the finite start can achieve

The preceding minimax criterion uses chains whose initial point tends to one. One might instead optimize that initial point, including the corresponding localization loss. The following identity rules out an improvement by this particular modification; it does not rule out stronger Fourier estimates.

For a 1-Lipschitz function $g : [0, 1] \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$, retain the notation $\Phi_\zeta(g)$ for the infimum of admissible chain costs from $1 - \zeta$ to zero, and $\Phi_0(g) = \lim_{\zeta \downarrow 0} \Phi_\zeta(g)$. Define

$$I_\zeta(g) = \zeta + g(1 - \zeta) - g(1), \quad 0 < \zeta < 1.$$

The Lipschitz bound gives $0 \leq I_\zeta(g) \leq 2\zeta$.

Proposition 12.1 (Finite-start identity). *For every such profile,*

$$0 \leq \Phi_0(g) - \Phi_\zeta(g) \leq \text{Var}^-(g; [1 - \zeta, 1]) \leq \frac{1}{2} I_\zeta(g).$$

Consequently

$$\inf_{0 < \zeta < 1} (\Phi_\zeta(g) + I_\zeta(g)) = \Phi_0(g).$$

Proof. For $0 < n < n' < 1$, truncating a chain from n' when it crosses n preserves admissibility and decreases the crossing edge's cost. Thus the optimal cost is nondecreasing with its initial point. Conversely, successively replacing a current point $x > n$ by $\max\{n, 2x - 1\}$ gives a finite admissible bridge from n' to n : before the last step, $1 - x$ doubles. Each edge costs at most the negative variation on its interval. Appending an arbitrarily near-minimizing chain from n bounds the difference of optimal costs by $\text{Var}^-(g; [n, n'])$. This proves monotonicity, boundedness, and the first comparison on letting $n' \uparrow 1$.

A Lipschitz function is absolutely continuous and $-1 \leq g' \leq 1$ almost everywhere. Since $(-v)_+ \leq (1 - v)/2$ on that interval,

$$\text{Var}^-(g; [n, 1]) = \int_n^1 (-g')_+ \leq \frac{1}{2} \int_n^1 (1 - g') = \frac{1 - n + g(n) - g(1)}{2}.$$

It follows that $\Phi_\zeta + I_\zeta \geq \Phi_0 + I_\zeta/2 \geq \Phi_0$. Letting $\zeta \downarrow 0$ proves the reverse inequality for the infimum. $\square$

Here I_ζ is precisely the leading profile correction obtainable from the initial local-constancy argument. To see this, write $f(x) = x + g(x)$. At terminal depth N , suppose occupied terminal cubes have mass at most $2^{-f_N(N)}$, and an initial cube of depth n has mass at least $2^{-f_N(n) - eN}$. Localization at bandwidth 2^N contributes $2^{2N - f_N(N)}$. Converting the Lebesgue integral on the initial cube to its normalized average contributes 2^{-2n} , and division by its mass contributes at most $2^{f_N(n) + eN}$. The resulting exponent is

$$2(N - n) + f_N(n) - f_N(N) + eN.$$

For $n = (1 - \zeta)N$, its leading normalized part is $2\zeta + f(1 - \zeta) - f(1) = I_\zeta(g)$. Enlargements, grid errors, and regularization losses must still be added. Proposition 12.1 therefore applies even when this exact mass-profile correction replaces the coarser loss 2ζ . It is a limitation of that estimate, not a lower bound for all possible localization operators.

12.1 Why a zero shell exponent alone is insufficient

There are compact null-length subsets of the line with positive probability approximations whose mutually orthogonal quadratic increments are uniformly bounded. This elementary example clarifies an endpoint issue; it is not a planar distance-set counterexample.

Start with $E_0 = [0, 1]$. At step $j \geq 1$, subdivide every surviving interval into $j + 1$ equal pieces and retain the first j . Use closed intervals for the compact sets, ignoring endpoints in integrals. There are $j!$ intervals at stage j , each of length $\ell_j = 1/(j + 1)!$, and $|E_j| = 1/(j + 1)$. Put $p_j = (j + 1)\mathbf{1}_{E_j}$. These are probability densities and preserve the mass of each earlier interval. Their weak limit is a probability η on $E_\infty = \bigcap_j E_j$, which has length zero.

Direct computation gives

$$\|p_j\|_2^2 = j + 1, \quad \int p_j p_{j-1} = j, \quad \|p_j - p_{j-1}\|_2^2 = 1.$$

The increments are mutually orthogonal: each has integral zero on every earlier surviving interval, and the preceding increments are constant there. The limiting support even has Hausdorff dimension one. Indeed, each stage- j interval has mass $1/j!$. If $\ell_j \leq r < \ell_{j-1}$, an interval I of length r meets at most $r/\ell_j + 2$ stage- j grid cells, giving

$$\eta(I) \leq 3(j + 1)r.$$

For each fixed $0 < t < 1$, $(j + 1)\ell_{j-1}^{1-t} = (j + 1)(j!)^{-(1-t)}$ is bounded. Thus $\eta(I) \leq C_t r^t$, proving the dimension assertion.

Uniform bounds on individual quadratic increments therefore do not establish positive support length. These increments are not asserted to be Fourier annuli of a distance measure. An endpoint distance argument still needs stronger information, such as a uniformly bounded full positive approximation or another suitable nonconcentration estimate.

13 A local refined-decoupling terminal step

There is a natural way to insert the refined decoupling theorem of Guth–Iosevich–Ou–Wang [3, Theorem 4.2 and Corollary 4.3] into the preceding iteration. We prove the resulting estimate here. The following section shows that its optimized profile cost is already attainable by the quadratic chain; this particular insertion therefore does not improve the dimension cutoff.

Lemma 13.1 (Weighted local packet estimate). *Let $r \gg 1$, $\rho = r^{-1/2}$, and let F_θ have Fourier support in the usual canonical rectangles over a circle of radius r : tangential width $O(\rho^{-1})$, normal width $O(1)$, and bounded angular overlap. Work in a bounded unit region. Form its usual smooth packets*

$$f_T = \chi \eta_{\theta,T} F_\theta,$$

where $\chi = 1$ on the pin region and the nonnegative transverse partitions $\eta_{\theta,T}$ sum to one for each θ . Let λ have mass at most one, with density at most D after positive smoothing at scale r^{-1} . Retain packets satisfying

$$\lambda(CT) \leq H\rho, \quad H \geq 1.$$

The dilation CT includes the usual small-power packet enlargement and adjacent ρ -cubes. For every fixed $\varepsilon > 0$,

$$\int \left| \sum_{T \text{ retained}} f_T \right|^2 d\lambda \lesssim_\varepsilon r^\varepsilon H^{2/3} D^{1/3} \sum_\theta \int_{Q^+} |F_\theta|^2 + \text{RapDec}(r). \quad (123)$$

As elsewhere, small-power enlargements, polynomial packet counts and polynomial bounds for the input norms are permitted; their losses are absorbed by r^ε .

Proof. Local constancy replaces λ by a positive smooth density $w \lesssim D$. Enlarging the test tubes also gives $\int_{C'T} w \lesssim H\rho$, up to rapid errors. Pigeonhole the packet sixth norms, and fix one comparable class of W packets. Let Y_M be a union of ρ -cubes each meeting between M and $2M$ packets. Weighted incidence counting gives

$$M \int_{Y_M} w \lesssim WH\rho.$$

Indeed every cube incident to a packet lies inside its enlarged test tube. No equal-mass assumption on these cubes is needed. Hölder and refined decoupling at exponent six now imply

$$\begin{aligned} \int_{Y_M} |f|^2 w &\leq \|f\|_{L^6(Y_M)}^2 \left(\int_{Y_M} w^{3/2} \right)^{2/3} \\ &\lesssim r^\varepsilon (M/W)^{2/3} \sum_T \|f_T\|_6^2 D^{1/3} \left(\int_{Y_M} w \right)^{2/3} \\ &\lesssim r^\varepsilon (H\rho)^{2/3} D^{1/3} \sum_T \|f_T\|_6^2. \end{aligned}$$

The frequency rectangle has area $O(\rho^{-1})$, so Bernstein gives $\|f_T\|_6^2 \lesssim \rho^{-2/3} \|f_T\|_2^2$. For each θ , bounded overlap of its spatial partition gives $\sum_T \|f_T\|_2^2 \lesssim \int_{Q^+} |F_\theta|^2$. The powers of ρ cancel. Summing the logarithmically many amplitude and incidence classes proves (123).

These are precisely the standard microlocal packets in the cited corollary. One may use compact smooth spatial cutoffs and their Schwartz Fourier tails. Alternatively, use nonnegative band-limited Schwartz transverse partitions and a common band-limited Schwartz majorant bounded below on the pin region; its lower bound controls the desired extension there. In this alternative equality to one is unnecessary. The usual small-power enlargements reduce all tails to arbitrary inverse powers, while frequency localization, Bernstein and spatial overlap acquire only small-power losses. Polynomial input norms and counts allow those errors to be summed. Tiny amplitude classes are discarded using Bernstein and the same polynomial count. $\square$

Fix one regularized component σ with profile f , and put $g(k) = f(k) - k$. For $R = 2^N$ and a parent depth m , set

$$b = 2^{-m}, \quad r = Rb, \quad n = \frac{N+m}{2}, \quad a = 2^{-n} = \sqrt{b/R}, \quad \rho = a/b = r^{-1/2}.$$

Block-grid rounding changes exponents by $O(T)$. We keep $m \leq (1 - \zeta)N$, with fixed $\zeta > 0$, so the local frequency is at least R^ζ . For an active parent P , put $\lambda_P = \sigma|_{P^+}/\sigma(P^+)$. The denominator is at least $\sigma(P)$. Thus the regular cube bounds, after rescaling by b^{-1} , give

$$D_P \lesssim_T R^{CT} 2^{2(N-m)+f(m)-f(N)} = R^{CT} 2^{(N-m)+g(m)-g(N)}. \quad (124)$$

The old truncated energy bound gives

$$J_{\lambda_P}(\rho) \lesssim_T (N+1) R^{CT} 2^{c_g(m,n)}, \quad c_g(m,n) = g(m) - \min_{[m,n]} g.$$

Choose $H = R^{D_2 h + CT} 2^{c_g(m,n)}$. Lemma 13.1 then costs

$$2^{\mathcal{T}_g(m)} R^{O(h+\Gamma)+\varepsilon}, \quad \mathcal{T}_g(m) = \frac{2c_g(m, (N+m)/2) + (N-m) + g(m) - g(N)}{3}. \quad (125)$$

This uses pin masses at the actual scale R^{-1} , without a first-cube localization loss.

A single source function for the whole shell. Fix the subsequent coarse chain from depth m to zero. Its inherited marks are constant on each depth- m parent P and are unions of whole original standard source labels S , of width $R^{-1/2}$. Write $A_{P,S} \in \{0,1\}$ for their survival indicators. Group these standard labels into nominal ancestors θ of width $\rho \geq R^{-1/2}$, and form

$$F_{P,\theta} = \sum_{S \prec \theta} A_{P,S} F_S.$$

Decompose these functions into local *pin-side* packets, retaining whole packets according to the conditional tube bound. Their selected partition sums

$$c_{P,\theta}(y) = \sum_{T \text{ mretained}} \eta_{\theta,T}(y) \quad \text{satisfy} \quad 0 \leq c_{P,\theta} \leq 1.$$

For $y \in P$, define

$$G_{R,y}(x) = \sum_S A_{P,S} c_{P,\theta(S)}(y) \chi(x) (\psi_{R,S} \hat{\mu})^\vee(x). \quad (126)$$

All angular grids, partitions, test tubes and coefficients are fixed using R , independently of the circular radius throughout the annulus. The canonical rectangles have the required dimensions uniformly for every radius comparable to R , with constants allowed to depend on its fixed annular ratio. Hence (126) is one source function for the entire shell. Its coefficients are independent of the distance variable, so for each fixed pin they commute with the pinned pushforward and circular identity. Its circular extension on P is, up to the existing source-cutoff error, exactly $\sum_{\theta, T \text{ mretained}} \eta_{\theta,T} F_{P,\theta}$.

For the discarded first norm, expand only the *original* unit-length standard source packets. A source-pin pair meets at most $R^{O(h)}$ such packets, regardless of how many standard labels are inside θ . Their directions lie within $O(R^{-1/2+h})$ of the connecting line. Since $R^{-1/2} \leq \rho$ and $b\rho = a$, a bad local pin tube implies the containing heavy tube in that connecting direction. The previous radial-projection deletion bound therefore applies, with contribution

$$\lesssim R^{O(h)} \left(L^{1-q} B R^\Gamma + \sum_P \sigma(P^+) \frac{L}{H} J_{\lambda_P}(\rho) \right)$$

plus the already controlled coarse-chain deletions and rapid errors. The old choice $L = R^{D_1 h}$, then sufficiently large D_2 , makes this a negative power of R . Short *source* packets would not justify this argument: after propagation their transverse footprint is ρ , not a . They have not been used here.

The remaining energy. The local selectors disappear from the right side of (123). It leaves precisely the local parent energy

$$\sum_{P \text{ mactive}} \sigma(P^+) \sum_{\theta: |\theta|=\rho} \int |F_{P,\theta}|^2 dm_{P^+}.$$

For the next quadratic inflation, each initial parent label θ is partitioned into descendants of width $(Rb)^{-1} = \rho^2 \leq \rho$. The inherited marks were fixed before the local packet selection, so the old exact inherited identity applies inside every θ ; no selector remains in this energy. Continuing the coarse chain and then the original final circle estimate gives total cost

$$\Phi_g(m) + \mathcal{T}_g(m). \quad (127)$$

Here $\Phi_g(m)$ denotes the cost of the chosen admissible chain from m to zero. At $m = 0$, (127) is $(N - g(N))/3$, which recovers the GIOW shell exponent $(5 - 4s)/3$ under the Frostman lower bound. The next result compares (127) with the fully optimized quadratic chain.

The weighted family below exponent six. The same packet-compatible construction allows the weighted theorem of Du–Ou–Ren–Zhang [4, Theorem 1.1(b)] to be used without throwing away its natural-scale gain. In unit parent coordinates, suppose the smoothed pin density satisfies $w \leq A$, and every ρ -square has pin mass at most v . Put

$$Q = \frac{rv}{A} \leq 1.$$

In large coordinates $X = rx$, the weight $w(X/r)/A$ lies in $[0, 1]$ and has mass at most r^2v/A on each $r^{1/2}$ -square. Taking $\alpha = 2 \log(r^2v/A)/\log r \leq 2$ in that theorem gives the squared weighted gain $Q^{2/p-1/3}$, for $2 \leq p \leq 6$. For one comparable packet class of cardinality W , Hölder with respect to $w dx$, followed by that theorem, yields

$$\int_Y |f|^2 w \lesssim r^\varepsilon A^{2/p} Q^{2/p-1/3} \left(\frac{M \int_Y w}{W} \right)^{1-2/p} \sum_T \|f_T\|_p^2.$$

The same incidence bound and the packet Bernstein estimate $\|f_T\|_p^2 \lesssim \rho^{-(1-2/p)} \|f_T\|_2^2$ therefore give multiplier

$$A^{2/p} Q^{2/p-1/3} H^{1-2/p} \quad (128)$$

for the local parent square function. All counts and small-power losses are handled as in Lemma 13.1.

Writing $L = N - m$, the leading profile exponents are

$$I = L + g(m) - g(N), \quad J = -L/2 + g(N) - g(n), \quad c = c_g(m, n),$$

$$A = 2^I, \quad v = 2^{-L/2+g(m)-g(n)}, \quad Q = 2^J, \quad H = 2^c.$$

Here $J \leq 0$ by the Lipschitz inequality between n and N . The block and regularization errors only add the usual arbitrarily small losses; enlarging A slightly also enforces $Q \leq 1$ when those errors are present. Thus the weighted terminal cost is

$$\mathcal{T}_{g,p}(m) = \frac{2}{p}I + \left(\frac{2}{p} - \frac{1}{3} \right) J + \left(1 - \frac{2}{p} \right) c. \quad (129)$$

At $p = 6$ this is (125). The comparison with other exponents and with optimized quadratic chains is purely a profile calculation, proved next. These statements concern the specific terminal construction just described, not all possible uses of refined or weighted decoupling.

13.1 An exact comparison for local decoupling terminal costs

This section concerns an abstract profile optimization. Its proof is purely geometric and does not use the preceding analytic estimate.

For any 1-Lipschitz $g : [0, 1] \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$, define

$$c_g(m, n) = g(m) - \min_{[m, n]} g.$$

An edge $n \rightarrow m < n$ is admissible when $2n - m \leq 1$. Let $\Phi_g(n)$ be the infimum of the costs of finite admissible chains from $n < 1$ to zero, and write $\Phi_g(1) = \lim_{n \uparrow 1} \Phi_g(n)$. The limit and the finite-chain properties used below are justified in the proof. For $0 \leq m < 1$, set

$$L = 1 - m, \quad n = \frac{1 + m}{2}, \quad T_6(g, m) = \frac{2c_g(m, n) + L - g(1) + g(m)}{3}. \quad (130)$$

Theorem 13.2 (The terminal expression is attained by ordinary chains). *For every 1-Lipschitz $g : [0, 1] \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$,*

$$\begin{aligned} \Phi_g(1) &\leq \Phi_g(m) + T_6(g, m) \quad (0 \leq m < 1), \\ \inf_{0 \leq m < 1} (\Phi_g(m) + T_6(g, m)) &= \Phi_g(1). \end{aligned} \quad (131)$$

No sign condition, dimension barriers, or endpoint normalization are required. At every fixed start $n_0 < 1$, an actual chain with $O(1 + \log(1/(1 - n_0)))$ edges has cost at most the displayed upper bound. Uniform profile perturbations of size ε and grid rounding of mesh ρ give error $O(K(\varepsilon + \rho))$, where K is that edge bound.

The theorem rules out an improvement from replacing the terminal portion of an optimized chain by exactly (130). It does not rule out other uses of local decoupling.

13.2 A total-drop potential

For a 1-Lipschitz function $f : [0, 1] \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$ with $f(0) = 0$, let $\mathbf{T}(f)$ be the infimum of

$$\sum_{j \geq 1} \left(f(t_j) - \min_{[t_j, t_{j-1}]} f \right)$$

over good partitions $1 = t_0 > t_1 > \dots \rightarrow 0$, with $t_{j-1} \leq 2t_j$. We claim that

$$\mathbf{T}(f) \leq \frac{1 - 2\beta}{3}, \quad \beta = \min_{[1/2, 1]} f. \quad (132)$$

First suppose that f is piecewise affine with finitely many pieces. Its hard-point set

$$H = \left\{ t \in [0, 1] : f(t) = \min_{[t/2, t]} f \right\}$$

is a finite union of closed interval components, possibly degenerate. It contains zero, and f is nonincreasing on each component. Keleti–Shmerkin’s identity [2, Lemma 5.4] gives

$$\mathbf{T}(f) = \sum_{[u, v] \text{ component of } H} (f(u) - f(v)). \quad (133)$$

Consider the potential

$$P(t) = \frac{t - 2f(t)}{3}.$$

On a hard component $[u, v]$, its drop $\delta = f(u) - f(v)$ satisfies $0 \leq \delta \leq v - u$. Hence

$$P(v) - P(u) = \frac{v - u + 2\delta}{3} \geq \delta. \quad (134)$$

Now take the endpoints $v < u$ of a gap between components, and put $\Delta = f(u) - f(v)$. If $\Delta \leq 0$, then $P(u) \geq P(v)$. If $\Delta > 0$, hardness at u forces $v < u/2$, since otherwise $v \in [u/2, u]$ would give $f(v) \geq f(u)$. Also $f(u/2) \geq f(u)$, and therefore

$$0 < \Delta \leq f(u/2) - f(v) \leq u/2 - v.$$

It follows that

$$P(u) - P(v) = \frac{u - v - 2\Delta}{3} \geq v/3 \geq 0. \quad (135)$$

Let $r = \max H$. Summing (134) and (135), and using $P(0) = 0$, proves

$$\mathbf{T}(f) \leq P(r) = \frac{r - 2f(r)}{3}.$$

If $r \geq 1/2$, then $f(r) \geq \beta$ and $r - 2f(r) \leq 1 - 2\beta$. If $r < 1/2$, Lipschitz continuity gives

$$f(r) \geq f(1/2) - (1/2 - r) \geq \beta - 1/2 + r, \quad r - 2f(r) \leq 1 - 2\beta - r \leq 1 - 2\beta.$$

This proves (132) in the piecewise affine case. The finite-chain approximation below extends it to every 1-Lipschitz function, without an assumed continuity theorem for infinite partitions.

13.3 Reversal, concatenation, and finite approximation

Let $h : [0, 1] \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$ be 1-Lipschitz with $h(0) = 0$, and put $e = h(1)$ and $f(t) = h(1 - t) - e$. Under reversal, an original edge $y \rightarrow x$ corresponds to a ratio-two interval $[1 - y, 1 - x]$. The difference between its original cost and the total-drop summand is the change in f between the two endpoints. Telescoping, and then letting the start approach one, yields

$$\Phi_h(1) = \mathbf{T}(f) - e. \quad (136)$$

For completeness, a finite ratio-two partition starting at $\zeta > 0$ can be extended towards zero by successive halvings with additional cost at most ζ . Conversely, an infinite good partition can be truncated at its interval crossing ζ , moving that endpoint to ζ ; the crossing cost changes by at most 2ζ . These observations justify the limit in (136). Since

$$\min_{[1/2, 1]} f = \min_{[0, 1/2]} h - e,$$

equations (132) and (136) give

$$\Phi_h(1) \leq \frac{1 - e - 2 \min_{[0, 1/2]} h}{3}. \quad (137)$$

We record the finite-chain details before applying this bound. Truncating a chain at its first crossing of a lower start can only decrease its cost. Conversely, successive maximal admissible edges bridge two starts below one with total cost at most their distance. Thus the finite-start infima are nondecreasing, are bounded by one, and satisfy

$$0 \leq \Phi_h(1) - \Phi_h(1 - \zeta) \leq \zeta. \quad (138)$$

For $l < m < n$, comparison of the two interval minima gives

$$c_h(l, n) \leq c_h(l, m) + c_h(m, n). \quad (139)$$

Merge consecutive edges whenever their union is admissible. In a resulting chain no two consecutive edges can be merged, so the complementary distance to one more than doubles every two edges. Its number of edges is at most $2\lceil \log_2(1/\zeta) \rceil + O(1)$. An infimizing sequence of these bounded endpoint lists has a convergent subsequence. Admissibility is closed, and interval minima depend continuously on endpoints. Removing repeated limiting endpoints gives a chain attaining the finite-start infimum.

For a general h , approximate it uniformly by its piecewise affine interpolants, with the same endpoint values and Lipschitz constant. At any fixed finite start, the piecewise affine bound supplies chains of uniformly bounded length. Pass to a convergent subsequence of their endpoint lists. The interval minima and costs converge and admissibility is preserved. This proves (137)

for every finite start; (138) gives its limiting form. It also establishes (132) in general via the reversal identity.

Apply (137) to

$$h(x) = \frac{g(m + Lx) - g(m)}{L}, \quad L = 1 - m.$$

Admissibility rescales exactly:

$$2(m + Ly) - (m + Lx) \leq 1 \iff 2y - x \leq 1.$$

Multiplication by L gives the upper cost $T_6(g, m)$ for a tail chain ending at m . Concatenate it with a chain from m to zero. This proves the first assertion of (131). The Lipschitz bound gives

$$0 \leq T_6(g, m) \leq 1 - m.$$

Letting $m \uparrow 1$ proves the opposite inequality for the infimum, and hence the exact identity.

For a finite start $n_0 > m$, the rescaled tail has

$$O\left(1 + \log \frac{1 - m}{1 - n_0}\right)$$

edges. Compress the concatenated chain once more to obtain the edge bound in Theorem 13.2. Starts $n_0 \leq m$ are handled by monotonicity. A uniform perturbation of g by ε changes each fixed edge cost by at most 2ε . Rounding endpoints down to a grid of mesh ρ , with zero, one and the prescribed finite start on the grid, preserves admissibility and changes each edge cost by at most 2ρ . Indeed

$$\lfloor m/\rho \rfloor \geq \lfloor (2n - 1)/\rho \rfloor \geq 2 \lfloor n/\rho \rfloor - 1/\rho$$

when $1/\rho$ is integral. This proves the stated stability.

13.4 The weighted refined-decoupling family

The conditional terminal expression associated with exponents $2 \leq p \leq 6$ is

$$T_p(g, m) = \frac{2}{p}I + \left(\frac{2}{p} - \frac{1}{3}\right)W + \left(1 - \frac{2}{p}\right)c,$$

where, with L, n as in (130),

$$I = L + g(m) - g(1), \quad W = -L/2 + g(1) - g(n), \quad c = g(m) - \min_{[m, n]} g.$$

At $p = 6$ this equals (130). Direct algebra gives

$$\begin{aligned} T_p(g, m) - T_6(g, m) &= \left(\frac{2}{p} - \frac{1}{3}\right)(I + W - c) \\ &= \left(\frac{2}{p} - \frac{1}{3}\right)\left(\frac{L}{2} - g(n) + \min_{[m, n]} g\right) \geq 0. \end{aligned}$$

The last inequality is exactly the Lipschitz bound over an interval of length $L/2$. Consequently

$$\inf_{\substack{0 \leq m < 1 \\ 2 \leq p \leq 6}} (\Phi_g(m) + T_p(g, m)) = \Phi_g(1).$$

Thus allowing this entire weighted exponent family leaves the abstract profile optimum unchanged.

14 Realizing the sharp profiles in one measure

The matching profiles are not excluded by requiring one measure to be consistent across all scales. They occur infinitely often for a single compact planar set with the prescribed exact dimensions. Conversely, the single-collapse profile cannot occur at every large scale. Neither statement is a counterexample to a distance-set theorem.

Theorem 14.1 (Subsequential realization). *Let $0 < a < b \leq 1$, $d = 1 + a$, $D = 1 + b$. Suppose that $g : [0, 1] \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$ is 1-Lipschitz, satisfies $ax \leq g(x) \leq bx$, has $g(1) = a$, and equals bx on some interval $[0, c]$, $c > 0$. There are a compact set $E \subset [0, 1]^2$, a d -Frostman probability μ on E , and integers $N_j \rightarrow \infty$, with*

$$\dim_H E = d, \quad \dim_P E = \overline{\dim}_B E = D,$$

such that every occupied half-open dyadic square of depth n has mass $2^{-F_{\text{dyad}}(n)}$. With linear interpolation of F_{dyad} ,

$$\sup_{x \in [0, 1]} \left| \frac{F_{\text{dyad}}(N_j x)}{N_j} - x - g(x) \right| \rightarrow 0. \quad (140)$$

The associated limiting optimal chain costs converge to $\Phi_0(g)$.

Proof. Put $h(x) = x + g(x)$. It is nondecreasing and 2-Lipschitz, with $dx \leq h(x) \leq Dx$, $h(1) = d$, and $h(x) = Dx$ for $x \leq c$. Choose integers $N_0 = 0 < N_1 < \dots$ with $N_{j-1}/N_j < c$ and $N_{j-1}/N_j \rightarrow 0$. On $[N_{j-1}, N_j]$, define

$$F(t) = \max\{dt, N_j h(t/N_j) - (D - d)N_{j-1}\}. \quad (141)$$

At the left endpoint both entries equal dN_{j-1} , and at the right endpoint the maximum equals dN_j . Thus F is continuous, nondecreasing, and 2-Lipschitz, and

$$dt \leq F(t) \leq Dt, \quad F(N_j) = dN_j.$$

For every $0 \leq t \leq N_j$,

$$0 \leq N_j h(t/N_j) - F(t) \leq (D - d)N_{j-1}. \quad (142)$$

For $t \geq N_{j-1}$, this follows from the defining maximum; for $t \leq N_{j-1}$, use $h(t/N_j) = Dt/N_j$ and $dt \leq F(t) \leq Dt$. At a fixed $c_0 \in (0, c]$, the ratio $F(c_0 N_j)/(c_0 N_j)$ therefore tends to D . It follows that

$$\liminf_{t \rightarrow \infty} F(t)/t = d, \quad \limsup_{t \rightarrow \infty} F(t)/t = D.$$

Set $S(n) = \lfloor F(n)/2 \rfloor$. The increments of S are zero or one. Let A be the set of indices with increment one, and put

$$C_A = \left\{ \sum_{n \geq 1} \varepsilon_n 2^{-n} : \varepsilon_n \in \{0, 1\} \ (n \in A), \ \varepsilon_n = 0 \ (n \notin A) \right\}, \quad E = C_A \times C_A.$$

Give every allowed binary digit in each coordinate an independent fair choice. The resulting probability μ gives each occupied depth- n square mass $2^{-2S(n)}$, and there are $2^{2S(n)}$ such squares. Ambiguous binary expansions have zero measure, because there are infinitely many free digits and a prescribed infinite tail has probability zero. The support is compact. With $F_{\text{dyad}}(n) = 2S(n)$, rounding and interpolation give

$$\|F_{\text{dyad}} - F\|_{L^\infty([0, \infty))} \leq 4.$$

Equation (142) now proves (140) with error at most $((D - d)N_{j-1} + 4)/N_j$.

A ball of radius 2^{-n} meets a bounded number of depth- n dyadic squares. Consequently

$$\mu(B(z, 2^{-n})) \leq C2^{-F_{\text{dyad}}(n)} \leq 4C2^{-dn}. \quad (143)$$

Neighboring dyadic radii give the d -Frostman bound at all radii, so $\dim_{\text{H}} E \geq d$. At $n = N_j$, the support is covered by at most 2^{dN_j} squares of diameter $\sqrt{2}2^{-N_j}$. Their s -dimensional covering sum tends to zero for every $s > d$, proving $\dim_{\text{H}} E = d$.

The occupied-square count and the first inequality in (143) give matching upper and lower covering-number bounds, within absolute constants. Hence $\overline{\dim}_{\text{B}} E = \limsup_n F_{\text{dyad}}(n)/n = D$. For the packing dimension, use the standard characterization

$$\dim_{\text{P}} E = \inf_{E \subset \bigcup_i E_i} \sup_i \overline{\dim}_{\text{B}} E_i, \quad (144)$$

where the covers are countable and bounded; see, for example, [Falconer, *A capacity approach to box and packing dimensions*, equation \(4.1\)](#). Some member of any such cover has $\mu^*(E_i \cap E) > 0$. If M balls of radius 2^{-n} cover that member, then

$$\mu^*(E_i \cap E) \leq MC2^{-F_{\text{dyad}}(n)}.$$

Thus $\overline{\dim}_{\text{B}} E_i \geq D$. Equation (144) proves $\dim_{\text{P}} E \geq D$, and the upper box bound gives equality. The same argument shows that every subset of positive μ outer measure has packing dimension D .

It remains to justify convergence of the costs; this follows from the stability lemma below. The interpolated functions $F_{\text{dyad}}(Nx)/N - x$ are 1-Lipschitz, since their slopes are -1 or 1 . $\square$

Lemma 14.2 (Continuity of limiting cost). *For 1-Lipschitz functions g, h on $[0, 1]$, let Φ_0 denote the limiting optimal cost of finite admissible chains as the starting point tends to one. If $\|g - h\|_{\infty} \leq \epsilon$, then, for $0 < \zeta < 1$,*

$$|\Phi_0(g) - \Phi_0(h)| \leq 2\zeta + 2K(\zeta)\epsilon, \quad K(\zeta) = 2\lceil \log_2(1/\zeta) \rceil + 4.$$

In particular Φ_0 is continuous under uniform convergence within this Lipschitz class.

Proof. Write $\Psi_g(n)$ for the infimum of costs from $n < 1$ to zero. If $n < n'$, truncate a chain from n' at its first crossing of n . The crossing edge remains admissible and its cost can only decrease. Conversely, extend a chain from n up to n' by repeatedly doubling the complementary distance $1 - x$, stopping at n . The added cost is at most the negative variation on $[n, n']$, hence at most $n' - n$. Thus

$$0 \leq \Psi_g(n') - \Psi_g(n) \leq n' - n, \quad 0 \leq \Phi_0(g) - \Psi_g(1 - \zeta) \leq \zeta.$$

Merging adjacent admissible edges never increases cost, since $c_g(l, n) \leq c_g(l, m) + c_g(m, n)$ for $l < m < n$. After all possible mergers, every two edges more than double $1 - x$, giving the bound $K(\zeta)$. Each edge cost changes by at most 2ϵ under the uniform perturbation. Infimizing over the bounded-length chains and adding the two truncation errors proves the claim. $\square$

Remark 14.3 (Applicable templates and separated restrictions). The single-collapse profile $\min\{bx, 1 + a - x\}$ satisfies the realization hypotheses for every $0 < a < b \leq 1$. The matching two-collapse profile $\min\{bx, at + |x - t|, 1 + a - x\}$, in its certified parameter region, also does: its two other entries are strictly positive at zero, so it equals bx on an initial interval. Therefore both sharp costs occur along subsequences for actual Frostman measures.

A fixed occupied depth- k cylinder, with the measure normalized on it, has descendant cube exponent $F_{\text{dyad}}(n) - F_{\text{dyad}}(k)$. The bounded initial change disappears after normalization by N_j , so it has the same limiting profiles and dimensions. Choosing two sufficiently small cylinders around distinct support points gives compact source and pin supports a positive distance apart, each with these properties.

Lemma 14.4 (Persistence under large regular restrictions). *For the measure in Theorem 14.1, fix a union X of depth- N cubes, with $w = \mu(X) > 0$, and let $\sigma = \mu|_X/w$. Suppose its occupied depth- k cubes obey*

$$2^{-f(k)-eN} \leq \sigma(Q) \leq 2^{-f(k)}.$$

Then

$$F_{\text{dyad}}(k) + \log_2 w - eN \leq f(k) \leq F_{\text{dyad}}(k). \quad (145)$$

In particular, a component with $w \geq 2^{-\gamma N}$ changes the profile by at most $(\gamma + e)N$.

Proof. For the lower bound, combine the lower regularity estimate with $\sigma(Q) \leq \mu(Q)/w = 2^{-F_{\text{dyad}}(k)}/w$. For the upper bound, at most $2^{F_{\text{dyad}}(k)}$ occupied cubes have masses at most $2^{-f(k)}$, and their masses sum to one. $\square$

Thus selecting large regular components cannot remove the matching profiles at the constructed scales when the regularization losses tend to zero. This does not preclude using geometric information absent from the mass profile.

14.1 Single collapse cannot persist at all scales

Let $G : [0, \infty) \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$ be continuous and put $g_N(x) = G(Nx)/N$. Take $g(x) = \min\{bx, 1 + a - x\}$, $0 < a < b \leq 1$.

Proposition 14.5 (Separated clusters of near occurrences). *Suppose $0 < M < N$ and both g_M, g_N are within uniform distance ϵ of g , where $0 < \epsilon < b - a$. Then*

$$\frac{M}{N} \leq L_\epsilon := \frac{\epsilon}{b - a - \epsilon} \quad \text{or} \quad \frac{M}{N} \geq U_\epsilon := \frac{1 + a - \epsilon}{1 + a + \epsilon}.$$

For sufficiently small $\epsilon > 0$, write $\ell_\epsilon = \log(1/L_\epsilon)$ and $w_\epsilon = \log(1/U_\epsilon)$. Then

$$\limsup_{L \rightarrow \infty} \frac{1}{L} |\{t \in [0, L] : \|g_{e^t} - g\|_\infty \leq \epsilon\}| \leq \frac{w_\epsilon}{\ell_\epsilon} = O_{a,b}\left(\frac{\epsilon}{\log(1/\epsilon)}\right). \quad (146)$$

Proof. Put $r = M/N$ and $p = (1 + a)/(1 + b)$. The endpoint of g_M and the value of g_N at r give

$$|g(r) - ra| \leq \epsilon(1 + r).$$

For $r \leq p$, the left side equals $r(b - a)$, yielding $r \leq L_\epsilon$. For $r \geq p$, it equals $(1 + a)(1 - r)$, yielding $r \geq U_\epsilon$. For small ϵ , one has $0 < L_\epsilon < U_\epsilon < 1$. Thus in logarithmic scale no two near occurrences have separation strictly between w_ϵ and ℓ_ϵ . In an interval of length less than ℓ_ϵ , their set has diameter and measure at most w_ϵ . It is measurable by continuity of G . Partition long intervals into pieces of length $\ell_\epsilon - \delta$, and then let $\delta \downarrow 0$, to get (146). Finally, $w_\epsilon = O_a(\epsilon)$ and $\ell_\epsilon \sim \log(1/\epsilon)$. $\square$

For either matching template, a simpler obstruction follows from its initial linear interval: if $\lambda \leq c$ and both scales $N, \lambda N$ have error at most ϵ , then $\lambda(b - a) \leq (1 + \lambda)\epsilon$.

These results distinguish infinite recurrence from recurrence at every scale. The sparsity bound does not make shell estimates of size 2^{cN_j} summable when $c > 0$. Moreover, profiles obtained by separately regularizing an arbitrary measure at each scale need not be prefixes of a single function G . A new argument would be needed to exploit this obstruction in the analytic transfer. No improvement to the distance criterion is claimed here.

14.2 Simultaneous raw Fourier-energy saturation

The profiles can also occur where the source's raw Fourier energy nearly attains the Frostman exponent. The assertion concerns fixed separated restrictions of the same measure, so it is compatible with the source-pin separation required in the analytic proof.

Proposition 14.6 (Near-extremal profiles and energy on one annulus). *Under Theorem 14.1, choose two separated occupied cylinders at a fixed common depth k , and normalize the restrictions of μ to obtain source and pin probabilities σ, ν . Their compact supports both have Hausdorff dimension d and packing dimension D , and both probabilities are d -Frostman. Writing $F = F_{\text{dyad}}$, they have the common conditional exponent*

$$F_k(t) = \begin{cases} 0, & 0 \leq t \leq k, \\ F(t) - F(k), & t \geq k. \end{cases}$$

For every $\tau > 0$ and $\epsilon > 0$, there are infinitely many integers n such that

$$\|F_k(nx)/n - x - g(x)\|_{L_x^\infty([0,1])} \leq \tau, \quad \int_{2^n \leq |\xi| < 2^{n+1}} |\widehat{\sigma}(\xi)|^2 d\xi \geq 2^{(2-d-\epsilon)n}. \quad (147)$$

The source and pin supports are fixed independently of both tolerances.

Proof. The restrictions and dimensions were justified in Remark 14.3. They can be chosen at the same depth by taking two sufficiently small dyadic squares with separated closures. Both original cube masses are $2^{-F(k)}$. Every occupied descendant at depth $n \geq k$ has conditional mass $2^{F(k)-F(n)}$, proving the formula for F_k . In particular

$$\|F_k - F\|_\infty \leq F(k) \leq 2k. \quad (148)$$

Use the convention $\widehat{\sigma}(\xi) = \int e^{-2\pi i x \cdot \xi} d\sigma(x)$. The Gaussian Fourier transform and Fubini give

$$\begin{aligned} \mathcal{E}_\sigma(R) &:= \int e^{-\pi|\xi|^2/R^2} |\widehat{\sigma}(\xi)|^2 d\xi \\ &= R^2 \iint e^{-\pi R^2|x-y|^2} d\sigma(x) d\sigma(y). \end{aligned} \quad (149)$$

Fubini is justified by Gaussian integrability and finiteness of the measure. For $R_j = 2^{N_j}$ with $N_j \geq k$, two points in the same depth- N_j square have distance at most $\sqrt{2}/R_j$. The sum of the squares of the conditional masses of these squares is $2^{F(k)-F(N_j)}$. Since $F(N_j) \leq dN_j$,

$$\mathcal{E}_\sigma(R_j) \geq e^{-2\pi R_j^2} 2^{F(k)-F(N_j)} \geq c_0 R_j^{2-d}, \quad c_0 = e^{-2\pi} 2^{F(k)} > 0. \quad (150)$$

Conversely, the Frostman bound and spatial annuli of radii $2^m/R$ give

$$\int e^{-\pi R^2|x-y|^2} d\sigma(y) \leq C R^{-d} \left(1 + \sum_{m \geq 1} 2^{md} e^{-\pi 2^{2m-2}} \right).$$

The sum is finite. Equation (149) therefore yields, for $R \geq 1$,

$$\mathcal{E}_\sigma(R) \leq C_1 R^{2-d}, \quad \int_{|\xi| \leq R} |\widehat{\sigma}(\xi)|^2 d\xi \leq e^\pi \mathcal{E}_\sigma(R) \leq C_2 R^{2-d}. \quad (151)$$

Put $q = 2 - d > 0$, and temporarily fix $0 < \eta < 1/4$. At $R = R_j$, the part of the Gaussian integral below $R_j^{1-\eta}$ is at most $C_2 R_j^{(1-\eta)q} = o(R_j^q)$. The part above $R_j^{1+\eta}$, using $|\widehat{\sigma}| \leq 1$, is at most the exact planar Gaussian tail

$$\int_{|\xi| \geq R_j^{1+\eta}} e^{-\pi|\xi|^2/R_j^2} d\xi = R_j^2 e^{-\pi R_j^{2\eta}} = o(R_j^q).$$

Hence the intermediate region contributes at least $(c_0/2)R_j^q$ for large j . Its Gaussian weight is at most one, and it is covered by at most $2\eta N_j + 3$ dyadic annuli. Some index n_j consequently satisfies

$$(1 - \eta)N_j - 1 \leq n_j \leq (1 + \eta)N_j + 1, \quad (152)$$

$$\int_{2^{n_j} \leq |\xi| < 2^{n_j+1}} |\widehat{\sigma}(\xi)|^2 d\xi \geq \frac{c_\eta}{N_j} 2^{qN_j}, \quad c_\eta > 0. \quad (153)$$

Only existence of one annulus in this window is asserted.

For the given tolerances, take

$$\epsilon_0 = \min\{\epsilon, q/2\}, \quad 0 < \eta < \min\{1/4, \tau/16, \epsilon_0/(8q)\}.$$

For large j ,

$$(q - \epsilon_0)n_j \leq (q - \epsilon_0)(1 + 2\eta)N_j \leq (q - 3\epsilon_0/4)N_j.$$

The polynomial loss in (153) is absorbed by this strict exponential margin, proving the energy inequality in (147).

Finally $G(t) = F(t) - t$ is 1-Lipschitz and $G(0) = 0$, so

$$\|G(nx)/n - G(Nx)/N\|_{L_x^\infty([0,1])} \leq 2|n - N|/n.$$

This follows by separating the changes of argument and denominator, using $|G(Nx)| \leq N$. Equations (148) and (152) give, for large j ,

$$\|F_k(n_j x)/n_j - x - g(x)\|_\infty \leq F(k)/n_j + 4\eta + 4/N_j + \|G(N_j x)/N_j - g(x)\|_\infty.$$

The second term is less than $\tau/4$, and each of the other terms is at most $\tau/4$ for sufficiently large j , by (140). This proves the profile inequality. The windows in (152) are eventually disjoint, since $N_{j-1}/N_j \rightarrow 0$, so infinitely many distinct indices occur. $\square$

This proposition rules out a universal saving in the *raw* source Fourier-energy exponent merely from the pin profile being near one of the matching templates. It proves no sharpness for the modified good-packet estimate and says nothing adverse about the actual pinned distance sets. Angular geometry, cancellation, or a different summation argument could still yield a stronger distance theorem.

14.3 An obstruction at the curvature-matched scales

The coherent approximations at source-cell depth n have scalar error $O(2^{-2n})$. Their natural comparison with frequency $R = 2^N$ is therefore $N = 2n$, rather than $N = n$. The following calculation shows that the matching profiles can obstruct both existing estimates at these matched scales. It does not exclude an estimate coupling the two arguments in a genuinely new way.

Lemma 14.7. *Let μ be a homogeneous dyadic probability: at every integer depth k , all occupied squares have mass $2^{-F(k)}$. Assume that the conditional energies below are finite. Fix $0 < \gamma < 1/2$, put $\tau = 1 + 2\gamma$, and use the coherent quantity*

$$Z_n = 2^{-n(1+4\gamma)} \sum_{Q \text{ at depth } n+1} \mu(Q) I_\tau(\mu_Q).$$

For every integer $N \geq n + 1$,

$$Z_n \geq c_\gamma 2^{\tau N + F(n+1) - F(N) - n(2\tau-1)}. \quad (154)$$

In particular, if $N = 2n$, then

$$Z_n \geq c_\gamma 2^{F(n) - F(2n) + n}. \quad (155)$$

Proof. Fix an occupied square Q of depth $n + 1$. It contains exactly $2^{F(N) - F(n+1)}$ occupied depth- N descendants, each with conditional mass $2^{F(n+1) - F(N)}$. Two independent points under μ_Q lie in the same such descendant with probability

$$2^{F(n+1) - F(N)}.$$

Their separation is at most $\sqrt{2} 2^{-N}$. These pairs alone give

$$I_\tau(\mu_Q) \geq 2^{-\tau/2} 2^{\tau N + F(n+1) - F(N)}.$$

Summing with the parent weights, which total one, proves (154). For $N = 2n$, the terms containing τ reduce to n ; also $F(n+1) \geq F(n)$. This gives (155). $\square$

Suppose even depths N_j realize a template as in Theorem 14.1:

$$\frac{F(N_j x)}{N_j} \longrightarrow x + g(x) \quad \text{uniformly,} \quad g(1) = a.$$

Equation (155) gives

$$\liminf_{j \rightarrow \infty} \frac{1}{N_j} \log_2 Z_{N_j/2} \geq g(1/2) - a. \quad (156)$$

Consequently, when $g(1/2) = b/2$ and $b > 2a$, the coherent quantities grow along this subsequence. The coherent summability criterion cannot hold. This calculation is independent of the legal choice of γ . For the realized d -Frostman measures, the required conditional energies are finite whenever $1 + 2\gamma < d = 1 + a$. Integer rounding or a fixed additive change of the matching depth only changes the exponent by $O(1)$. A strictly positive limiting exponent also persists under sufficiently small fixed proportional changes of that depth.

Checking the matching templates. For the single-collapse witness of Section 6.9, with $0 < a < b \leq 1$, its first affine piece ends at

$$P = \frac{1+a}{1+b} > \frac{1}{2}.$$

Hence $g(1/2) = b/2$. Whenever

$$b \geq b_F(a) = \frac{2a}{1-2a}, \quad 0 < a \leq \frac{1}{4},$$

its limiting chain cost $C_1(a, b)$ is at least a . Since $b_F(a) > 2a$, the same witness obstructs the strict chain-cost test and the coherent summability estimate at the matched scales.

For the two-collapse witness of Section 6.8, its initial affine piece ends at

$$L(a, b) = \frac{(1+a)(1-b)(1+2a)}{(1-a)(1+2b)(1+b)}.$$

This function decreases in b . At $b = b_c(a) = (1+2a)/(4+2a)$, direct simplification gives

$$L(a, b_c(a)) - \frac{1}{2} = \frac{8a^2 + 11a - 1}{2(1-a)(4a+5)}.$$

For $\alpha = (3-\sqrt{7})/4$, its numerator equals $23\alpha - 2 > 0$; the last inequality follows from $61^2 > 23^2 \cdot 7$. The numerator increases for positive a . Thus

$$\alpha \leq a \leq a_c, \quad 2a \leq b \leq b_c(a) \implies L(a, b) > \frac{1}{2}.$$

In particular $g(1/2) = b/2$ throughout this range. For $\alpha < a \leq a_c$ and $r_2(a) \leq b \leq b_c(a)$, the proved matching cost satisfies $C_2(a, b) \geq a$, while $b > 2a$. Equation (156) again makes both existing sufficient tests fail on the same realized example, with their indices matched by curvature.

The zero-exponent boundary can also be realized without decay. For $0 < a \leq \alpha$, use the two-collapse witness with $b = 2a$. It is in the witness's parameter domain: $\alpha < 1/8$ implies $4a^2 + 6a < 1$, equivalently $2a < b_c(a)$. It has cost at least a , and

$$L(a, 2a) - \frac{1}{2} = \frac{1-5a}{2(1-a)(1+4a)} > 0.$$

Thus $g(1/2) = a$. Uniform template convergence alone only gives a zero limiting exponent in (156); it does not prove failure of summability. The following modification of the realization does prove that failure.

Write $d = 1 + a$, $D = 1 + 2a < 2$, and $h(x) = x + g(x)$. Suppose a block starts at depth M with cumulative value dM . Choose the next even endpoint N sufficiently large and, on $[M, N]$, define

$$\mathcal{F}(t) = \min\{Nh(t/N), 2t - (2-d)M\}.$$

The template initially equals Dx , on an interval extending past $1/2$. The two entries first meet at

$$t_0 = \frac{2-d}{2-D}M.$$

Choose N so large that $t_0 < N/2$ and that this meeting occurs in the initial linear part. Before t_0 the second entry is smaller. Afterwards it remains at least the first, since it has slope two and the template is 2-Lipschitz. Therefore

$$\mathcal{F}(N/2) = DN/2, \quad \mathcal{F}(N) = dN.$$

This block joins the preceding one continuously, is nondecreasing and 2-Lipschitz, and obeys $dt \leq \mathcal{F}(t) \leq Dt$. Choose successive blocks with $M/N \rightarrow 0$. Away from an initial interval of length $O_a(M)$ the block agrees exactly with its template, so the same uniform realization limit holds.

Use the product-digit construction with integer exponent $F(k) = 2\lfloor \mathcal{F}(k)/2 \rfloor$, as in Theorem 14.1. Its uniform d -Frostman and upper-cover bounds follow from the same barriers. Its exact Hausdorff and packing dimensions are d, D , using the endpoint and midpoint scales, respectively, in

that theorem's dimension argument. The rounding error is less than two at integer depths, and hence

$$F(N/2) - F(N) + N/2 \geq -2.$$

Equation (155) implies $Z_{N/2} \geq c_\gamma/4$ along infinitely many blocks. Thus the coherent summability criterion fails even at this zero-exponent boundary. The realization still has the matching limiting chain cost at least a .

Fixed positive-mass cylinder restrictions preserve the calculation: their later-depth exponent is $F(k) - F(k_0)$, and the subtracted constant cancels in (155). The separated source and pin restrictions supplied by the realization construction are therefore compatible with these examples.

This result concerns the two existing estimates, not the actual distance laws. In particular, one cannot infer a hybrid improvement merely because the coherent comparison looks favorable at depth N where the Fourier profile is unfavorable at frequency 2^N : the directly matching coherent depth is $N/2$, where the examples above are unfavorable. Controlling a different bridge between the two approximation schemes could still improve the distance theorem.

15 Plan for formal verification

This previously requested plan is retained for reference. Current work is focused on the natural-language proof; no additional formalization is claimed for the integrability or selection arguments.

The module `FalconerPacking/HardGapAlgebra.lean` now verifies both weighted certificates, the cost-difference identity, the quadratic and rational strict-threshold equivalences, and the two exact example margins. Each of these seven theorems uses only `propext`, `Classical.choice`, and `Quot.sound`. Their hypotheses are the explicit gap and tail inequalities; the geometric reduction and the analytic transfer remain separate obligations. No unconditional Lean verification or comparator acceptance is claimed. The existing target must retain the standard Euclidean distance, the same Borel-set hypotheses, and the standard Hausdorff and packing dimensions. No analytic conclusion may be inserted as an axiom or hidden in a definition.

The elementary part can be developed first: define finite admissible chains with only $2n - m \leq N$; prove zero-cost merging and its length bound; formalize the affine-potential construction, its localized low-slope version, and the perturbation and rounding bounds. Then prove the algebra of U and B_U , including strict joins and continuity. The minimum refinement additionally needs the tail-minimum reflection, the three affine intersections, their positive denominators and strict monotonicity, and existence and continuity of the unique root b_* . These are exact real-analysis statements; numerical root plots are not formal proofs of the curve. The adaptive extension additionally requires the edgewise endpoint-clipping inequality, the supporting-line stopping argument, and the variable free endpoint. Formalize the rational function C_θ before defining its minimum over the compact interval. Prove joint continuity, attainment, strict monotonicity in the upper slope and the root theorem. A minimizing parameter at the larger slope proves that compact minimization preserves strict increase here. The parameter is then fixed before choosing the strict Frostman and covering exponent slacks in the Borel reduction. For the sharp gap extension, formalize the reversed hard-component identity with its endpoint correction, then the gap lemma and both tail inequalities. The seven- and eight-weight certificates are finite algebraic identities: each multiplier's nonnegativity must be proved before summing inequalities. Formalize the matching profiles separately from the analytic conclusion; their sharpness must not be recast as a distance-set counterexample. The explicit quadratic root and both joins then replace numerical optimization in the final strongest curve.

The analytic part needs independent formal proofs of Frostman extraction, finite regularization, averaged radial projection, packet localization, the inherited marking identities, local orthogonality, local constancy, conditional tube counting, the pinned quadratic identity, and the joint limit. The standard spatial packets and the finer spectral labels must be separate objects. Formalizing their exact sum identity before any inequality would catch the main potential gap in this refinement.

A useful order of deliverables is:

Milestone	Required checked statement
Profile calculus	A bounded admissible chain with the exact cost and explicit grid error.
Finite geometry	Cube ancestry, conditional normalization, tube overlap, and both angular inequalities.
Packet/spectral interface	Whole-standard-cap reconstruction and the exact inherited spectral sum.
Quadratic step	One tube threshold per inflation step, with every parameter dependency explicit.
Measure conclusion	Summable shell densities identify the original joint distance law and a positive-length pin.

Finally assemble the measure theorem and compact/Borel reduction, and compare the elaborated unconditional statement with a fixed reference statement. Build every dependency and inspect the theorem's axiom report. Acceptance requires only `propext`, `Classical.choice`, and `Quot.sound`; `sorryAx`, extra analytical axioms, or a conditional replacement target would fail the requested standard. This is a development plan, not evidence that the comparator has already accepted the theorem.

16 A weighted embedding for one Fourier step

This appendix proves the one-step estimate (31) directly from its geometric and Fourier hypotheses. In particular, the selected caps may depend arbitrarily on the child cube. The proof does not restore the omitted caps before applying the good-tube condition. The pin measure need not satisfy a Frostman bound in this step.

For a bounded rectangle A of positive area, write $m_A = |A|^{-1} \mathcal{L}^2|_A$. Dilations of cubes and rectangles below are concentric. We use the Fourier convention $\widehat{f}(\xi) = \int e^{-2\pi i x \cdot \xi} f(x) dx$.

Proposition 16.1 (Selected-cap weighted embedding). *Fix an integer $K \geq 1$, an index $0 \leq j < K$, and constants $C_0, B_0 \geq 1$. Let $0 < a \leq b$, and let P be an axis-parallel square of side b . Let $\mathcal{Q}$ be a finite subfamily of squares of an axis-parallel a -grid, each contained in P . For $L \geq L_0(C_0, K)$, set*

$$Q^+ = L^{2j+2}Q, \quad \widetilde{Q} = LQ^+, \quad P^+ = L^{2j+4}P, \quad D = L^{4K+20}.$$

Let σ be a finite positive Borel measure, and put

$$w_Q = \sigma(Q^+), \quad M = \sigma(P^+).$$

Let Θ be a finite label set. For every $\theta \in \Theta$ choose a function $f_\theta \in L^2(\mathbb{R}^2)$, a unit vector u_θ , a frequency center ξ_θ , and an effective unit direction v_θ , subject to the following conditions:

1. The Fourier support of f_θ is contained in

$$\left\{ \xi : |(\xi - \xi_\theta) \cdot u_\theta^\perp| \leq C_0/a, \quad |(\xi - \xi_\theta) \cdot u_\theta| \leq C_0/b \right\}.$$

These supports are also contained in balls of radius C_0/a whose pointwise overlap is at most B_0 .

2. The angular mismatch obeys

$$|u_\theta - v_\theta| \leq C_0 a/b.$$

Directions may first be given consistent signs, since the rectangles and the tests depend only on the unoriented lines.

3. For each child there are numbers $\varepsilon_{Q,\theta} \in \{0,1\}$. Let $T_{Q,\theta}$ be the rectangle centered at the center of Q , of width Da perpendicular to v_θ and length Db parallel to v_θ . For a number $H \geq 1$, assume only that

$$\varepsilon_{Q,\theta} = 1 \implies \sigma(T_{Q,\theta} \cap P^+) \leq H \frac{a}{b} M. \quad (\text{G})$$

The function f_θ is the same for all children; only the selection numbers depend on Q . Then, for every $m > 0$,

$$\begin{aligned} & \sum_{Q \in \mathcal{Q}} w_Q \int_{Q^+} \left| \sum_{\theta \in \Theta} \varepsilon_{Q,\theta} f_\theta \right|^2 dm_{Q^+} \\ & \leq CL^{8j+14} HM \sum_{\theta \in \Theta} \int_{P^+} |f_\theta|^2 dm_{P^+} + C_m M a^{-2} L^{-m} \sum_{\theta \in \Theta} \|f_\theta\|_2^2. \end{aligned} \quad (157)$$

Here C and C_m may depend on the fixed constants C_0, B_0, K , and C_m also on m . They do not depend on a, b, L, H , the measure, or the numbers of children and labels.

Proof. We separate the geometric consequence of the selected tests, local orthogonality, and the weighted reproducing-kernel estimate.

Geometry and the selected tube weights. The enlarged child cubes have overlap at most

$$\Lambda \leq CL^{4j+4}. \quad (158)$$

Indeed, in each coordinate at most $L^{2j+2} + 2$ grid centers can place a point in the corresponding enlarged interval. Also, for a point in $\tilde{Q}$, its distance from the center of P in the maximum norm is at most $(1 + L^{2j+3})b/2$. It follows that

$$\text{dist} \left(\bigcup_{Q \in \mathcal{Q}} \tilde{Q}, \mathbb{R}^2 \setminus P^+ \right) \geq Lb \quad (159)$$

for $L \geq 4$. In particular all Q^+ lie in P^+ , and

$$\sum_Q w_Q \leq \Lambda M. \quad (160)$$

Fix θ , and let U be any translate of a rectangle of width a and length b , oriented along u_θ . We claim

$$\sum_{\substack{Q: \varepsilon_Q, \theta=1 \\ \tilde{Q} \cap U \neq \emptyset}} w_Q \leq \Lambda H \frac{a}{b} M. \quad (161)$$

If the index set is empty this is immediate. Otherwise choose one of its cubes, Q_0 . Every Q^+ in that sum lies inside $T_{Q_0, \theta}$, as we now check.

Let q, q_0 be the centers of Q, Q_0 , and choose $z \in \tilde{Q} \cap U$, $z_0 \in \tilde{Q}_0 \cap U$. For $x \in Q^+$, write

$$x - q_0 = (x - q) + (q - z) + (z - z_0) + (z_0 - q_0).$$

The first, second, and fourth terms have length at most $CL^{2j+3}a$. The third has components at most a and b perpendicular and parallel to u_θ . Therefore

$$|(x - q_0) \cdot u_\theta^\perp| \leq CL^{2j+3}a, \quad |(x - q_0) \cdot u_\theta| \leq CL^{2j+3}b.$$

Changing to v_θ adds at most $CC_0L^{2j+3}a$ to the transverse component. The longitudinal component stays bounded by $C(1 + C_0)L^{2j+3}b$. Since $2j + 3 \leq 2K + 1$, the prescribed value of D exceeds twice these factors once $L \geq L_0(C_0, K)$. This proves the containment. All the cubes in question also lie in P^+ . Their overlap bound and the selected test at Q_0 now give

$$\sum_{\substack{Q: \varepsilon_Q, \theta=1 \\ \tilde{Q} \cap U \neq \emptyset}} \sigma(Q^+) \leq \Lambda \sigma(T_{Q_0, \theta} \cap P^+) \leq \Lambda H(a/b)M,$$

as claimed. Thus the mass bound for *every* dual rectangle in (161) is a consequence of the given tests at selected children, not an additional assumption.

Local orthogonality for a selected subset. Choose a Schwartz function v whose Fourier transform is supported in the unit ball and whose modulus is at least one on the unit square centered at zero. To obtain one, start with the inverse transform of a smooth bump supported in a sufficiently small ball; its value can be made nearly constant on that square and then multiplied by a fixed constant. For a child centered at q , put

$$v_Q(x) = v \left(\frac{x - q}{L^{2j+2}a} \right).$$

The product $v_Q f_\theta$ has Fourier support in the corresponding frequency ball enlarged by at most a^{-1} . These enlarged balls have overlap at most a fixed multiple of B_0 . In fact, dilating equal-radius balls by two increases their overlap by at most a factor nine in the plane: balls contributing at a point have their original balls inside the concentric ball of three times the radius, and an integration of the original overlap bound gives this count.

For every subset $A \subseteq \Theta$, Plancherel and pointwise Cauchy–Schwarz in frequency therefore give

$$\left\| v_Q \sum_{\theta \in A} f_\theta \right\|_2^2 \leq C \sum_{\theta \in A} \|v_Q f_\theta\|_2^2. \quad (162)$$

The constant is independent of the subset. Apply this to $A = \{\theta : \varepsilon_{Q,\theta} = 1\}$. Restrict the left side to Q^+ , and truncate the right side at $\tilde{Q} = LQ^+$. Schwartz decay and normalization of the cube averages give, for every $p > 0$,

$$\begin{aligned} \int_{Q^+} \left| \sum_{\theta} \varepsilon_{Q,\theta} f_\theta \right|^2 dm_{Q^+} \\ \leq CL^2 \sum_{\theta: \varepsilon_{Q,\theta}=1} \int_{\tilde{Q}} |f_\theta|^2 dm_{\tilde{Q}} + C_p a^{-2} L^{-p} \sum_{\theta} \|f_\theta\|_2^2. \end{aligned} \quad (163)$$

For the first term the area ratio is exactly L^2 . For the second, $|Q^+|^{-1} \leq a^{-2}$, and the square of the cutoff is bounded by $C_p L^{-p}$ outside $\tilde{Q}$. No unselected label has been introduced into the main term.

The anisotropic weighted embedding. For a fixed label define the finite positive averaging measure

$$\tau_\theta = \sum_{Q: \varepsilon_{Q,\theta}=1} w_Q m_{\tilde{Q}}.$$

Equations (161) and (160) imply

$$\tau_\theta(U) \leq \Lambda H(a/b)M \quad \text{for every dual rectangle } U, \quad \tau_\theta(\mathbb{R}^2) \leq \Lambda M. \quad (164)$$

Take a smooth compact frequency bump equal to one on $[-C_0, C_0]^2$. Translating, rotating, and rescaling it produces a reproducing kernel k_θ for the Fourier rectangle in the proposition. Thus $f_\theta = f_\theta * k_\theta$, and

$$\begin{aligned} \|k_\theta\|_1 &\leq C, \\ |k_\theta(z)| &\leq \frac{C_p}{ab} \left(1 + \frac{|z \cdot u_\theta^\perp|}{a} + \frac{|z \cdot u_\theta|}{b} \right)^{-p} \quad (p > 0). \end{aligned} \quad (165)$$

The translation of the frequency rectangle merely modulates the kernel and does not change these absolute-value estimates. Each L^2 function with the specified bounded Fourier support has a continuous representative, since its Fourier transform is also integrable. The reproducing identity and the following pointwise estimate are understood for that representative. Cauchy–Schwarz yields

$$|f_\theta(x)|^2 \leq C \int |f_\theta(y)|^2 |k_\theta(x-y)| dy.$$

For each fixed y , partition the plane into translates of dual rectangles a -by- b centered on the corresponding rectangular lattice based at y . The mass estimate in (164), the kernel bound with any $p > 2$, and summation of the lattice decay give

$$\int |k_\theta(x-y)| d\tau_\theta(x) \leq \frac{C}{ab} \Lambda H \frac{a}{b} M = C \frac{\Lambda H M}{b^2}. \quad (166)$$

This computation displays the single occurrence of the tube threshold.

If $y \notin P^+$, the support margin (159) gives $|x - y| \geq Lb$ on the support of τ_θ . Since $a \leq b$, the anisotropic distance in (165) is then at least a fixed multiple of L . Its arbitrary-order decay and the total mass in (164) give the additional bound

$$\int |k_\theta(x - y)| d\tau_\theta(x) \leq C_p \frac{\Lambda M}{ab} L^{-p} \quad (y \notin P^+).$$

Integrating the pointwise estimate for f_θ , and using Tonelli's theorem, now proves

$$\int |f_\theta|^2 d\tau_\theta \leq C \frac{\Lambda H M}{b^2} \int_{P^+} |f_\theta|^2 dy + C_p \frac{\Lambda M}{ab} L^{-p} \|f_\theta\|_2^2. \quad (167)$$

Finally sum (163) with weights w_Q , and apply (167) to each label. The main coefficient, after converting to the normalized parent average, is

$$CL^2 \Lambda H M \frac{|P^+|}{b^2} \leq CL^{2+4j+4+4j+8} H M = CL^{8j+14} H M.$$

The local-orthogonality remainder is bounded by $C_p \Lambda M a^{-2} L^{-p} \sum_\theta \|f_\theta\|_2^2$. The weighted-kernel remainder has the same bound with an additional L^2 , since $(ab)^{-1} \leq a^{-2}$. Choosing the arbitrary decay order p larger than $m + 4j + 6$, and absorbing (158), gives the stated remainder. This proves the proposition. $\square$

Verification of the hypotheses in the unforced transfer

Fix a spatial parent $P = Q_{j+1}$ and one parent angular label in Section 3.5. Apply Proposition 16.1 with

$$a = a_j = r_j/R, \quad b = a_{j+1} = r_{j+1}/R, \quad L = R^h, \quad \sigma = \sigma_i, \quad H = H_{i,j}.$$

The spatial dilations and the test dilation then coincide exactly with those specified there, with $K = K_0$. In particular the proposition does not require replacing the current tests by tests on additional parents or by a new measure.

Take

$$f_\theta = F_{P,\theta}, \quad \varepsilon_{Q,\theta} = \mathbf{1}_{\{\theta \text{ is good for } Q\}}.$$

The inherited identity (30) says that each child's function is exactly the selected sum in the proposition. For this fixed parent the functions $F_{P,\theta}$ do not depend on the child. The selections are constants on the averaging cubes, even though different cubes may choose completely different cap subsets.

The actual Fourier direction u_θ is the direction of the auxiliary angular interval, and v_θ is its effective marking direction. Their difference is $O(\bar{\delta}_j)$, with $\bar{\delta}_j \leq a_j/a_{j+1}$ by (26). This supplies the angular mismatch hypothesis. The marking rule supplies (G): multiplying its conditional probability bound by $\sigma_i(P^+)$ gives precisely the unnormalized inequality there. Thus the stronger-looking bound (161) for arbitrary dual rectangles has been derived from the existing marks, rather than silently assumed.

The circular support of each auxiliary cap has tangential frequency width $O_T(R/r_j) = O_T(a^{-1})$ and normal width $O_T(R/r_j^2) \leq O_T(R/r_{j+1}) = O_T(b^{-1})$. The fixed frequency convolution adds bounded width, absorbed because $b \leq 1$. The supports lie in bounded-overlap balls of radius $O_T(a^{-1})$. When labels are pairs (S, I) , only boundedly many standard labels S are nonzero at a direction, and the dyadic intervals have bounded overlap. Their enclosing balls have uniformly bounded overlap as well: consecutive angular centers at a given level are separated by a fixed

multiple of δ_j , up to this bounded multiplicity. The constants C_0, B_0 may depend on the fixed annular ratio, hence on T , but not on R . The terminal widths are at least a constant times R^{-1} , so the fixed frequency smoothing causes no growing ball multiplicity.

All functions in this application belong to L^2 . For example, a bounded-density finite circular measure convolved with the fixed compact smooth frequency function has a smooth compactly supported Fourier representative. This observation applies also to the hard angular indicator pieces; no differentiation of those indicators is needed anywhere in Proposition 16.1.

Consequently (157), followed by summation over parents and parent angular labels, proves (31), with a loss $R^{C_{\kappa_0} h}$ and the single factor $H_{i,j}$. The remainder is rapidly decreasing in the required sense. Indeed $a_j \geq R^{-1}$, and for any target decay power A , the remainder in the proposition contains

$$a_j^{-2} L^{-m} \leq R^{2-hm}.$$

For fixed $h > 0$, choose m sufficiently large to absorb A and the polynomial bounds on the remaining sums and global norms. Constants depending on this choice are independent of the frequency.

Remark 16.2 (Scope and necessary distinctions). The proposition permits arbitrary finite positive pin measures, even atomic ones, and arbitrary child-dependent subsets of the fixed cap family. It would not justify allowing the selection to vary pointwise inside a child average, substituting unrelated numbers for the masses $\sigma(Q^+)$, or replacing the common parent functions by child-dependent functions. The present transfer makes none of those changes. This appendix verifies the one-step analytic implication; it does not establish optimality of the profile bound or of the resulting dimension condition.

References

- [1] T. Orponen. On the dimension and smoothness of radial projections. *Analysis & PDE* 12 (2019), 1273–1294. [arXiv:1710.11053](#).
- [2] T. Keleti and P. Shmerkin. New bounds on the dimensions of planar distance sets. *Geometric and Functional Analysis* 29 (2019), 1886–1948. [arXiv:1801.08745](#). Lemma 3.4, Corollary 3.5, Theorem 3.11.
- [3] L. Guth, A. Iosevich, Y. Ou and H. Wang. On Falconer’s distance set problem in the plane. *Inventiones Mathematicae* 219 (2020), 779–830. [arXiv:1808.09346v1](#). Section 3, especially radial projection and packet localization.
- [4] X. Du, Y. Ou, K. Ren and R. Zhang. Weighted refined decoupling estimates and application to Falconer distance set problem. [arXiv:2309.04501v1](#) (2023), Theorem 1.1(b).
- [5] B. Liu. An L^2 -identity and pinned distance problem. *Geometric and Functional Analysis* 29 (2019), 283–294. [arXiv:1802.00350](#), Theorem 1.9.
- [6] B. Liu. Lebesgue measure of distance sets with regular pins and multi-scale Mizohata–Takeuchi-type estimates. Version 3, 16 July 2026. [arXiv:2603.15328v3](#). Lemmas 3.1, 4.2–4.4.